

ADDITUDE

Strategies for Motivation, Emotional Regulation, Working Memory, Prioritization, & More



ADDITUDE | Expert eBook

A trusted source of advice and information for families touched by attention-deficit disorder—
and a voice of inspiration to help people with ADHD find success at home, at school, and on the job.

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The Adult's Guide to Stronger Executive Functions

Strategies for Motivation,
Emotional Regulation, Working Memory,
Prioritization, & More

CONTENTS

Introduction	5
Chapter 1: The ADHD-Executive Function Link.....	9
Chapter 2: Emotional Self-Regulation: Strategies for Managing Big Feelings ...	30
Chapter 3: Motivation: Overcoming Procrastination & Getting Things Done	86
Chapter 4: Prioritization & Planning: Tackling Indecision, Time Blindness, & To-Do Lists.....	132
Chapter 5: Verbal & Non-Verbal Working Memory: Curbing ADHD Forgetfulness	159
Chapter 6: Inhibition & Self-Restraint: Managing Impulsivity & Distractions ..	184
Chapter 7: Self-Awareness: Recognizing—and Embracing—Our ADHD Differences	216

Introduction

The 7 Executive Function Deficits Tied to ADHD

The cognitive skills that help us plan, prioritize, and execute complex tasks are commonly tied to ADHD in children and adults. In this eBook you will learn how executive dysfunction originates in the ADHD brain and what these deficits typically look like.

By Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D.

Executive function is the cognitive process that organizes thoughts and activities, prioritizes tasks, manages time efficiently, and makes decisions. Executive function skills help us establish structures and strategies for managing projects and determine the actions required to move each project forward.

Individuals with executive dysfunction often struggle to analyze, plan, organize, schedule, and complete tasks on deadline—or at all. They misplace materials, prioritize the wrong things, and get overwhelmed by big projects.

Is Executive Dysfunction a Symptom of ADHD?

There's a lot of confusion around “executive function”—and how it relates to ADHD. Is ADHD an executive function disorder? Is every executive function disorder also ADHD? The answers hinge on what we mean by “executive function”—and how they relate to self-regulation.

The term “executive functioning” was coined in the 1970s by Karl Pribram, whose research indicated that executive functions are mediated primarily by the prefrontal cortex. Traditionally, it's been used extensively in neuropsychology, clinical psychology, and psychiatry. In recent years, however, it's spread into the broader field of general psychology and into education, where it's often incorporated into teaching strategies and classroom accommodations.

So far, we know about four circuits in the prefrontal cortex of the brain that relate to executive function—and executive dysfunction.

INTRODUCTION

Executive Function and the ADHD Brain

- **The “What” Circuit:** Goes from the frontal lobe—especially the outer surface—back into an area of the brain called the basal ganglia, particularly a structure called the striatum. The “What” Circuit is linked to working memory, so it’s in this circuit that what we think starts to guide what we do. This is particularly true when it comes to plans, goals, and the future.
- **The “When” Circuit:** This second circuit goes from the same prefrontal area back into a very ancient part of the brain called the cerebellum, at the very backmost part of your head. The “When” Circuit is the timing circuit of the brain—it coordinates not just how smooth behavior will be and the sequence of behavior, but also the timeliness of your actions and when you do certain things. An improperly functioning “When” Circuit in a person with ADHD explains why we often have problems with time management.
- **The “Why” Circuit:** The third circuit also originates from the frontal lobe, going through the central part of the brain (known as the anterior cingulate) to the amygdala—the gateway to the limbic system. It’s often referred to as the “hot” circuit because it’s linked to our emotions: it’s where what we think controls how we feel, and vice versa. It’s the final decision-maker in all our plans. When thinking about multiple things we could be doing, this circuit eventually chooses among the options based on how we feel about them and their emotional and motivational properties.
- **The “Who” Circuit:** This final circuit goes from the frontal lobe to the very back of the hemisphere. It’s where self-awareness takes place—it’s where we’re aware of what we do, how we feel (both internally and externally), and what’s happening to us.

By viewing ADHD in relation to these four circuits, you can understand where symptoms originate. Depending upon which circuits are most impaired and least impaired, you can see variations in the kinds of symptoms that any individual will have. Some people have more working memory deficit. Some people have more emotion regulation problems. Some people have more difficulties with timing, but less difficulties with all the others. But they all involve these circuits.

What Are the Core Executive Function Skills?

So, we know what parts of the brain control executive functions, but what are they specifically? Broadly speaking, executive function refers to the cognitive or mental abilities people need to

INTRODUCTION

actively pursue goals. In other words, it's about how we behave toward our future goals and what mental abilities we need to accomplish them.

The term is very closely related to self-regulation—executive functions are things you do to yourself, to change your behavior. By employing your executive functions effectively, you're hoping to change your future for the better.

Executive function is judged by the strength of these seven skills:

- 1. Emotional Self-Regulation:** The ability to take self-awareness, inhibition, verbal and non-verbal working memory and use them to manipulate your emotional state. This means learning to use words, images, and self-awareness to process and alter how you feel about things.
- 2. Self-Awareness or Metacognition:** Simply put, this is self-directed attention.
- 3. Inhibition:** Also known as self-restraint.
- 4. Verbal Working Memory:** Self-speech, or internal speech, and the ability to hold language and words in your mind. Most people think of this as their “inner monologue.”
- 5. Non-Verbal Working Memory:** The ability to hold things in your mind. Essentially, visual imagery—how well you can picture things mentally.
- 6. Planning and Problem-Solving:** Experts sometimes like to think of this as “self-play”—how you play with information in your mind to come up with new ways of doing something. By taking things apart and recombining them in different ways, you're planning solutions to your problems.
- 7. Self-Motivation:** How well you can motivate yourself to complete a task when there is no immediate external consequence.

Does this list sound familiar? It should. Anyone who exhibits the classic symptoms of ADHD will have difficulty with all or most of these seven executive functions. Problems with inhibition in someone with ADHD lead to impulsive actions, for example. Problems with emotional regulation leads to inappropriate outbursts.

Essentially, ADHD is an executive function deficit disorder (EFDD). The umbrella term “ADHD” is simply another way of referring to these issues.

INTRODUCTION

These seven executive functions develop over time, in generally chronological order. Self-awareness starts to develop around age 2, and by age 30, planning and problem-solving should be fully developed in a neurotypical person. Those with ADHD are generally about 30% to 40% behind their peers in transitioning from one executive function to the next. Therefore, it makes sense for children and adults with ADHD to have trouble dealing with age-appropriate situations—they're thinking and acting in ways that are like much younger people.

Awareness of these executive functions is the first step. Then, with proper accommodations and treatment, people with ADHD can learn to use what they know and strengthen these executive functions over time. This eBook is designed to power both of those steps: building awareness and accumulating strategies to overcome challenges with each of the seven executive functions outlined above.

Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D., is a clinical scientist, educator, and practitioner who has published numerous books, including Taking Care of Adult ADHD, scientific articles, rating scales, and clinical manuals about ADHD. At the time of this work, he was a clinical professor of psychiatry at the Virginia Commonwealth University School of Medicine in Richmond, Virginia. He is now retired.

CHAPTER 1:

The ADHD-Executive Function Link

Chapter 1: The ADHD-Executive Function Link

Is ADHD an Executive Function Disorder?

By Thomas E. Brown, Ph.D.

As an ADHD researcher, former clinical professor of psychiatry at the Yale University School of Medicine, author, and psychologist helping patients manage their symptoms and reclaim their lives, I have seen ADHD from all sides.

My research into the brain has posited a new model for ADHD. The old model thinks of ADHD as a behavioral disorder. Many adults and children living with ADHD have never had significant behavior problems; they have difficulty focusing their attention on necessary tasks and using working memory effectively, making ADHD a cognitive disorder, a developmental impairment of executive functions (EFs)—the self-management system of the brain.

My theory of executive function impairment, or executive function disorder (EFD), has been slow to filter down to family doctors who are making diagnoses and prescribing medication. Too many doctors think about ADHD in the old way—as a behavior problem accompanied by difficulty in paying attention. They don't understand that “executive function” is really a broad umbrella. When patients hear the symptoms associated with EFD—finding it hard to get organized or start tasks, to sustain the effort to finish tasks, to hold off instead of jumping impulsively into things, to remember what was just read or heard, or to manage emotions—they'll say, “Yeah, yeah, yeah, that's me.” A lot of executive function impairment goes beyond the *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (DSM-5)* criteria for ADHD.

We need to better understand the individual variants of ADHD in adults. Some adults experience problems in school, but once they graduate, they can specialize in something they're good at or take a job where an assistant helps them manage the day-to-day minutia, and they do fine. Other adults manage through school but don't do well at jobs or household management. We're beginning to identify the domains of impairment and

recognize that executive function difficulties not only affect people with academic tasks but also their ability to maintain social relationships and manage emotions.

After serving on the clinical faculty of Yale Medical School for 25 years, Thomas E. Brown, Ph.D., relocated to Manhattan Beach, California, to open the Brown Clinic for Attention and Related Disorders. He is also an adjunct clinical associate professor of psychiatry and behavioral sciences at the Keck School of Medicine of the University of Southern California and the author of Smart but Stuck: Emotions in Teens and Adults with ADHD and Outside the Box: Rethinking ADD/ADHD in Children and Adults: A Practical Guide.

What Is Intention Deficit Disorder?

By Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D.

Intention deficit disorder is not a real diagnosis but a term I used to describe what I believe is a central struggle of ADHD: difficulty in accomplishing one's goals.

Think of ADHD as a performance disorder. People with ADHD know what they need to do, but they struggle—greatly, at times—to transform intention into action, whether that's preparing for a test or finalizing an important project at work. It's an issue directly tied to the executive function difficulties inherent in ADHD. And yet, this very real challenge of ADHD is often mistaken for laziness and lack of motivation, which may breed low self-esteem and even depression.

Unpacking Intention Deficit Disorder: The ADHD Struggle to Perform

1. Executive Dysfunction Affects Behavior and Performance

The self-regulation problems inherent in ADHD stem from executive function deficits or the mental skills that allow us to initiate and carry out actions toward a future goal.

The executive system lives in the brain's frontal lobe and is responsible for putting into action the knowledge that lives in the back of the brain. But ADHD separates these two parts of the brain like a meat cleaver.

In ADHD brains, intention and action are disconnected. This is why people with ADHD seem unlikely, unable, or unwilling to carry out behaviors that they know may be good for them. It is also why they are often unable to act effectively on what they know.

2. Executive Dysfunction Muddles Time

Executive dysfunction also creates issues with time, timing, and timeliness of behavior. People with ADHD are often "time blind," and they struggle to organize large, hierarchically sequenced behavior across time.

3. Intention Deficit Turns Everything Into a Crisis

As people with ADHD are nearsighted to time, they will often wait until the future is imminent to take action. That means that as long as they perceive the future as "out there," an I-don't-have-to-deal-with-it-yet outlook will prevail. Hence the almost universal experience of procrastination.

This far-away feeling of future events often means that people with ADHD are only able to take action at the 11th hour when time is all but running out. In a race to make

a deadline, they may put things together in a slapdash manner. Or they may deliver high-quality work—at the cost of burnout and exhaustion.

The inability to organize and prioritize until the delayed future means that everything inevitably becomes a crisis with a too-near deadline.

4. Intention Deficit Looks Like Laziness

Future-directed behavior is intentional behavior. When there's a sizable gap between intention and action, the term “intention deficit disorder” feels more accurate than “attention deficit hyperactivity disorder,” I think.

However, those without ADHD often have very little patience for the short-sighted decisions of individuals with ADHD. They view these outcomes as avoidable and attribute them to laziness, carelessness, poor time management, lack of motivation, and moral failure instead of what it really is: executive dysfunction.

Intention Deficit Disorder: Turning Intention Into Action

Many people mistakenly believe that skill-building—in the form of time-management tips, self-motivation skills, etc.—will help people with ADHD bridge the gap between intention and action.

But in the neuropsychology field, we know that the best way to treat an executive disorder is by targeting the point of performance, or the place and time across various settings of a person's life where they fail to act on what they know. Targeting the point of performance largely involves changing environments to facilitate performance. The following are key point-of-performance enhancements that work for people with ADHD:

1. Externalize Time

Executive dysfunction renders internal cues unreliable, hence “time blindness” among people with ADHD. External representations of time—like calendars, whiteboards, visual timers (like the Time Timer), and other tools—may help guide behavior more reliably and effectively.

2. Bring the Future to the Present

If people with ADHD wait until the future is imminent to act, then pushing the future back a few notches can help spur action. Dividing long-term goals into smaller, contiguous steps is one way to ensure constant action on an overall goal.

3. Ensure Motivation Along the Way

Along with breaking up tasks into manageable chunks, people with ADHD will benefit from what I call ‘motivational prostheses’ to sustain action toward a goal. The following are a few ideas:

- Short breaks in between longer bursts of work
- Body doubles, or accountability partners
- Visualizing rewards and positive outcomes

Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D., is a clinical scientist, educator, and practitioner who has published numerous books, including Taking Care of Adult ADHD, scientific articles, rating scales, and clinical manuals about ADHD. At the time of this work, he was a clinical professor of psychiatry at the Virginia Commonwealth University School of Medicine in Richmond, Virginia. He is now retired.

You Can't Train Away ADHD Executive Dysfunction

By Ari Tuckman, Psy.D.

You promised you'd be there on time. You even set a departure time reminder. But when the alarm sounds, you tell yourself, "I just need two more minutes on this." Time somehow slips by, and you're not sure how, but you end up an hour late.

The sink overflows with dishes. You know you need to wash them, but the thought overwhelms you. Another day goes by, and the dishes pile higher.

You remember you have a bill to pay. You tried signing into your account but forgot your password. While you wait for the password reset email, you get sidetracked. Before you know it, you have forgotten about that initial bill.

This is ADHD—or, more accurately, executive dysfunction—in action. The brain processes humming in the background (i.e., executive functions) that are supposed to help you organize, plan, and execute simply aren't reliable. As a result, following through is a core issue for you, even when you know what you're supposed to do.

The biggest trap many of us fall into is believing we can "build" executive function or "train away" deficits. This is not the most effective way to help people with ADHD reliably and consistently do what they need to do. Here, learn why—and what to do instead.

The Hard Truth About ADHD Executive Dysfunction

ADHD might as well be called Executive Function Deficit Disorder. It is fundamentally a disorder that impacts how we use the brain processes that help us perform day-to-day functions and work toward short- and long-term goals.

It's not that individuals with ADHD necessarily have fewer or less effective executive functions. The problem is that executive functioning is applied inconsistently. We see this when we hyperfocus on tasks we find interesting yet find it downright painful to focus on things we find boring.

ADHD is a deficit in reliably converting intentions into actions. Your batting average for doing the right thing at the right time is slightly lower than most people without ADHD. The question is, how can you improve your stats?

Building a library of executive function skills is not the answer. That's because you already know how to use a planner to keep organized. You know that reminders are helpful for forgetfulness and time management. You know you should keep a to-do list. You know that you need to eliminate distractions to focus. The problem is with putting these skills into action.

Success comes from creating systems and backstops to support existing executive functions and relieve their strain. It's about setting yourself up—with honesty, self-awareness, and intention—so that you can more easily rely on your abilities to make the better choice.

Strategies to Support Executive Functioning and Achieve Consistency

Externalize, Delegate, and Automate

Take the load off your executive functions by outsourcing the work to reliable tools.

- **Externalize to-dos with intention.** Whether it's sticky notes on the bathroom mirror, planners, whiteboards, voice notes, texts to self, smart speakers, location-based reminders, or recurring alarms on your phone, find a way to dump it all out of your head so you don't have to manage information internally.
- **Set up automatic payments** and purchases as necessary.
- **Use AirTags or other trackers** on your belongings. (Keep losing your keys? Consider installing a keypad or an electronic lock.)
- **Use password managers** to save account logins.

Your Environment Matters

Seek environments that allow you to perform at your best. Ask yourself: Where do I seriously do my best work? What keeps me on track?

Be detailed and honest in your answers, and don't assume conventional approaches work best. Perhaps your productivity spikes when you work out of a bustling coffee shop. Or maybe you need the total silence of a corner in your office building or local library. Or you may be unusually productive while taking public transportation. Perhaps you need variety because staying in one spot for too long becomes boring.

A note on clutter: A disorganized environment won't do you any favors, but it's not worth worrying about aesthetics if you can still function and get things done in a full space.

Match Tasks to Brainpower

Our energy levels and ability to focus change throughout the day, so plan your most cognitively demanding tasks for when you have the most brain power. That may mean

after a workout, in the morning before other tasks pile up, or in the evening once the day's responsibilities are behind you. Plan to tackle demanding tasks when your ADHD medication is most effective, not when it's wearing off.

Cut Down on “Noise” and Friction

Temptations and distractions compete for our attention 24/7. Our executive functions help keep us on track, but why make that harder than necessary?

- **Take willpower out of the equation.** Why spend lots of energy resisting your phone when it's much easier to silence notifications, install an Internet blocker, or keep the phone in another room?
- **Think signal-to-noise ratio.** Our attention is directed to what is big, loud, and obvious. Consider this as you boost the signal of desired tasks—where you want your attention to go—and reduce the noise of distractions.
- **Would you bet \$1,000 on it?** Too often, we're overly optimistic about our ability to handle distractions and muster the discipline to get things done. Cut through the false optimism by increasing what's at stake: Would you bet money that you can stay focused with your phone around? That you can leave on time without setting (and honoring) reminders? What would it take for you to confidently make that bet?

Speed Up Consequences

We're more likely to put off doing things we need to do when the payoffs and consequences are vague, potentially avoidable, or too far off. This is why we work on large and important home or work projects at the last minute when the consequences for failing are front and center.

- **Make potential regret come faster by creating artificial consequences** that are immediate, certain, and specific enough to spur you into action. Take the initiative to schedule weekly check-ins with your boss to review progress on a large project. Tell a friend about what you intend to do and when to externalize accountability.
- **Create artificial circumstances.** Set up a rule at home, for example, that phones can only be used after serving dinner and washing and putting away the dishes.

Reduce Stress and Chaos

Chaos begets chaos. More things are likely to fall through the cracks with a disorganized, chaotic life. Trying to juggle it all and scrape by further burdens your executive functions. Reduce the chaos in your life by finding order wherever you can—with routines and healthy habits—to take the pressure off sensitive brain functions that are better used on cognitively demanding tasks. Intentionally incorporate breathing room into your daily schedule, especially during tricky transitions.

We can all agree that exercise, sleep, healthy eating, and mindfulness benefit cognitive and emotional processes, so don't neglect these areas. Medication helps people with ADHD do what they know, so take medication as indicated.

Maintain Motivation by Enjoying the Journey

The central question that will follow you throughout your life as you manage ADHD is, "How will I do the things I know I want to do?" The answer lies in continuing to set up good processes that will help you experience more desired outcomes than negative ones. The more success and productivity you experience in managing ADHD's impact on your life, the healthier your self-esteem will be.

- **Make processes enjoyable.** The benefits of making better choices (e.g., dedicating time to keep your spaces organized, filing important documents, going to sleep on time, and attending to other responsibilities) often arrive far too gradually to fuel motivation. You can find ways to make these processes and routines fun and easy. Reward yourself along the way for putting one foot in front of the other.
- **Don't do it for anyone else.** The processes you create are for your benefit only, not for anyone else's seal of approval. The more you remember this, the easier it will be to seek changes that improve your life, without looking to the opinions of others as motivators.
- **Always credit yourself for taking positive actions.** Given how much criticism and correction people with ADHD receive, take pride whenever you make choices that set you up for success (or get you closer to it). Never sell yourself short, and don't worry about achieving perfection.
- **Setbacks are inevitable.** Don't beat yourself up or catastrophize when they happen. Handle them resiliently by refusing to surrender.

Ari Tuckman, Psy.D., is a psychologist specializing in diagnosing and treating ADHD, and the author of More Attention, Less Deficit: Success Strategies for Adults with ADHD and Understand Your Brain, Get More Done: The ADHD Executive Functions Workbook. The content for this article was derived, in part, from his ADDitude webinar, "Executive Function Strategies to Externalize Time, Memory, Motivation."

Self-Test: Do You Experience Executive Dysfunction?

Executive function deficit is not synonymous with ADHD, but its symptoms overlap in significant ways. Take this self-test and share the results with a specialist to determine if you're experiencing executive dysfunction.

Executive dysfunction does not mean having attention problems in the present tense but rather having a sustained attention problem. An adult with weak executive functions may have difficulty analyzing, planning, organizing, scheduling, and completing tasks. They may also lack the ability to regulate their emotions or recall information from conversations or books.

If this sounds familiar, take this self-test to determine whether you show signs of executive dysfunction. If you have concerns about executive dysfunction, see a health professional for a thorough evaluation. This self-test is for personal use only.

1. Do you have trouble starting or initiating tasks?
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

2. Do you start tasks with enthusiasm but lose interest quickly?
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

CHAPTER 1: THE ADHD-EXECUTIVE FUNCTION LINK

3. Do you find it hard to do things that aren't necessary or highly stimulating?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

4. Are you easily distracted by the things you see or hear?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

5. Do you become absorbed in things or tasks that interest you—sometimes to the point of forgetting about people around you or other obligations?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

6. Do you have trouble following conversations because you are distracted or are trying to remember what you wanted to say?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

CHAPTER 1: THE ADHD-EXECUTIVE FUNCTION LINK

7. Do you forget things, even when they are important to you?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
8. Do you lose or misplace items (e.g., keys, wallet, purse, or phone) at least once daily?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
9. Do you struggle to manage clutter? Does your personal space get messy with piles of papers and miscellaneous items?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
10. Do you have difficulty determining what is most important or what you should start with, given a list of things to do?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

CHAPTER 1: THE ADHD-EXECUTIVE FUNCTION LINK

11. Do you waste time trying to decide what to do first?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

12. Do you become frustrated when things don't go as planned and quickly become angry?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

13. Do you let go of anger as quickly as it comes?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

14. Do you struggle to complete multiple-step tasks and move from one task to another?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

CHAPTER 1: THE ADHD-EXECUTIVE FUNCTION LINK

15. Do you say, “I will do it later,” and then forget about it?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

16. Do you forget appointments and typically run late?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

Results: Assign the following values to your answers: Very Often (4 points), Often (3 points), Sometimes (2 points), Rarely (1 point), and Never (0 points). The higher your point total, the greater the likelihood of showing signs of executive dysfunction. (Maximum score: 64 points)

Note: *This screener is designed to determine whether you demonstrate symptoms of executive dysfunction. A high score does not necessarily mean you have executive dysfunction. A score of 50-64, means you answered “Often” or “Very Often” to most of the questions and should see a trained healthcare professional as there is a possibility that you are experiencing symptoms of executive dysfunction. An accurate diagnosis can only be made through a clinical evaluation.*

“8 Illuminating Insights Into ADHD: Making Sense of Your Brain”

By Jeff Copper, PCAC, PCC

My goal as an ADHD coach is to help people with ADHD view their condition differently. When they finally get to me, I know they’ve not yet experienced this “aha” moment because their stories are almost all the same: They’ve tried it all—to no avail—and they’re drowning in strategies for managing their life with ADHD.

This is when I can help them reach a crucial epiphany: They’ve been looking at the roots of their ADHD challenges—from procrastination and motivation to prioritization and productivity—all wrong.

Here are the most important ADHD insights I’ve collected and shared with my clients over the years to help them separate their symptoms from themselves and reach their goals.

1. The ADHD Brain Likes to Seek Escape

Whenever we think, we engage our executive functions. For people with ADHD, thinking is effortful and difficult because these underlying executive functions are impaired. That’s why the ADHD brain’s reaction is to seek escape when thinking becomes too taxing, even if it’s directed toward a desired goal.

I spend a lot of time helping my clients acknowledge that this tendency is at the root of most ADHD-related challenges. Managing ADHD is more about making thinking easier, which reduces escapism and facilitates goal-directed behavior.

2. The ADHD Brain Is Emotional and Reflexive

Just as thinking is effortful and difficult due to executive dysfunction, so is self-regulation. Poor self-regulation makes it challenging to control emotions and inhibit impulses, especially when it is based on feelings. Emotional dysregulation also makes enduring temporary discomfort for a desired goal difficult. The ADHD brain wants to feel good now, not later.

3. Ambiguity Fuels Procrastination

The ADHD brain wants to procrastinate when there’s something unpleasant about a task. That unpleasantness, I’ve found, is often rooted in ambiguity.

You might be totally unclear about the task in front of you. Or you might understand the end goal but have trouble wrapping your head around the steps needed to reach it. Either way, avoidance makes all the sense in the world when the unpleasantness of uncertainty is present.

No matter where your procrastination blooms, it helps to admit that you find the task hard, even if it is simple by other people's standards. To the ADHD brain, which struggles with effortful thinking and goal-directed behavior, it's not so simple at all. Admitting that a task is difficult increases self-awareness and allows you to think of solutions. Is the task difficult because it is unclear? Do you lack the skills or tools to carry it out?

4. There Is No Such Thing as Being Unmotivated

Like countless adults with ADHD, you might be quick to say that you're lazy or unmotivated if you don't follow through on a task. That couldn't be farther from the truth. I'll never forget a long conversation I had with Roberto Olivardia, Ph.D., who said that everything we'll ever do in life, even if we engage in avoidance, is rooted in motivation.

Some clients, filled with shame, will say things to me like, "I'm unmotivated. I just sit on the couch all day and watch Netflix." I reframe it for them. I say, "You are motivated—to watch Netflix." I also explain the link between clarity and motivation. When we lack clarity on what to do, the motivation to engage in that task diminishes.

Here's another way to think about it: Your dopamine-starved brain, unable to find pleasure in an unpleasant task (even boredom is physically uncomfortable), is greatly motivated to avoid pain and seek pleasure elsewhere.

Acknowledge that there's no such thing as being unmotivated. It will help you avoid shaming yourself. As Laura MacNiven, a fellow ADHD coach, said, "You can't treat ADHD from a lens of shame or blame."

5. Popular Productivity Tools May Stifle ADHD Brains

The tools and systems that work conveniently and consistently for others may be unhelpful for you. Worse, you might not even realize you've fallen victim to illusions of convenience.

I recently worked with a client whose work productivity issues, unbeknownst to him, were in large part due to the company's practice of communicating complex information and reports via email. Each time he received an email, he'd have to re-engage his mind on the topic, consider the new information he received, and develop a response—an effortful process that taxed his working memory. Email is convenient for others, so he never questioned whether the tool worked for him. Once he questioned it, he realized he was better off talking—not emailing—with colleagues about dense, complex projects.

Think carefully about the systems and procedures you use in your day-to-day life. Are you sticking to unproductive methods because they seem to work for everyone else? Let go of what isn't serving you. Consider the systems and tools to which you gravitate.

6. ‘Task Darwinism’ Is Why Prioritization Plans Fail

How many times have you organized your to-do list items by order of importance, only to focus on the low-priority items before the more urgent ones (and beat yourself up for it)? I call this “task Darwinism”—the natural selection process that tasks undergo and a common ADHD phenomenon.

You choose to do the less important task first, not because you’re lazy, but because conditions and elements allow it. You have clarity, time, and a conducive location, all of which facilitate performance.

You avoid or skip over a task, even one you deem important, because it’s missing these elements.

Say you have an important presentation to prepare. Though you’re in a conducive location and have time and tools, you lack clarity on how and where to start. So, rather than focus on the presentation, you answer emails—a low-priority item on your list. You’re drawn to that item because you have all the right elements in place to facilitate action. Still, your inner voice reminds you that you should be preparing the presentation.

Remember the task Darwinism principle the next time you prioritize. It will save you from self-torment and allow you to think about which elements you need to act on important items.

7. The Right Kind of Stimulation Induces Sleep

It takes most people about 15 minutes to fall asleep. It often takes much longer for people with ADHD. Why? Because waiting to drift into unconsciousness is boring, even uncomfortable. Many of my clients admit that they’ll do anything not to get into bed. If they are in bed, they’ll seek to stimulate their mind and further delay sleep. They do this even knowing they’ll wake up exhausted the next day.

The trick to falling asleep is to find an activity that stimulates your reward-seeking brain, but not to the point where your mind won’t surrender to sleep. Finding the right balance of stimulation and mindlessness will take a bit of self-observation along with trial and error. If you need inspiration, consider the following strategies:

- Invest in a coloring book—a creative, soothing, relaxing activity.
- Dim the lights and do some light cleaning and organizing.
- Listen to a podcast episode and lower the volume, so your mind must strain slightly to hear it.

8. Rehearsing the Past Won’t Change the Future

Constant feelings of guilt and shame are an unfortunate part of the ADHD experience for many people, especially those who did not receive an explanation for their

challenges until later in life. While useful information exists in these experiences, fixating too much on past mistakes and painful memories prevents progress.

Some people with ADHD benefit from psychotherapy to learn how to cope with intense feelings. Mindfulness, meditation, and self-compassion are also excellent tools for regulating feelings, even with an emotional brain. Mindfulness decreases emotional reactivity, while self-compassion allows for self-forgiveness.

Jeff Copper, PCAC, PCC, is the founder of DIG Coaching and moderator of Attention Talk Radio. The content for this article was derived, in part, from his ADDitude webinar, “7 Insights Into the ADHD Brain That Transform Lives.”

“Back-to-School Shopping Pushes My Executive Functions Beyond the Brink”

By Stacey

Last weekend, I realized it was time to buy supplies for my daughters’ upcoming school year, so I did what any reasonable person with ADHD would do: I avoided back-to-school shopping by throwing myself into a different—and completely unnecessary—task.

The bad news is my kids still aren’t prepared. The good news is that I have three new bird feeders and an app for identifying birds from the American Southeast.

Back-to-School Shopping Fills Me with Dread

It’s not that I think it’s more important for me to learn about finches and sparrows than for my 9-year-old to learn about pronouns and fractions or for my 12-year-old to learn about monarchies and democracies. It’s just that back-to-school shopping fills me with dread. I have ADHD, which impairs my executive function, such as the ability to plan things, motivate myself, and focus—all skills that shopping for school supplies requires.

Planning the purchases is hard because, well, where even *are* the school supply lists? I tried Googling them once but turned up dubious websites. Another time, I searched for them on the school district’s website page but had no luck. I did, however, succumb to a targeted ad for glow-in-the-dark colored pencils.

Driving to a Big Box retailer might be easier. Some parents have said school supply lists are posted at Walmart. But I’d have to put on real pants to see for myself. All my real pants are dirty. That means I’d have to wear the ripped athletic shorts I slept in last night. And that means I’d have to shave my legs, and you know what? Forget it.

Even if I got to the store, I’d be so distracted by the neon notebooks and glittery binders that I’d stray from the school supply list. Instead, I’d return home with a planner for myself (that I will never use), a fishing license, a *Beaches* DVD (even though I no longer own a DVD player), a fourth bird feeder, guilt, and mental fatigue.

What would I not bring home from the store? Something essential, like pencils. (If only I could send the kids to school with the glow-in-the-dark colored pencils. Unfortunately, colors like “Mind-Tripping Green” aren’t school-appropriate.)

School Supply List Solution

So, this year, I’m trying something different. I accept that I’ll order everything online at the last minute—after my mom texts me the supply lists—and have it overnighted. That’s what I’ve done every year so far, and my kids have been OK.

I mean, last year, my older daughter gave a poster presentation on theoretical vacation travel to the solar system's outer planets. My younger daughter won the third-grade essay contest and built the most stable chopstick-and-marshmallow tower in her class.

Sometimes I need to remind myself that they're thriving, that I am doing enough, and that I am enough. Besides, I make up for the conventional back-to-school shopping experience by impulse-purchasing nonsense my kids want all year—from scented markers to hand-knit backpacks decorated with frogs.

Now, if you'll excuse me, I've got to photograph this bird. It's incredibly urgent that I find out if it's a chimney swift.

Stacey is an ADDitude contributor.

The following *ADDitude* experts and authors contributed to this chapter: Eileen Bailey; Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D.; Thomas E. Brown, Ph.D.; Jeff Copper, PCAC, PCC; and Stacey.

CHAPTER 2

Emotional Self- Regulation: Strategies for Managing Big Feelings

Chapter 2: Emotional Self-Regulation: Strategies for Managing Big Feelings

DESR: Why Deficient Emotional Self-Regulation Is Central to ADHD (and Largely Overlooked)

What Is DESR?

Deficient emotional self-regulation (DESR) is a relatively new term used to describe the problem of impulsive emotion coupled with emotional self-regulation difficulties—issues long associated with ADHD. “DESR may be new to the ADHD lexicon. However, I argue that it is a core and commonly overlooked component of the disorder—and one that can help predict a patient’s impairments and even improve diagnostic and treatment practices,” says Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D., a retired clinical scientist, educator, and practitioner who has written extensively about DESR. Dr. Barkley discussed DESR’s central role in ADHD during the *ADDitude* webinar titled “Deficient Emotional Self-Regulation: The Overlooked ADHD Symptom That Impacts Everything.”

Emotional dysregulation is noticeably missing from the diagnostic criteria for ADHD. However, Dr. Barkley says, most patients and experts recognize that it is central to the disorder. DESR is a manifestation of emotional dysregulation. Dr. Barkley says it specifically refers to deficiencies with these four components of emotional self-regulation:

- Ability to inhibit inappropriate behavior triggered by strong emotions. “I argue that this emotional impulsiveness (EI) is an aspect of poor inhibition associated with ADHD that is illustrated by low frustration tolerance, impatience, being quick to anger, aggression, greater emotional excitability, and other negative reactions, all of which are related to the impulsivity dimension of the disorder,” he says.
- Ability to self-soothe and down-regulate a strong emotion to reduce its severity
- Ability to refocus attention from emotionally provocative events

- Ability to organize or substitute more moderate, healthier emotional responses in the service of goals and long-term welfare

To understand the role of EI and DESR in ADHD is to acknowledge the prominent role of emotional control difficulties in the disorder's appearance and outlook, including understanding the following:

- Why are these issues prevalent in individuals with ADHD
- Why major comorbid disorders often develop because of these challenges
- The major life impairments not adequately explained by traditional symptoms of ADHD

“A wealth of compelling evidence—from ADHD’s clinical conceptualization over time to neuroanatomical and psychological research—clearly shows that EI and DESR are key components of ADHD and should be incorporated into the disorder’s diagnostic criteria and treatment practices,” Dr. Barkley says.

EI and DESR in ADHD Psychological Research

Emotional self-regulation is a major dimension of executive functioning required for daily life activities. It is also one of the most impaired dimensions in children and adults with ADHD. “Ample evidence from an abundance of psychological research shows that children and adults with ADHD are highly likely to manifest EI-DESR including low frustration tolerance, anger, poor inhibition of emotion, and emotional excitability,” Dr. Barkley says.

EI and DESR and Impairment in Major Life Activities

Centering the role of emotion in ADHD predicts a variety of impairments that are not similarly associated with the traditional symptoms of ADHD: hyperactivity, inattention, and/or impulsivity.

Dr. Barkley says that emotional dysregulation uniquely predicts the following:

- Social rejection in children with ADHD
- Interpersonal hostility and marital dissatisfaction in adults with ADHD
- Greater parenting stress and family conflict in parents of children with ADHD; greater stress in parents with ADHD
- Road rage, DUIs, and crash risks during driving

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

- Job dismissals and workplace interpersonal problems
- Dating/cohabiting relationship conflict
- Impulse buying; poor finances

EI and DESR: Diagnostic Implications

“Elevating EI-DESR’s place in ADHD would greatly assist with differential diagnosis of the disorder from mood disorders and other conditions involving emotional dysregulation,” Dr. Barkley says. In other words, it would reduce the odds of misdiagnosis for patients simply experiencing what is central to ADHD. (Individuals with ADHD are commonly misdiagnosed with mood disorders.)

“Mood disorders, however, are common in individuals with ADHD, so comorbidity must be considered,” Dr. Barkley says. He explains that duration could be a guiding diagnostic principle to distinguish a legitimate mood disorder from the emotional dysregulation associated with ADHD.

“Emotions, unlike moods, are of short duration, setting-specific, provoked, and easily traced to the source. EI-DESR is a ‘top-down’ deficit in regulating rational, emotional responses to events; its impact is typically shorter in duration than a mood disorder,” he says.

Mood disorders, Dr. Barkley says, are generally “bottom-up” excessive expressions of emotions likely attributed to underlying amygdala-limbic system activities. Moods are of long duration—lasting hours, days, or weeks. They are also cross-situational and irrational in the case of mood disorders. (It is often not clearly understood, for example, what triggers a patient with bipolar disorder to become manic, or the opposite.)

“Impulsive emotion and emotional dysregulation are core facets of ADHD,” Dr. Barkley says. “Impulsive emotion is linked to the impulsivity dimension of ADHD, and difficulty with emotional control is part of the large inattentive/executive dimension of ADHD. Historical concepts of ADHD include EI-DESR, and research in the fields of neuroanatomy, neuropsychology, and psychology also link ADHD to EI and DESR. This core relationship may help to explain, at least in part, why the disorder poses a high risk for oppositional defiant disorder (ODD) and mood disorders, as well as the unique impairments some patients experience.

“By recognizing that EI and DESR are involved in ADHD, we can significantly improve diagnostic and treatment practices.”

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

Why We Feel So Much—and Ways to Overcome It

Research shows that people with ADHD have outsized challenges with frustration, impatience, anger, and excitability. Use these strategies to regulate emotional responses to frustrations and setbacks, to stay on course, and to move forward.

Everyone experiences frustrations, setbacks, and challenges, but not everyone reacts as strongly as you do to them. Small, relatively insignificant setbacks seem to get an outsized response from those diagnosed with ADHD. Research shows that we have greater challenges with frustration, impatience, anger, and excitability than others do. That's because ADHD impairs our ability to regulate our emotions, to experience them in a controlled way so that they don't gush out into the world.

But there are ways to tone down emotional explosions and turn them into positive energy. Before we explore them, here is more science on the ADHD emotions factory.

ADHD: A Failure-to-Regulate Mood Disorder

From a neuropsychological standpoint, regulation is all about connectivity within the brain. Emotions are generated in the limbic system—which includes the amygdala, the anterior cingulate, and other parts that make up our “primitive brain”—and that system controls fear, pleasure, and anger. When an emotion is generated, the limbic system connects with the prefrontal cortex, which manages that emotion. The cortex pauses, assessing the significance of the situation, calculating the costs of reacting outwardly, and suppresses actions not in our best interest.

The frontal cortex is like a security checkpoint. But in the ADHD brain, the neurochemical connectivity needed to guard that checkpoint is weak, allowing emotions to stampede past the security gate and wreak havoc with outbursts. Not assessed. Not calculated. Not suppressed. Never in our best interest.

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

Unchecked Emotions Can Damage Relationships, Careers, Everything

- **We react to minor problems or annoyances as if they were DEFCON Level 1 threats.** We're thrown into panic mode easily; we get super-stressed about little stuff; we lose sight of the big picture, often resulting in decisions or actions we later regret.
- **We have difficulty calming down once a strong emotion takes hold.** We stew for hours or days over an emotional event. And that stewing prevents, or at least impairs, our getting back to work and moving our priorities forward.
- **We're extremely sensitive to disapproval, rejection, and criticism.** We might interpret a colleague's reaction to something we proposed as criticism, disapproval, or even an insult when none was intended. We tend to react self-defensively, or worse, angrily. Rejection sensitivity is extremely common in people with ADHD.
- **We get overly excited about things, including good things.** Just as we often overreact to minor problems and annoyances, we can also go overboard in the other direction. This may mean diving headlong into a new hobby and realizing after dishing out \$1,800 on equipment and six months of lessons, that "We should have eased into this."

Body Awareness Helps to Identify Unhealthy Feelings

This all may sound pretty bleak, but ADHD emotionality is actually a bad news/good news situation. The good news is that we can build some defenses and leverage against some of our strong emotions to shift our energy in the direction we want to go: forward.

Learning to handle our negative emotions as they occur begins with becoming fully aware of when we're in their grasp. A key to doing this is to listen to our bodies.

Research shows that body awareness helps us identify unhealthy feelings and step off the emotional merry-go-round. When we have a negative emotion, our body sends stress signals: tension in our neck and shoulders, discomfort in our solar plexus ("gut pangs"), or wherever we first feel stress in our bodies.

A second prerequisite to these interventions is to name our emotions. Naming emotions, what psychologists call labeling, goes beyond just thinking, "Yes, I'm angry" or, "Wow, am I sad." *Emotional Agility* author Susan David, Ph.D., says, "[When] experiencing a strong emotion...take a moment to consider what to call it, but don't stop there. Come up with two more words that describe how you're feeling."

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

You Can Create a Healthier “Emotional Home”

Imagine a late afternoon at work. You got little sleep the night before, had to skip lunch, and haven’t been able to get to the gym or take a walk outdoors for a couple of weeks. You have just spent the last 10 minutes staring at the tasks you must do to keep what feels like a dead-end job. This feeling would be an “unhealthy emotional home.”

Now imagine that your teenage son calls and tells you that he just totaled the SUV. Your reaction probably won’t be measured and balanced.

Let’s rebuild that emotional home: You’re getting seven to eight hours of sleep most nights; you’re feeding your ADHD brain with protein and complex carbs, and, even when the day is so crazy that you skip lunch, you have some raw nuts and protein bars handy. Even though you haven’t gone to the gym in a couple of weeks, you took a long walk around the neighborhood before bedtime; you’ve been blocking off the mornings in your calendar to build in quality work sessions and restorative breaks.

Now you get that awful call from your son. Will your emotional response be different? Maybe you would go into your problem-solving mode rather than launching into a scream-fest? Diet, sleep, exercise, mindset, and other lifestyle adjustments will help protect you from emotions.

There are many things you can do every day to reduce your emotional vulnerability. Here are four simple additions:

- **Daily gratitude ritual.** The act of writing down three things every day for which you are grateful has been shown in the research of Harvard’s Shawn Achor, author of *The Happiness Advantage* and *Big Potential*, to reduce reactivity and boost a positive outlook in the face of challenges.
- **Get a positive nag.** You’ve likely heard of vision boards or dream boards. Research shows that positive imagery reduces stress and improves mental clarity. Consider creating a simple montage of aspirational images reflecting your ideal life, and put it where you’ll see it every day, if not all day long. My computer screensaver is a rotation of such images along with empowering quotes.
- **Journaling.** There are more than 40 years of research on the link between writing and emotional processing. For instance, a study of laid-off workers found that those who explored their negative feelings in writing were three times more likely to find a new job.

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

- **Self-compassion.** When you screw up, be kind to yourself. It's like the Golden Rule with a twist: treat yourself as you would treat others. Talk to yourself like you were consoling a good friend: "Hey, Buddy, don't sweat it. Tomorrow's a new start."

Replace the Negative Emotion with a Positive One

After you've caught that tension in your body and named that emotion, you can release it. And the best way to release an emotion is to replace it—with gratitude, for instance. Gratitude vaporizes negative emotions. Personal development guru Tony Robbins notes: "When you're grateful, there's no anger. It's impossible to be angry and grateful simultaneously."

Easier said than done? Yes. But think about this: We are the only species that can think a thought and become angry... think a thought and become sad...and think a thought and be grateful.

My client, Erin, who is a life coach, has learned to listen to her body to detect an emotional storm on the horizon. "When I grab a strand of my hair and start twirling it, I know it's time for me to stop, listen to my breath, and reclaim my brain from my amygdala." She solidifies control by defaulting to gratitude and asks, "What is good about right now?" There's always something to be grateful for.

"Flip" Your Anger

What if a fit of anger could become the spark for getting busy on a tough task? With a little mental jiu-jitsu, you can flip your anger around, so that it's moving you in a positive direction.

Since anger is grounded in a feeling that something needs to change, that feeling creates energy—usually destructive energy, but energy that could be constructive.

As author Soleira Green puts it: "Anger is the tip of passion. You wouldn't get upset if you didn't care so much about something. Anger is your own body telling you, 'Here's something that matters... and here's some energy to deal with it.'" The trick to flipping angry energy is to ask a few questions:

- "What's triggering me—what's underneath this?"
- "What do I care about that's making me angry?"

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

- “What could I do to use that energy to move forward with this thing that’s making me angry?”

Answering these questions creates what Green describes as a “negative nag”: using that which ticks you off to fuel motivation and problem-solving. Next time you’re angry about something (even at yourself), observe that energy and ask that series of questions.

All emotions, particularly negative ones, have “adaptive value”—meaning they can help us cope with and respond to difficult situations. At the heart of every negative emotion is the sense that *something must change*.

Research shows that those who recognize and control their emotions earn more and achieve more than those who don’t. So, our emotionality is one more way people with ADHD have a tougher journey than our neurotypical friends. But with these strategies, we can go from destructive emotions to acceptance and problem-solving.

This article was written by Alan P. Brown, an ADHD coach and founder of ADD Crusher, a video series designed for teens and adults with ADHD.

How ADHD Ignites Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria

By William Dodson, M.D., LF-APA

What Is Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria?

Rejection sensitive dysphoria (RSD) is extreme emotional sensitivity and pain triggered by the perception that a person has been rejected or criticized by important people in their life. It may also be triggered by a sense of falling short—failing to meet their own high standards or others' expectations.

Dysphoria is the Greek word meaning unbearable; its use emphasizes the severe physical and emotional pain suffered by people with RSD when they encounter real or perceived rejection, criticism, or teasing. The emotional intensity of RSD is described by my patients as a wound. The response is well beyond all proportion to the nature of the event that triggered it.

Rejection sensitive dysphoria is not a formal diagnosis, but rather one of the most common and disruptive manifestations of emotional dysregulation—a common but under-researched and oft-misunderstood symptom of ADHD, particularly in adults. Rejection sensitive dysphoria is a brain-based symptom that is likely an innate feature of ADHD.

Early childhood trauma makes anything worse, but it does not cause RSD. Often, patients are comforted just to know there is a name for this feeling. It makes a difference knowing what it is, that they are not alone, and that almost 100% of people with ADHD experience rejection sensitivity. After hearing this diagnosis, they're relieved to know it's not their fault and that they are not damaged.

When this emotional response is internalized (and it often is for people with RSD), it can imitate a full, major mood disorder complete with suicidal ideation. The sudden change from feeling perfectly fine to feeling intensely sad that results from RSD is often misdiagnosed as rapid cycling mood disorder.

It can take a long time for physicians to recognize that these symptoms are caused by the sudden emotional changes associated with ADHD and rejection sensitivity, while all other aspects of relating to others seem typical.

When this emotional response is externalized, it looks like an impressive, instantaneous rage at the person or situation responsible for causing the pain.

RSD can make adults with ADHD anticipate rejection—even when it is anything but certain. This can make them vigilant about avoiding it, which can be misdiagnosed as

social phobia. Social phobia is an intense anticipatory fear that you will embarrass or humiliate yourself in public, or that you will be scrutinized harshly by the outside world.

Rejection sensitivity is hard to tease apart. Often, people can't find the words to describe its pain. They say it's intense, awful, terrible, overwhelming. It is always triggered by the perceived or real loss of approval, love, or respect.

One-third of my adult patients report that RSD was the most impairing aspect of their personal experience of ADHD, in part because they never found any effective ways to manage or cope with the pain.

People with ADHD cope with this huge emotional elephant in two main ways, which are not mutually exclusive.

- **They become people pleasers.** They scan every person they meet to figure out what that person admires and praises. Then they present that false self to others. Often this becomes such a dominating goal that they forget what they actually wanted from their own lives. They are too busy making sure other people aren't displeased with them.
- **They stop trying.** If there is the slightest possibility that a person might try something new and fail or fall short in front of anyone else, it becomes too painful or too risky to make the effort. These bright, capable people avoid any anxiety-provoking activities and end up giving up things like dating, applying for jobs, or speaking up in public (both socially and professionally).
- **Some people use the pain of RSD to find adaptations and overachieve.** They constantly work to be the best at what they do and strive for idealized perfection. Sometimes they are driven to be above reproach. They lead admirable lives, but at what cost?

How Is RSD Different from a Mood Disorder?

RSD is characterized by intense but short-lived emotional pain triggered by a distinct event of real or perceived rejection, criticism, or teasing. Mood disorders, on the other hand, are characterized by the following:

MOOD DISORDER	RSD AND ADHD
Mood changes are untriggered; out of the blue	Mood changes always have a clear trigger
Moods are independent of what's going on in the person's life	Moods match the perception of the triggers
Mood shift is gradual over weeks	Mood shift is instantaneous
Offset of mood episodes is gradual over a period of weeks to months	Episodes end quickly in a matter of hours
Duration of episode must be > two weeks	Episodes rarely last more than a couple of hours

In other words, the moods of ADHD and RSD are normal in every way except their intensity.

Is Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria a Symptom of ADHD?

Rejection sensitive dysphoria is not included in the *DSM-5* for ADHD; it is not a formal symptom of ADHD in the United States, however emotional dysregulation is one of the six fundamental features used to diagnose ADHD in the European Union.

It's widely understood that the diagnostic criteria for ADHD in the *DSM-5* only fit well with elementary school-age children (6-12) and have never been validated in a group of people over the age of 16. They are based on only observational or behavioral criteria that can be seen and counted. The traditional diagnostic criteria intentionally avoid symptoms associated with emotion, thinking styles, relationships, sleeping, etc., because these features are hard to quantify. For clinicians who work with later adolescents and adults, the *DSM-5* criteria are almost useless because they ignore so much of which is vital to understanding how people with an ADHD nervous system experience their lives.

When people started researching and writing about the concepts of RSD and emotional dysregulation years ago, this new awareness of the emotional component of ADHD was enthusiastically accepted by patients and their families because they matched their life experiences so exactly. The reception from clinicians and many researchers, however, was decidedly cool. Many professionals did not fully grasp that the emotional compo-

nent of ADHD had always been there but intentionally not pursued. It appeared to them that the concept had no real and historical basis. What's more, there was very little published research and most studies came from the European Union, which used the term emotional dysregulation (ED), not RSD.

These obstacles to recognizing RSD/ED as a major and defining characteristic of adult ADHD and to using medications to offer some relief from the disruptions and pain of this feature of ADHD are being addressed. There has been a rapid increase in available research in a very short period of time. The redefinition of adult ADHD in the EU—adding emotional self-regulation as a fundamental part of the criteria for diagnosing ADHD—has further assured that RSD/ED is really “a thing” that can no longer be ignored.

Still, there are at least three reasons why emotional dysregulation or RSD may never be included in the diagnostic criteria for ADHD, no matter how prevalent:

- RSD/ED are not always present. It comes in triggered episodes.
- People with RSD/ED are usually ashamed of their over-reactions and hide them so they will not be further embarrassed and thought of as mentally or emotionally unstable.
- Even when RSD/ED is present, it can't be measured, and, therefore, can't get published in research.

As a consequence, emotional dysregulation was consciously excluded from the diagnostic criteria for ADHD and effectively forgotten for many years. Over the last decade, researchers have developed several new ways of looking at ADHD through the lifecycle. By the end of 2019, this re-evaluation of the very fundamental aspects of ADHD led the European Union to issue its 10-year update of the Consensus Guidelines on Adult ADHD, which redefined adolescent and adult ADHD to include difficulty with emotional regulation as one of only six fundamental features in the ADHD syndrome:

- Inattention and hyperfocus
- Impulsivity
- Hyperactivity
- Emotional dysregulation
- Excessive mind wandering
- Behavioral self-regulation (which they equated with executive function deficits)

Although the EU has chosen the more inclusive term of emotional dysregulation (ED) instead of RSD, the concepts are fundamentally the same. Emotional dysregulation is described as:

“The type of emotional dysregulation seen in ADHD has been characterized as deficient self-regulation of emotional symptoms such as irritability, frustration and anger and low frustration tolerance, temper outbursts, emotional impulsivity, and mood lability. Emotional dysregulation in ADHD is different from episodic symptoms such as marked sustained irritability occurring within the context of altered mood states, such as an episode of extreme sadness or mania. In ADHD, emotional symptoms tend to reflect short-lived exaggerated changes, often in response to daily events, with rapid return to baseline within a few hours.”

How Is Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria Treated?

Psychotherapy does not particularly help patients with RSD because the emotions hit suddenly and completely overwhelm the mind and senses. It takes a while for someone with RSD to get back on their feet after an episode.

There are two possible medication solutions for RSD. The simplest solution is to prescribe an alpha agonist like guanfacine or clonidine. These were originally designed as blood pressure medications.

These two medications seem to work equally well but for different groups of people. If the first medication does not work, it should be stopped, and the other one tried. They should not be used simultaneously, just one or the other.

Although the alpha agonist medications, guanfacine and clonidine, have been FDA-approved for the treatment of ADHD for decades, they were not directly associated with the terms of rejection sensitivity and emotional dysregulation. Nonetheless, it has been my clinical experience and the experience of others that the symptoms of RSD/ED can be significantly relieved with clonidine and guanfacine in about 60% of adolescents and adults. When that happens, the change is life-altering. Sometimes this treatment can make an even greater impact than a stimulant does to treat ADHD, although the stimulant can be just as effective for some people. To me, this observation strongly indicates that RSD is neurological and not due to a lack of skills. Skills do not come in pill form.

There currently exists no formal research on using alpha agonist medications to treat symptoms of RSD or ED in patients with ADHD.

The second treatment is prescribing monoamine oxidase inhibitors (MAOI) off-label. This has traditionally been the treatment of choice for RSD among experienced clinicians. It can be dramatically effective for both the attention/impulsivity component of ADHD and the emotional component. Parnate (tranylcypromine) often works best, with the fewest side effects. Common side effects are low blood pressure, agitation, sedation, and confusion.

MAOIs were found to be as effective for ADHD as methylphenidate in one head-to-head trial conducted in the 1960s. They also produce very few side effects with true once-a-day dosing, are not a controlled substance (no abuse potential), come in inexpensive, high-quality generic versions, and are FDA-approved for both mood and anxiety disorders. The disadvantage is that patients must avoid foods that are aged instead of cooked, as well as first-line ADHD stimulant medications, all antidepressant medications, OTC cold, sinus, and hay fever medications, and OTC cough remedies. Some forms of anesthesia can't be administered.

If a patient does not benefit from medication, they have little control over an episode of RSD once it begins. The incidents have to run their course. Some people with ADHD, however, report that getting interested in something new and fascinating can help to end an RSD episode more quickly than it would otherwise.

In my clinical experience, neither coaching nor traditional psychological or behavioral therapies—like CBT or DBT—offer any prevention or relief from impairments. Nonetheless, many people report that it is very helpful for them to know that this highly disruptive experience is real, common, and shared by other people with ADHD. “It helps me to know what is happening to me and that it is ultimately going to end.”

William Dodson, M.D., LF-APA, is a clinician, writer, speaker, and consultant on ADHD medicine. Dr. Dodson was one of the first practitioners to specialize in adults with ADHD.

Rejection Sensitivity Is Worse for Women with ADHD

Too many women with ADHD choose isolation to avoid the emotional pain of rejection—an unhealthy sacrifice with health repercussions. Acknowledging that rejection sensitivity is a common experience, not the reflection of character flaws, is the first step toward accepting support and pursuing treatment for RSD.

Much attention has been focused on RSD—and many women with ADHD identify with the experience.

Studies link rejection sensitivity to depression, anxiety, borderline personality disorder, body dysmorphic disorder, bipolar disorder, and autism. However, it appears to be most strongly associated with ADHD. Impaired executive functions and emotional dysregulation increase the tendency to personalize ambiguous social interactions, interpret them negatively, and be unable to regulate an emotional reaction to the interaction that prompted it.

“Rejection sensitivity is not a formal diagnosis or disorder, but many women report that the inability to control their reactions to rejection is one of the most undermining aspects of their ADHD,” says Ellen Littman, Ph.D., co-author of *Understanding Girls with ADHD*.

Dr. Littman has been involved in the field of attention disorders for more than 30 years and has seen some highly sensitive women experience perceived rejection in superficial interactions (e.g., “I had to ask our waiter for water twice—he doesn’t like me”). But, she says, the most devastating incidents involve rejection from those closest to them. “It can take hours to recover from a wounding interaction, and many women ruminate about the incident, sometimes waking in the middle of the night to relive it. Their quality of life is affected by anxiety, distress, shame, and avoidance,” Dr. Littman says.

ADHD Rejection Sensitivity and Gender

Society supports the idea of female obligation to accommodate others’ needs. Girls with ADHD feel this responsibility early but find they are poorly wired to be attuned to the feelings of others, explains Dr. Littman. “They are often bullied and ostracized by peers for being overly sensitive, easily confused, and missing social cues,” she says. “Many girls with ADHD behave in ways that others find frustrating and become targets for criticism. Their inability to conform to societal demands resonates with their learned expectation of rejection.”

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

Extreme stimulation causes the brain to adapt in extreme ways, even at the cost of compromising other functions. “Many women with ADHD have experienced chronic negative feedback in their childhoods, with countless episodes of harsh punishment, bullying, exclusion, and humiliation from family, peers, and teachers,” Dr. Littman says.

“The resilience of girls with ADHD is chipped away by early traumatic experiences that are unpredictable, inescapable, and repeated,” she continues. “These damaging messages can affect normal development and alter brain chemistry by increasing the release of adrenaline and cortisol. For many girls with ADHD, the repeated threat of rejection triggers primitive survival mechanisms; too vulnerable for fight or flight, they often freeze up, unable to act. These episodes set the stage for the expectation of future social adversity.”

Anxiety Is Amped Up in Women with ADHD

After decades of further rejection, women with ADHD feel like impostors, fearing that their perceived failures will be discovered and provoke rejection, explains Dr. Littman. Well-documented gender differences describe these women as having less confidence, lower self-esteem, and more distress than men with ADHD or women without ADHD.

“It makes sense, then, that women with ADHD are primed to expect criticism, internalizing their anxious and fearful reactions to rejection,” Dr. Littman says. “Men are more likely to externalize their responses with defensiveness, anger, and projecting blame on others. Studies show that anxious reactions increase the likelihood of anxiety about future interactions. Those with angry responses experience decreased anxiety about future interactions.

“Many women interpret these rejections as a judgment of their value and are devastated by the idea that they continually disappoint others. Studies show that anticipatory anxiety creates a self-fulfilling prophecy in which fearful reactions elicit more negativity, reinforcing the sense of rejection. Their emotional volatility may be seen as a melodramatic overreaction, further invalidating their pain. Some women believe that their behavior merits rejection, that they are, indeed, unworthy. If they feel they can do nothing right, despair can lead to substance abuse, eating disorders, self-harm, and suicidal thoughts.”

Avoiding Situations That Might Lead to Rejection

Dr. Littman says that most undiagnosed women gradually internalize decades of negative messages. With shattered self-esteem, they judge themselves harshly for their outbursts

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

of rage, panic, or tears. Ashamed of their inability to control their impulsive responses, some focus on people-pleasing, flying under the radar, and censoring their opinions.

While catering to others, they justify, defend, and apologize for their reactions. Others go further, taking on a rigid, perfectionist facade to hide their volatility. “This defense mechanism demands hypervigilant self-monitoring that comes at the cost of relentless anxiety and emotional exhaustion,” Dr. Littman says.

Ultimately, many women learn to avoid situations in which they anticipate rejection. “They conclude that withdrawal will protect them from the painful rejections that seem inescapable, and they develop social anxiety,” Dr. Littman says. “They find that hiding decreases their anxiety, and they accept distance and disconnection as a tolerable trade-off. Choosing isolation is a sacrifice no one should have to make. Women may feel protected, but it prevents them from being seen, heard, and known.”

The bottom line is that these powerful emotional reactions wreak havoc on relationships. Their intensity derails communication with partners who tire of de-escalation duty. Some women resort to radio silence with friends who judge them as overreacting. Many feel shame and despair at losing control and question their efficacy as a woman in the world.

Managing Rejection Sensitivity with ADHD

Dr. Littman explains that the tendency to experience rejection sensitivity is part nature and part nurture. In addition to the role genetics play, the physiology of rejection sensitivity is related to the neurobiology of emotional dysregulation. These reactions may respond to guanfacine, a non-stimulant medication that has demonstrated some success in decreasing symptoms, she says.

The nurture component involves the traumatic history of early rejections, as well as the current environments reinforcing the negative messages. A therapist can help women understand their triggers and recognize high-risk situations. “Therapy helps women re-evaluate their beliefs about their self-worth and reframe the importance of the appraisals of others,” Dr. Littman says. “The knowledge that rejection sensitive dysphoria is a common experience, not the reflection of character flaws, is often the first step toward accepting support and pursuing treatment.”

ADHD Rage and Anger Issues: New Insights into Emotional Dysregulation and Treatment Considerations

By Joel Nigg, Ph.D.

Anger issues stemming from emotional dysregulation—while noticeably missing from diagnostic criteria for ADHD—are a fundamental part of the ADHD experience for many children and adults. Even when controlling for related comorbid conditions, individuals with ADHD experience disproportionate problems with anger, irritability, and managing other emotions. These problems walk in lockstep with the general difficulties in self-regulation that characterize ADHD. Research, however, suggests that problems with emotional regulation, including anger and negative emotions, are genetically linked to ADHD, too.

Ultimately, emotional dysregulation is one major reason that ADHD is subjectively difficult to manage, and why it also poses such a high risk for other problems like depression, anxiety, or negative self-medication. Scientific and clinical attention is now increasingly turning to correct the past neglect of this integral aspect of ADHD.

Understanding ADHD and Emotional Dysregulation

Why is emotional dysregulation so ubiquitous with ADHD? The frequent presence of ADHD's comorbid conditions—namely anxiety, trauma, and substance abuse—is certainly one reason. But not the only one. The connection is more fundamental to ADHD as well. Here are the prevailing theories:

- **Executive dysfunction:** Implicated in ADHD, deficits in executive function skills like inhibition and working memory make regulating emotions more difficult. The same skills that help us concentrate also work to adjust emotions to the situation.
- **Confused internal signals:** Research shows that poor emotional coherence—or mixed physiological signals (heart rate, facial muscles, brain activity)—is a complication for many with ADHD. Emotional coherence is the melody played by an orchestra with many harmonized instruments; it sums up how one feels. With mixed signals, the melody becomes a cacophony and difficult to interpret—people may feel strongly but with confused emotions. For example, frustration and disappointment may feel the same, but they aren't. Frustration is a signal to move forward with more effort or a new strategy, while disappointment is a signal to move away. Thus, responses may be mismatched to the situation.
- **Hidden expectancies or biases.** Emotion has conscious and automatic influences. It involves interpreting physiological signals—at first, we do so automatically, then we

do so deliberately. Heart rates, for example, may jump at a sudden sound. But once we realize the small sound is nothing to fear, we feel fine. But if one has a hidden bias, they may interpret ambiguous signals as a threat or in some other way that makes it harder to map emotion to the situation.

Recognizing this inherent relationship between emotional dysregulation and ADHD is also important when discerning between related and similar conditions, like disruptive mood dysregulation disorder (DMDD), bipolar disorder, intermittent explosive disorder (IED), depression, anxiety, and ODD. In all, paying mind to anger issues and emotionality in patients with ADHD is crucial for successful treatment and symptom management in the long term.

Anger Issues and ADHD: Theories & Research

Though separated from ADHD in official nomenclature today, emotional dysregulation and anger were connected to ADHD in the mid-20th century before current diagnostic norms were created and have continued to form part of personal and clinical experiences. Decades ago, when ADHD was known as “minimal brain dysfunction,” criteria for diagnosis actually included aspects of negative emotionality.

Anger problems and emotional dysregulation in individuals with ADHD are sometimes explained by co-occurring mood disorders, such as anxiety or depression. However, these associated disorders do not explain the near-universal anger and emotional issues that ADHD individuals experience.

A critical aspect to consider, then, is ADHD’s nature as a disorder of self-regulation across behavior, attention, and emotion. In other words, any difficulties in regulating thoughts, emotions, and actions—as is common with ADHD—may explain the irritability, tantrums, and anger regulation issues these individuals experience. And the majority do.

About 70% of adults with ADHD report problems with emotional dysregulation, according to research published in *BMC Psychiatry*. A study in *Psychological Assessment* found that went up to 80% in children with ADHD. In clinical terms, these problem areas include:

- **Irritability:** Issues with anger dysregulation—“tantrum” episodes as well as chronic or generally negative feelings in between episodes.
- **Lability:** Frequent, reactive mood changes during the day.
- **Recognition:** The ability to accurately recognize other people’s feelings. Individuals with ADHD may not notice other people’s emotions until pointed out.
- **Affective intensity:** Felt intensity—how strongly an emotion is experienced. People with ADHD tend to feel emotions very intensely.

- **Emotional dysregulation:** Global difficulty adapting emotional intensity or state to a situation.

Genetic Basis for ADHD and Anger Issues

From a genetic standpoint, emotional dysregulation appears to be strongly associated with ADHD. Our findings suggest that genetic liability for ADHD is related directly to most traits of emotional dysregulation, like irritability, anger, tantrums, and overly exuberant sensation-seeking. What's more, irritability appears to have the biggest overlap with ADHD versus other traits, like excessive impulsivity and excitement, in children.

These findings refute the idea that mood problems in ADHD are necessarily part of an undetected depression—even though they do indicate a higher future risk for depression as well as a higher possibility of depression being present.

Treating Anger and Developing Emotional Resilience

From practicing coping skills to meeting basic health needs and seeking professional interventions, adults can deploy various strategies to rein in extreme emotions and achieve greater emotional stability. Here are the most common and effective strategies for developing emotional resilience.

1. Monitor Overall Health for Emotional Resilience

Neglecting to eat and sleep well, coupled with a lack of exercise, will impair an individual's ability to feel good and deal with life's stressors and challenges. Dedicating yourself to a new schedule for a month is usually enough time to see if there's any positive change. Some habits may help regulate emotions in the moment, but they are seldom useful in the long run.

2. Ensure Social Support

Social circles are critical to cultivating emotional resilience.

3. Manage Stress

Adults with ADHD are more prone to feeling stress, even when faced with the same events as their neurotypical peers. While a strength in some situations, this sensitivity can overwhelm and make coping more difficult. It's critical to become aware of chronic stressors and triggers and figure out which stressors can be eliminated, and which can be managed.

4. Use Counseling and Psychotherapy

For adults, counseling is the most well-proven intervention for addressing the emotional dysregulation tied to ADHD, as well as anger problems and extreme irritability. Professional counselors help patients identify coping skills and put them into practice, so they actually work.

Behavioral counseling (as in CBT) has clear evidence pointing to its benefits in treating emotional regulation problems for adults with ADHD. Specifically, these therapies improve skills in the following:

- **Interior regulation** refers to what individuals can do to manage out-of-control emotions. The key element here is learning coping skills, practicing them, and checking back with a counselor for refining. Important for patients to understand is that learning about coping skills without practice, or trying some self-help without professional consultation, is generally not as effective. Some examples of coping skills include:
 - **Anticipatory coping** entails building a mental framework before facing a recurring, stressful situation (like dealing with a child's tantrums) or devising an exit plan to a triggering situation—"I know I'm going to get angry next time this happens. What am I going to plan ahead of time to avoid that situation?" With a plan, it is much easier to maintain an emotional match to a situation and reduce overwhelm.
 - **Appraisals and self-talk** will mentally reframe an event and keep your temper under control (e.g., after someone bumps into you say, "Maybe that was an accident, or they're having a bad day").
 - **Shift attention** to focus elsewhere instead of on the upsetting situation or a stressor such as social media, the news, or a specific person.
 - **Humor.** Laughing about a situation (e.g., joking about it with a friend or exaggerating its importance) can change perspectives and attitudes around the once troubling situation.
 - **Rationalization.** Although often referred to in a negative light, rationalizing can also be an effective way to cope—also by changing perspectives.
- **Exterior supports:**
 - **Social connections**—talking to others and having their support tremendously benefit adults struggling with ADHD and anger.
 - **Self-care strategies**, such as exercise, mindfulness, and reducing stress can help.

Strategies with Limited Benefits

Typical ADHD medication helps with core symptoms but has only modest benefits on emotional dysregulation for adults with ADHD, according to a study published in *Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorders*.

Another study published in *Medicine* found that meditation classes offer some benefits for managing ADHD symptoms and emotional dysregulation for teens and adults (and

for children if parents join in the practice, too), but most studies on this intervention tend to be of low quality so it is difficult to draw strong conclusions.

High-dose micronutrients may help adults with ADHD emotionality, based on a small but robust study published in the *British Journal of Psychiatry*.

Problems with emotional dysregulation, particularly anger reactivity, are very common in people with ADHD. You are not alone in struggling in this area. Anger may indicate an associated mood problem but often is just part of the ADHD. Either way, changes in traditional ADHD treatment can be very helpful.

Joel Nigg, Ph.D., is a clinical psychologist and a professor in the departments of psychiatry and behavioral sciences at Oregon Health & Science University. The content for this article was derived, in part, from his ADDitude webinar, “You’re So Emotional: Why ADHD Brains Wrestle with Emotional Regulation.”

How to Control Your Anger When ADHD Emotional Reactivity Kicks In

By Sharon Saline, Psy.D.

It starts with a trigger. In an instant, a volcano of anger and negative emotion erupts. Before you can process what's happening, you say or do things you will regret. But you can't stop yourself. If we're being honest, sometimes it feels good to let it all out.

Living with ADHD means living with a stress-producing condition that begets emotional reactivity. Though the ADHD brain is wired to feel emotions like anger, frustration, and hurt quite intensely, emotional reactivity is ultimately a response pattern—that you can shift with the right tools and frame of mind.

Why Anger and Big Emotions Rock ADHD Brains

Emotional dysregulation is part and parcel of ADHD. Taken together, the following features explain why emotional eruptions occur so acutely and so often in ADHD.

Amygdala Hijack and Emotional Flooding

The amygdala is the emotional part of the brain that drives the fight-flight-freeze response. Amygdala hijack, a term coined by Daniel Goleman, Ph.D., occurs when the brain overreacts to a threat, real or perceived, and effectively takes over the prefrontal cortex—the thinking part of the brain.

ADHD brains appear more likely to experience amygdala hijack for a variety of reasons. For one, amygdala abnormalities are commonly seen in ADHD brains. The ADHD brain also struggles to turn off emotional processing—a problem when stress, either caused by systemic or individual forces, is persistently present. A constant flooding of stress and emotions essentially causes individuals to lose access to the rational part of themselves.

Poor Working Memory

Strong working memory is tied to effective emotional regulation, while weak working memory—which is associated with ADHD and executive dysfunction—often compromises a person's ability to manage and respond appropriately to emotions. Weak working memory could explain why you struggle to recall and decide on the coping strategies and tools available to you when faced with a trigger. Executive dysfunction also explains limited impulse control—or why you might say or do things you regret when you're overwhelmed.

Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria

RSD charges your thoughts and puts you on edge, often contributing to emotional eruptions.

As you brace to hear or experience the worst, for example, you may lash out as a defense mechanism. That's why anger is often called a secondary emotion—fear and other feelings are often hidden beneath the surface. The possibility that the negative outcome you've imagined might not occur doesn't even come into sight.

How to Control ADHD-Laced Anger

Understand Your Anger Habits

- Habits are mostly involuntary patterns of behavior that develop to meet an emotional need. Habits are made up of triggers, routine behaviors, and reinforcing outcomes. Changing a habit only requires targeting one of these components.
- Not all habits are good for us. Anger and emotional outbursts are habitual responses to uncomfortable feelings. They often arise when we underestimate our ability to cope with stressors.

Investigate Your Reactivity

Become curious about how your anger works (think about it in terms of the components of a habit), when it shows up, and any patterns associated with the emotion. Metacognitive thinking is a powerful tool (and an executive function) that can help you monitor and evaluate your thoughts and behaviors when you experience anger. The following metacognitive questions can help you understand your reactive patterns:

- **“What is happening that is activating me or making me feel on edge?”** Receiving negative feedback, being blamed unfairly, having someone yell at you, and/or feeling ashamed over something can all test your limits, as can other stressors.
- **“What sensations do I feel when I become angry or upset?”** Anger appears in many forms: a headache, a stomachache, sweating, chest tightness, etc.
- **“What behaviors do I resort to when I’m upset or angry?”** Reactivity habits include lashing out, attacking, catastrophizing, blaming, denying, and more.
- **“What’s helped me calm down when I’ve been in similar situations? Are those responses useful?”** Create a list of ‘slow me down’ options to manage the amygdala takeover more effectively.
- **“How are others reacting to my words and actions? What are their faces or bodies showing?”** Noticing other people’s facial or bodily expressions will also move you from a knee-jerk response to something that is more thoughtful and measured.

It takes time and effort to strengthen metacognitive skills. Refrain from judgment as you observe your thoughts, sensations, and behaviors. Remember that you are doing your best as you investigate your reactivity and apply different tools to control your anger.

Manage RSD

- **Identify your strengths and notice the good.** Each day, write down three things that went well, no matter how small. Example: “I had a great cup of coffee. I smiled today. I like the clothes I wore.”
- **Treat yourself with kindness.** Gather affirmations and personal words of encouragement. Put these on your phone or post them around your house or office.
- **Plan for how to respond to criticism**, even the constructive kind. Use the STAR method (Stop, Think, Act, and Recover).

Change Old Anger Habits with Effective Responses

Gather tools to slow anger at every stage: You need to access the modulated part of you that wants to stay calm. Here are ideas for responses at every stage of emotional intensity.

When you're mildly uncomfortable: This stage is just above your baseline of calm and comfortable. The soft trigger is easy enough to ignore, but it's nonetheless there.

- **Notice the negative, critical voice** that is starting to change your thoughts.
- **Compare your limiting beliefs** about the situation or yourself to the real facts.

When you're activated: You're growing upset, angry, or overwhelmed at this stage—and it's becoming difficult to ignore. Perhaps you're ruminating on something that is bothering you. There's a battle of sorts between the emotional and thinking parts of the brain.

- **Talk down the emotional brain.** Acknowledge and validate your feelings. Say, “It's okay to be angry. But what can I do to settle down?”
- **Repeat affirmations or supportive phrases.** Here is an example: “This is not the most fun or your best moment, but you'll get through it.”
- **Visualize yourself settling down.** Imagine yourself by a lake, tossing in a few pebbles. As each one journeys to the sandy bottom, feel yourself settle into your feet or your chair.

When you're on high alert: You're at your most dysregulated at this stage. Your body is fully engaged to fight or flee. Physical signs of anger appear—and physical responses can help your body slow down in the middle of the tidal wave of emotion.

- **Try focused breathing techniques**—alternate nostril breathing, belly breathing, etc. I often recommend triangle breathing: Breathe in for four counts, hold for four counts, and exhale for six counts. Pause before repeating the cycle. The longer exhales slow the physiological response of fight or flight.
- **Physically remove yourself** from the stressor or situation.
- **Engage in a physical activity**, like a walk or a run, to blow off steam.

- **Turn to a timed distraction.** Listen to music or play a game on your phone.

Identify your preferred soothers but know that you can mix and match responses. Breathing, for example, is useful at every stage.

Maintain a Healthy Lifestyle

- **Follow** a routine that allows you to get enough sleep, eat nutritious meals, move your body, and connect with others. A routine can ground you and reduce stress.
- **Think HALT** throughout the day—are you hungry? Angry? Lonely? Tired? What are your options to address these and regulate them?
- **Focus on building positive relationships** with others. Learn how to resolve conflicts by planning for them well in advance.

Practice, Practice, Practice

Stressful situations are a part of life largely outside our control. But we can manage our responses using insightful strategies. Keep the following pointers in mind as you move away from habits of reactivity to new habits of responsiveness.

- **Commit to change.** List your coping tools in multiple places—in your phone, on sticky notes around your home—to help you readily retrieve them.
- **Focus on one thing** that you can change at a time. Smaller goals mean greater progress.
- **Rely on a growth mindset.** Expect challenges and frustration as you adjust your emotional responses. View mistakes as learning opportunities and areas for improvement, not as personal flaws.
- **Remember why you want to change** your habits and move away from anger.
- **Don't be so hard on yourself.** Shame and regret will only hold you back. Berating yourself for things that you've done is useless if you can't take helpful lessons from those experiences. Practice self-compassion by honoring that you are doing the best you can. Accept that you will lose it at times, despite your best efforts. Progress may look like two steps forward and one step back, but that's still one step forward.
- **You are not your ADHD reactivity.** Intense feelings might have been a part of your life for a long time, but they do not define you. You are more than your foibles. Stumbling helps us do what we are supposed to do: learn.

Sharon Saline, Psy.D., is a clinical psychologist and author of What Your ADHD Child Wishes You Knew: Working Together to Empower Kids for Success in School and Life and The ADHD Solution Deck. The content for this article was derived, in part, from her ADDitude webinar, "When ADHD Triggers Emotional Outbursts: Scripts for Your Flashpoints."

The Emotional Resilience Playbook for People with Big Emotions

By Tamara Rosier, Ph.D.

ADHD brains are routinely hijacked by big emotions—and big problems often follow.

Sometimes, adults with ADHD react with big emotions when things don't go according to expectations.

Even minor frustrations and interruptions can cause us to overreact with an outburst or meltdown, making it hard to complete tasks and maintain relationships.

This emotional dysregulation creates a vicious cycle, dooming us to repeat the same reaction again and again.

We can't always stop big emotions from spilling over, but we can learn to minimize the damage they cause to others and ourselves and develop emotionally healthy responses in the future. This process of developing emotional resilience is critical. But first, we need to understand how we process our emotions: by hurling or by hiding.

Hurlers and Hiders (aka Fire Breathers and Shame Eaters)

Most people with ADHD who experience strong ADHD emotions fall into one of two camps: the “hurlers” or the “hiders.” The hurlers, aka fire breathers, sling their big emotions at anyone or anything around them. In doing so, they damage their relationships in ways they may not realize or understand.

The hiders, aka shame eaters, shove their emotions inside. Why? It might be due to conflict avoidance, fear of rejection, low self-esteem, or the feeling that they won't be heard. They may experience stomach or digestive issues because they're stuffing their emotions into their body.

Strategies for Hiders

Name that emotion. Don't judge the emotion you are feeling; just identify it. This is critical to releasing it. Otherwise, your stuffed-deep-into-your-body emotions will re-surface as unresolved pain that needs to be felt and heard.

For example, perhaps you got yet another parking ticket, and you reason that you deserve this punishment because you are bad at life. That is the feeling of shame.

Breathe and release. Now that you have named the emotion, let it go. Find an effective catharsis—a healthy release valve—like exercise, music, or even a primal scream. (See more ideas below.)

Strategies for Hurlers

Understand your patterns so you can anticipate big emotions before they erupt. What do you start to feel? How do you know when big emotions are building? When I'm angry, I hear, "Oh, heck no," in my head. When I hear this big emotional tell, I tell myself to calm down, listen to that emotion, and not give in to the hurler mode.

Learn to release emotions preemptively. Ask: "How do I let go of this energy? What are my options?" Find a healthy release.

Strategies for Relatives and Friends of Hurlers

Have you ever found yourself on the receiving end of a hurler in full fire-breathing mode? Here are a few tips to manage this:

- **Don't argue with the hurler in the moment.** The individual isn't capable of rational thinking until the hurling is done. If you say, "Don't talk to me like that," the hurler's ADHD brain will say, "Oh, yeah. That's more energy. That's more fire for me to breathe."
- **Create a boundary.** After the hurling is over and some time passes, say to the person, "Your hurling hurts me." Sometimes, the hurler will feel ashamed.
- **Don't bury the hurt.** If the hurler refuses to take responsibility, consider seeking help from an ADHD coach or ADHD-informed therapist.

Calming Big Emotions

Here are some more catharsis tips:

- **Sit up, push back your shoulders, and take a deep breath.** Inhale, hold, and exhale—each for five seconds. This signals to your brain that you can't possibly be in danger; if you were in peril, your breathing would be fast and shallow.
- **Vomit words (i.e., rant) safely.** For some of us, spouting out grievances provides an emotional release. One client of mine would call a friend and ask, "Permission to vomit?" The friend would say, "Permission granted," and then my client would rant. Once she got it all out, the emotion was gone. Crying or yelling into a pillow also works.
- **Move your body.** Go for a run or take a hike to trigger a release.
- **Try tapping (also known as Emotional Freedom Technique).** This practice involves

tapping your fingertips on meridian points on the face and body. Tapping helps relax the nervous system, calming our fight-or-flight mode and creating space to breathe.

- **Consider self-havening, or therapeutic touch**, to calm emotions. Begin by focusing on something calming, then cross your arms and give yourself a hug.
- **Cool down.** When you feel your emotions intensifying, or your pulse or breath quicken, go to a bathroom right away and put your hands and wrists under cold water. It is amazing how quickly this can reset your brain. Ice cubes on the wrists also work.
- **Establish daily practices to assess your emotional state frequently.** When you start your day, rate your emotional intensity using a number from one to 10, with 10 being the most intense. Repeat this assessment at lunchtime and at the end of the day. If you feel like a 10, you can say, “I need to do a catharsis ASAP.” On days when I don’t get enough sleep, I’m at risk for high-intensity emotions, so I check in with myself frequently to make sure I’m emotionally managed.
- **Choose how you want to feel.** If something frustrating happens, check in with yourself and say, “I don’t want to react in an unhealthy way.” Choose an appropriate and healthy level of intensity; that’s key as we practice emotional resilience.

Tamara Rosier, Ph.D., is the founder of the ADHD Center of West Michigan, a board-certified coach (BCC), and the president of the ADHD Coaches Organization (ACO). The content for this article was derived, in part, from her ADDitude webinar, “Build Your ADHD Emotional Resilience: Strategies for Adults Who Feel Things Deeply.”

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

Self-Test: Do I Have Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria?

Rejection sensitive dysphoria, or the extreme emotional pain linked to feelings of rejection and shame, commonly affects adults with ADHD. Use this self-test to determine if your symptoms match those of RSD.

Rejection sensitive dysphoria is not a formal diagnosis, but rather one of the most common and disruptive manifestations of emotional dysregulation — a common but under-researched and oft-misunderstood symptom of ADHD, particularly in adults. Rejection sensitive dysphoria is difficult for people with ADHD to describe, but all who have it agree that it feels awful. The trait often triggers a profound and wide-reaching sense of failure, as though the person with RSD hasn't measured up to personal or external expectations.

Could RSD be the cause of your strong emotional responses? Take this self-test, adapted from the work and presentations of William Dodson, M.D., LF-APA, and share the results with a mental health professional.

This screener is for personal use only and should not be used as a diagnostic tool. An accurate diagnosis can only be made through clinical evaluation.

1. Do you experience sudden, intense bouts of rage when your feelings are hurt?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

2. Do you experience sudden, intense bouts of extreme sadness when you think you have been rejected or criticized?
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

3. Are you your own harshest critic?
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

4. Do you feel anxious in social situations because you assume no one likes you?
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

5. Do you consider yourself a “people pleaser,” going above and beyond to get on someone’s good side?
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

6. Do you pass up opportunities or avoid starting projects because you're afraid you'll fail?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
7. Have you been called "overly sensitive" because of your strong emotional reactions?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
8. Do you dedicate more time than is necessary to a project or become perfectionistic to ensure your work has no mistakes (and is above reproach)?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
9. Do you ever experience your emotions as a physical sensation, as though you've been punched in the chest or physically "wounded"?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

10. Do you feel shame about the “lack of control” you have over your emotions?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
11. Before you were diagnosed with ADHD, were you told you might have a mood disorder?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
12. Do you shy away from close friendships or romantic relationships because you worry that if people “know the real you,” they won’t like you?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
13. Do you assume the worst in commonplace interactions—worrying you will be fired every time your boss calls you into their office, for instance?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

14. Do you think that you cannot go on feeling this way?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

15. Do you avoid meeting new people or trying new things because your fear of rejection and criticism is so strong?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

Results: Assign the following values to your answers: Very Often (4 points), Often (3 points), Sometimes (2 points), Rarely (1 point), and Never (0 points). The higher your point total, the greater the likelihood of showing signs of rejection sensitive dysphoria. (Maximum score: 60 points)

Note: *This screener is designed to determine whether you demonstrate symptoms like those of rejection sensitive dysphoria. A high score does not necessarily mean you have rejection sensitive dysphoria. If your score is 46-60, that means you answered “Often” or “Very Often” to most of the questions and should see a trained healthcare professional, as there is a possibility that you may be experiencing symptoms of rejection sensitive dysphoria. An accurate diagnosis can only be made through clinical evaluation.*

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

How Does RSD Really, Actually Feel?

Stabbing knives, white-hot rage, and debilitating fear are all descriptions used by *ADDitude* readers to convey the unseen and often unappreciated power of RSD.

In a survey, *ADDitude* asked adults with ADHD to describe how their RSD feels and how it impacts their lives. Responses confirmed that RSD is a serious, debilitating psychological phenomenon.

“Some rejection hits like a physical punch. The air leaves my lungs because of the hurt. Other times I feel this all-consuming humiliation. Or a fierce frustration and anger at myself. If I’m blindsided, I feel like a sad, confused little girl, thunderstruck in my bewilderment. I’ve even lashed out like an injured animal, cornered by the pain, and wanting to dish it back out. **These varied reactions can be accompanied by tension headaches, instant fatigue, nausea, and tightness in my throat or chest.** Sometimes I can shake it off, while other times the funk it puts me into can leak into the next day or week.”

“Anytime someone critiques an interest of mine, **it feels like a dagger ripping through me**, especially if the critique comes from someone I care about. Their rejection can pretty much shatter my interest and leave me feeling empty.”

“My partner and I both suffer from RSD, and any difference in opinion is a potential pit of despair. My hyperactivity makes it incredibly painful to be patient with his inattentive symptoms. **His silence and emotionless demeanor feel like knives.** Medication helps, but clear boundaries and humility help the most.”

“When I feel I am being criticized, especially by my husband, **I get very angry—I see red.** Now that I know why this happens and we have a name for it, it’s a lot easier for us to know how to handle it together. He now appreciates that I don’t have the ability to resolve it at the moment and leaves me alone to calm down.”

“If you close a door on me, if you reject me, if you dismiss my feelings, I can’t control my reaction. **It turns from frustration into white-hot rage** so quickly that I’m liable to throw or break something. It’s incredibly embarrassing as an adult, and I’m in therapy working on the anger.”

“**RSD feels like constant failure**, and then being criticized for feeling like a failure if I express any of my emotions.”

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

“Criticism usually triggers **feelings of self-doubt and unworthiness**. I immediately feel disconnected from the person who criticizes me.”

“The initial feeling is as if **you’ve been punched in the head and are struggling to regain consciousness**. You then deny that it is affecting you, but your brain goes blank, your body paralyzes, and, as if by the force of a volcanic eruption, you plunge into an abyss of infernal pain and fear. That is only the beginning. Nothing derails the power of RSD.”

“Due to many real and perceived rejections in my life from friends, family, and co-workers, **I have become scared to start any new friendships or group activities**. I no longer volunteer to do things at church as I struggle too much to remember to get the tasks done or to attend the meetings. My family helps me out by reminding me and forgiving me when I forget.”

“**Any sidelong look or shared smirk between people in a group conversation feels like I’m being made fun of**, and most corrective feedback feels like, ‘You are not good enough. This is how you have failed.’ I know intellectually that these worries are irrational, but the thought only occurs to me after I’ve already felt the emotional sting of perceived rejection. I feel like I’m walking on eggshells around new acquaintances because I’m constantly trying to figure out what they want.”

“I understand rationally that my partner is not rejecting me when he doesn’t want to come to the Sunday market with me, but my emotions get easily out of hand. **I feel like he doesn’t want to spend time with me, that I don’t matter, that I’m stupid for asking, that I’m uninteresting and dull, etc.** It’s exhausting.”

“It is humiliation, followed by self-berating, and **I feel it as a nauseous anxiety in my stomach**. I anticipate it all the time when I have to present ideas at work, and in social situations, I tend not to express my thoughts or feelings.”

“**It feels like my heart drops into my stomach**, and I’m completely taken out of the moment.”

“When I am criticized for a simple mistake at work, I become extremely emotional and cry. **It has been so humiliating that I have quit jobs.**”

“Every single time is **like the very first time you got rejected as a child.**”

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

“It’s a punch in the gut and a **kick to the head while you are writhing on the ground**. The parts of me that others miss, I take care of by beating myself up for leaving myself vulnerable to them in the first place.”

“I often misunderstand what people say and become defensive or angry. I feel like they are talking about me and laughing at me. **I interrupt at inappropriate times and say something irrelevant that pops into my head because it feels urgent**. My relationships have been affected by my outbursts and perceived insults.”

“The slightest change of expression or hesitation **can feel like a slap in the face**, whether it is real or perceived. For years, if my husband tidied the house, I perceived it as criticism, even though I knew he was meticulous before we married. He has had to walk on eggshells to avoid the minefield of my easily hurt feelings. I struggle with people-pleasing and am constantly analyzing the behavior of co-workers and supervisors for signs of their judgment.”

“RSD feels like searing regret, shame, embarrassment, and failure. **At the slightest hint of disapproval, I crumble**. I feel so inferior, and I want to hide from the world—it’s safer that way.”

“I struggle to regulate frustration and grumpiness. **When I feel those emotions, I shut down and can’t communicate**. It tends to be triggered by plans changing, which happens a lot with three young girls! Luckily, my wife is brilliant at being patient with me and helps me recognize what is happening.”

“Emotional dysregulation manifests as rejection sensitivity for me. The **fear of being perceived negatively has stopped me from trying new things**. I’m an artist, but I don’t draw anymore; I couldn’t bear to hear a single negative comment about my work.”

“My life is most impacted by how easily and quickly I become frustrated and angry. **I respond impulsively** in social interactions and make comments that, in retrospect, I realize may be perceived as rude or inappropriate. I am currently trying to manage this by practicing these steps: ‘stop, breathe, think, do/say.’”

“My biggest emotional dysregulation burden is the constant anxiety that I feel about not living up to my potential. There’s so much I want to do and achieve, but **my mind spins so fast that my emotions can’t keep up**. It’s like one of those videos where someone is sitting still, but everything else around them is moving fast; the sun comes up and goes down, and they are still sitting there. That image captures my inability to act and implement changes that could actually help.”

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

“Most of my life, I would ignore or put off feeling my emotions until it was way past the moment when they could have been resolved. **I struggle to trust my ‘gut feeling’ and intuition**, which contributes to my anxiety and depression.”

“Rejection sensitive dysphoria is my biggest emotional challenge. **I am so hard on myself and take even the silliest of slights personally**. I am fairly successful at my job, but fear of failure always holds me back.”

“**My biggest issue is depending too much on emotional support from my parents and boyfriend**. I’m at a place where I don’t feel like I could survive without either of them.”

“It’s car rage. Not road rage—no one else is threatened—but **when I’m sitting inside my car my brain rewinds to recent or long-past insults, the bad news of the day, or anything else that triggers me**. I end up doing the ’70s primal scream therapy thing (which is why I sound like I’ve smoked 10 packs of cigarettes). When the insults or stressors happen in real-time, my brain goes into a fog of what I now assume is cortisol overload: There’s an ocean-like roar in my head that freezes me up and makes me useless and unable to react.”

“The area of emotional dysregulation that most affects my life is criticism from others and from myself. **I feel some emotions as a physical sensation**—how can others receive criticism so calmly? Most people don’t understand my hypersensitive reactions. I am finally seeing a counselor and implementing CBT techniques, which has helped.”

Why Am I So Overly Emotional?

By Peter Jaksa, Ph.D.

More than half of people with ADHD find it hard to regulate their emotions, according to research. Irritability, angry outbursts, rejection sensitivity, and other intense emotions define the ADHD experience—at least in part—for many. Genetics and biology are partly responsible and contribute to a recipe for emotional dysregulation—reacting too intensely, too impulsively, and out of proportion to the situation at hand.

This emotional intensity affects relationships with friends, co-workers, family, and partners. On the positive side, it can make people with ADHD more caring, more loving, and more passionate about things that interest them. On the negative side, ADHD emotionality makes people more likely to overreact, in ways that can be destructive. The reason this happens is no mystery: Emotional people react emotionally. It becomes a problem when it happens too frequently and too intensely.

Below are profiles of highly emotional individuals with ADHD and relationship struggles. Learn how they managed to address challenges like rejection sensitivity, outbursts, and more.

Overly Emotional with ADHD: Real-Life Stories

Rejection Sensitivity

“I don’t take criticism well,” Pauline says. She always feels “on edge” about being criticized. When it happens, she says, “I feel overwhelmed emotionally, so I panic and shut down.”

Being hypersensitive to criticism (real or imagined) leaves Pauline in a high state of anxiety, which is bad enough. Beyond that, it damages her relationship with her husband, Brian, because she withdraws from him. “She stops communicating,” Brian says. When Pauline withdraws, he feels neglected. It kills emotional intimacy and trust, and it is painful for both of them.

How did the couple solve the problem? Pauline acknowledged her RSD in conversations with Brian. She discussed her feelings in the moment and did not hide them. This also helped Brian connect with her feelings instead of being shut out. It gave him a chance to explain himself better when Pauline was feeling criticized because very often, he was not being critical. This helped her to keep things in perspective and to get reassurance from Brian that she was not failing in some way.

This understanding and support from Brian helped Pauline better control her overreaction. Dealing openly with the rejection sensitivity gave this couple a foundation for healthy communication and a happier relationship.

Temper Flares and Angry Outbursts

Ethan loses his temper once or twice a week. It happens more often at home, with his wife and children, and sometimes at work. Luckily for Ethan, he owns his own business. Otherwise, his outbursts would have gotten him fired long ago.

Ethan often gets frustrated and angry when someone does not do something the right way. “I react too quickly rather than talk it through,” he explains. He has tried many times to tone down his anger, but “I don’t know where the off switch is.”

Ethan’s family had to put up with his frequent outbursts, although they knew he was not a mean person. He heated up quickly but also calmed down quickly, within a matter of a few minutes. Even so, it made them feel unsafe around him. After several discussions, his wife insisted that he seek professional help. Ethan agreed it was a problem.

The most helpful treatment was a combination of ADHD medication and behavior therapy. The medication helped moderate his high levels of emotion. The behavior therapy helped him identify the physical and emotional anger cues, so that he could catch himself and defuse the anger before it became an outburst. With treatment, Ethan found the “switch” for better temper control.

Impatience and Pushy Demands

Aiden has no patience for unresolved issues and drawn-out discussions. He needs answers and wants things settled—now. If he’s arguing with his partner, and his partner wishes to end the discussion and walks away, Aiden follows him into the next room to continue the conversation.

“I pick on something, and I can’t let go,” Aiden says. He knows that this is inconsiderate to his partner, but “for the life of me, I can’t help it.” This leaves his partner feeling angry and resentful.

Aiden understands that his need for immediate gratification is part of his ADHD biology and goes back to his childhood. He threw tantrums in the toy store and the grocery store. Through the years, these behaviors have damaged relationships. It has never happened in a work relationship because of the clear boundaries there, and the consequences can be severe. Work relationships are not as meaningful to him.

Aiden ultimately managed his pushy behavior by taking more control of his emotions and his impulsivity. He made a strong commitment to respect the wishes of his partner and other people in his life. No meant no—a good rule to live by. He also put into practice a five-second rule when he felt himself getting impatient or pushy. Before he allowed himself to say anything, he counted to five and considered the consequence of his behavior. It was not foolproof, but it helped.

Overly Emotional: 5 Strategies for Managing Intense ADHD Feelings

1. **Understand the biology of ADHD and emotional dysregulation.** Managing biology is most helpful while criticizing the behavior is never helpful.
2. **The person with ADHD is always responsible for managing their behavior.** ADHD should never be used as an excuse. Never. Ever. Period.
3. **Self-awareness and self-monitoring can manage emotional over-reaction** at the behavioral level. Therapy and coaching can help.
4. **Medication and exercise** modulate ADHD biology and the tendency to overreact.
5. **Treat co-existing conditions** (e.g., anxiety, mood disorders, stress disorders, etc.). These comorbidities complicate emotional self-regulation when they are present.

Peter Jaksa, Ph.D., is a clinical psychologist, former president of the Attention Deficit Disorder Association (ADDA), and author of Life with ADHD.

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

How to Manage Your Anger Before It Bubbles to a Boil

ADDitude readers share their strategies for managing anger and controlling negative emotions.

Adults with ADHD experience disproportionate problems with anger, irritability, and rejection sensitivity. This emotional dysregulation is exacerbated when baseline stress and anxiety are already abnormally high. *ADDitude* asked its readers, “How do you manage negative emotions, such as anger, in your relationships?” Read their advice below.

“Empathy and knowledge of ADHD’s hallmark symptoms has helped me. Dislike the disorder but not the person. This approach doesn’t always work, but it is the best place to start.”

“The best way to assess and restrain yourself is to understand and accept your disability. My husband struggles with my ADHD. He doesn’t understand why I need sticky notes for everything he tells me, placed in areas where I can’t miss them. I have used articles from *ADDitude* to help him understand that my missteps are not intentional. Just as I have learned to live with his CPAP machine running all night, he is learning to live with my disability.”

“I pause before speaking, and I think hard about whether I am taking things or words the wrong way.”

“Mostly by biting my tongue, withholding certain remarks, and taking time to think about the situation and my responses. When I’m tired or under pressure, I do not listen well, and my reaction time is short. I say things I later regret. When I am angry, **I will ask for a timeout or some space to cool down.** Medication has played a big role in helping me to avoid ruminating about things.”

“I am a duck in the rain. Everything is water that runs off my back. I’ve been married for 48 years, and I have to ignore things to keep from strangling my spouse.”

“I take a break and return to the conversation once I’ve calmed down and have had time to think. I write down important thoughts before talking to ensure I remember topics.”

CHAPTER 2: EMOTIONAL SELF-REGULATION: STRATEGIES FOR MANAGING BIG FEELINGS

“I exercise. Simply **making time to go on a walk or hike helps** calm me and improves my mood.”

“Through CBT, I have begun to recognize how anxiety and other emotions can cloud judgment and responses. It is hard not to get caught up in the moment when you have ADHD, but I am getting better at recognizing what I am feeling, then reflecting and gathering my thoughts before responding.”

“I ask for time to ‘gather my thoughts.’ It gives me time to cool down and think about their perspective and if I am having a rational response to whatever triggered me.”

“I call a trusted friend and vent when I am frustrated, but always make sure it is a friend who will not judge my husband or children by what I tell them. I also write my thoughts on paper or **write a letter about the issue** that I may or may not give to my partner or child.”

“**Learning about the emotional components of ADHD** has been instrumental in being able to step outside of my anger for a moment and also allows me to understand how my emotions affect my husband, friends, and family.”

“I try to **communicate what I need and how I’m feeling right away**, rather than hold it in. I tend to explode if I don’t.”

“My spiritual life is a huge asset that allows me to assess my thoughts and emotions. **Prayer, study, and mindfulness** are fundamental.”

“**Self-care!** I get up early to start the day quietly and focus myself before my son gets up.”

“**Talk things out**, take deep breaths, and schedule breaks during the day.”

“I take full responsibility for how I respond to my emotions. **I identify and express the primary emotion, which is not anger.** Usually, it is fear or pain.”

Expert Q&A with Sharon Saline, Psy.D.

Q: “I can’t handle rejection. Will I ever change?”

RSD, as you know too well, causes extreme emotional pain. Whether or not the rejection has actually occurred or is strongly perceived, RSD makes it difficult to recover from criticism. Many people with ADHD look at social situations through the filter of past experiences of rejection and exclusion, which further fuels rejection sensitivity.

In part, RSD is tied to fears of embarrassment or of letting down others and to concerns that mistakes will cause others to withdraw their love, support, or connection to you.

Many folks try to discount their emotions in an attempt to overcome RSD (though denial only makes them stronger), or they avoid situations where any semblance of criticism could occur.

These strategies never work because you can never please everybody all of the time. Rejection, negative feedback, or judgments are inescapable parts of life. Instead of relying on avoidance or the negative expectancy that fuels anxiety, understand that your responses to rejection follow a pattern. Your goal is to create new patterns of responding, thinking, and behaving to reduce both the perceptions of rejection and the reactions when they actually occur.

Here are some tips for how to improve your coping skills and manage the effect that rejection has on your ADHD brain.

- 1. Remember the times you persevered despite discomfort.** If you are reading this, there’s great news. You’ve survived everything that life has thrown at you, including all the terrifying and uncomfortable moments. RSD threatens to erase those memories of triumph and tries to convince you that the pain of rejection is unsurpassable. Make it a habit to recall moments where you persisted in the face of fear. Write some of these down in your phone or journal so you can remind yourself of your courage. Over time, the unbearableness of rejection will subside.
- 2. Identify your strengths.** Focus as much as possible on what you love to do and what you do well. You are not the sum of broken parts. You are much, much more than that. Make a list of qualities or talents you like about yourself. Write these down as well. Then transform them into affirmations for those challenging moments. “I am brave; I am creative; I take risks; I keep trying.”
- 3. Do a “happy and a crappy.”** Each day, name a few good (happy) and not-so-good (crappy) things that transpired. This practice will teach you to de-emphasize negative thoughts and shift your attention to what’s working.

4. **Be a “STAR”:** Stop, Think, Act, and Recover to manage big feelings, especially during unpleasant interactions. Pausing will help you accurately gauge a situation instead of speaking out of turn or rushing to a conclusion.
5. **See your sensitivity positively.** Unfortunately, many people are quick to negatively label and shame sensitive individuals, which does nothing to help RSD. What does help RSD is embracing sensitivity and the good that comes with it. Say: “I am sensitive, which means I feel things deeply and connect to people in special ways.” Wear sensitivity like a badge of honor.

As you form new patterns, they may feel strange or awkward. Practice self-compassion. We have all experienced (and will continue to experience) rejection and hurt in life. When things don’t go the way you hope, take time to regroup, and treat yourself like you would a child with a skinned knee—with care and kindness.

Expert Q&A with Lisa Kaufman, LCSW

Q: “Intense emotions are ruining my life. How can I control my temper?”

People with ADHD have intense thoughts and emotions. Your highs are higher, and your lows are lower. So, you may experience happiness and criticism more powerfully than your peers and loved ones do. You can become frustrated and angry quickly, and it is hard to deal with everyday challenges when your responses are always extreme.

It is also common for individuals with ADHD to spend much time ruminating on negative emotions. Many of my clients report that managing emotions is the most challenging aspect of ADHD. You may not feel like you have control over your emotions, but there is plenty you can do to modify their intensity before they damage your relationships with friends, loved ones, and co-workers.

To begin, a multimodal treatment plan, including ADHD medication and behavior therapy, such as CBT, is effective in helping people understand how situations and thought patterns affect their emotions.

Here are more ways to manage emotional dysregulation.

1. Understand How ADHD Affects Your Emotions

Recognize that emotional sensitivities are part of your disorder; they are common and measurable symptoms. This awareness can help you avoid unnecessary and destructive self-criticism over your hypersensitivity and intensified emotions.

2. Own Your Feelings

Coping with uncomfortable emotions is not about avoidance. Avoiding or suppressing your feelings will exacerbate them when you least expect it. Instead of putting a lid on your emotions, acknowledge them, accept them, and breathe through them.

3. Be Prepared to Respond to Situations That Will Set You Off

Recognize the situations that might lead to a blowup. Think about your usual response and consider what you can do to ensure a better outcome. Review your plan before you get into the situation again, and, if possible, make some notes or use a visual cue (perhaps a favorite bracelet) to remind you of the plan when the situation arises again.

5. Replace Distorted Thoughts with Realistic Thinking

Individuals with ADHD encounter frequent and frustrating setbacks in life. Because of those setbacks, you may become self-critical and pessimistic. This, in turn, brings on negative emotions, cognitive distortions, and an unhealthy self-image.

6. Express Yourself

With a better understanding of your emotions, you can express yourself without

anger. When you can articulate your feelings and say what you need, you will feel heard and understood. Let others know what is upsetting you.

7. Take a Time Out

When you are flooded with emotion, take some time and space until you feel more centered. This is a common strategy for relationships where anger-fueled disagreements cause conflict. When either person calls a time-out, both walk away from the problem and return after cooling down. You can also create a mutually agreed-upon verbal cue—a code word—that you use when emotions get out of hand.

8. Set Boundaries

After expressing strong anger, ask yourself, “What made me so angry?” It may be that someone overstepped a boundary. If you can define a boundary, rather than react after one has been crossed, you will feel respected and be less likely to get angry.

9. Become Your Own Cheerleader

If you are too critical of yourself, replace criticism with self-compassion. When you are self-critical, you move further away from what you want—self-control. When you accept yourself, you give yourself encouragement. This is essential to building self-confidence and empowerment.

Lisa Kaufman, LCSW, is the founder of MindFuel Counseling in Denver, Colorado.

“Why You Lash Out—Sometimes for No Good Reason”

By Sandy Maynard

Do you lash out when your spouse reminds you—nicely—to take out the dog or pick up a gallon of milk? Do you fly off the handle when the boss asks you to turn in the next report on time? Have you wondered, “Why am I always angry?”

I know many people who do, including myself. In fact, many adults with ADHD lack restraint when we think that someone is dissing us. The question is: Are they? Because many of us have low self-esteem—after years of negative interactions—we are hypersensitive to criticism, real or imagined.

Bursts of anger have repercussions that last much longer than the few seconds it takes to vent. Having an argument in the workplace can get you fired. Blowing up at a loved one can strain the relationship. And it all takes a toll on your self-esteem—bringing remorse or shame for days afterward.

Is Anger a Symptom of ADHD in Adults?

My client, Mike, came to me to learn some anger-management strategies after he realized his ADHD tantrums had damaged his relationship with his teenage son, who, like Mike, has ADHD. Mike had long believed that “getting the anger out of [his] system” was healthy.

Until now. “My outbursts are creating a rift between me and my son that doubling his allowance won’t repair,” he told me.

I explained that most teens know which buttons to press because they installed them. After a good laugh, we identified the times when Mike was most likely to lose his temper—after a tough day at work when he had screwed up an assignment. When he came home to find that his son hadn’t taken out the garbage—again—Mike got upset. If his son had a fender bender, received a parking ticket, or cut out of school early, Mike blew his lid.

Help, Don’t Yell

I reminded Mike that he must maintain realistic expectations about his son, who was easily distracted. Mike came to see that neither he nor his son was perfect and that he should adjust his own imperfect behavior. Instead of yelling at his teen for forgetting to do a chore, Mike worked on helping him remember by posting a list on a bulletin board in the kitchen and reinforcing it with text messages during the day.

If Mike’s son still forgot—or got into trouble at school—Mike learned to observe his rising anger and figured out ways to short-circuit it. He took a relaxing walk with his dog and deferred discussions with his son until Saturday or Sunday morning when

he felt refreshed and less pressured by his job. He and his son could talk calmly—and productively—during those chats.

Finally, Mike found comfort in a local ADHD support group for parents contending with similar problems. It is a great comfort to him to know that he isn't alone with his anger problems.

Another client, Karin, who was sweet and personable during her visits, surprised me when she said she had problems managing her anger at work. Karin was furious with a coworker who frequently blamed her for something that wasn't her fault.

Instead of talking with the co-worker or her immediate supervisor, she acted impulsively and went to the boss to defend herself. "Knowing that everyone thought it was my fault that the company lost the contract made me so angry," Karin says. "I felt I had to let Mr. James know it wasn't."

We talked about a strategy that would let her indulge her anger without acting rashly. I suggested that Karin set a timer and let herself be angry for five minutes. After the time was up, she had to move on. I also had her place a visual cue next to her phone to remind her to pause before taking rash action—like calling the boss. She rummaged through her photos and found a snapshot of herself and her kids making sandcastles on the beach.

"Looking at the photo does two things for me when I get angry," Karin says. "It reminds me that my job is not as important as it seems. What counts most is my relationship with my family. It also reminds me that my happiness doesn't come from my job but from within—and that no co-worker or boss can take it away from me."

Karin still gets angry at work, so she has expanded her cueing strategy: She keeps a draft folder for emails labeled "Wait On." If she thinks she is sending an email out of anger, she lets her message sit for 24 hours and reads it again before hitting the send button. "Many of these emails never leave that folder. If I decide to send one, I edit out rude or inappropriate remarks before doing so."

And when she slips up and says something she regrets, Karin "owns up to her mistake and apologizes." Not all apologies are accepted graciously, but saying she's sorry makes Karin feel better about herself. As a result, her relationship with her coworkers has improved dramatically.

Sandy Maynard is an ADHD coach and founding board member of the Institute for the Advancement of AD/HD Coaching (IAAC).

“Have I Overreacted? Big Time? Five Ways I Rectify Emotional Outbursts.”

By Les Steed

It's crisis time. I know because my heart rate is up. A lump in my throat forms. My muscles feel tense and alive. I hear words, but it's a part of the blur around me as I am hit with a thousand stimuli at once. My mind races as I consider potential escapes and threats. Everything is slow and fast at the same time.

Something's happened, and it's on me to figure out what it is and safely deal with it. It could be anything—a car crash, a death, a breakup, an arrest—it doesn't matter. The point is that I'm losing control, and I must regain that control to make us safe.

My ADHD spikes as my adrenaline increases. In many ways, ADHD symptoms have evolved so that individuals with ADHD are hard-wired to recognize a true threat and assess and react instantaneously, without fear or consideration of long-term consequences.

We skip all the bits we don't need, including logic, and jump straight into action. Our thoughts are on autopilot: Just stop the threat. Make everyone safe. Do not rest until your mission is complete. Deal with the aftermath later.

The only problem is that this time the big threat consists of... 10 party poppers and a loud “Surprise!”

But it's too late. I hear loud bangs and see lots of movement in what should be my empty apartment. I hyperfocus on the bright streamers and the fiery candles thrust into my face along with the loud noises around me. My mind and body are consumed: “We're under attack: Protect your girlfriend!” I swiftly forgo the non-threatening cues and details. I don't just ruin the surprise; I decimate it.

My flight-or-fight impulses cause me to shove the homemade cake my adorable grandma was wielding from behind the front door away from me with one hand and launch my partner back down the hall to protect her with the other.

Now grandma's lying over a bean bag four feet away from her walker, her legs and petticoats waving in the air above her, covered in icing that reads ‘Happy Birthday’ and four letters of my name. Meanwhile, I'm standing in the middle of this mess shouting, “Sorry! Sorry! Sorry!” while flapping my arms like a penguin that just drank four espressos.

Everyone's yelling and looking at me in horror (except for grandma who assures me that “It's quite alright, dear!” while I slip over my freshly iced floor in a rush to pick her up, and my brother, who is crying with laughter).

I feel overwhelmed and try to explain myself. I forget to apologize and just start blubbering everything in my head while the place erupts around me. It is chaos!

So, how should I handle this situation and others like it? Here's my hard-learned process:

1. **Close your eyes.** Shut out everything and take a deep breath. Make sure you enunciate clearly and say, "I'm sorry." Only say it once. The more you talk, the more it sounds like you are making excuses.
2. **Remove yourself from the situation and handle your emotions.** Tell people where you're going (behind a bush, a different room, etc.) and let them handle things while you pull yourself together. Otherwise, your stressed-out follow-up will make everyone else's reaction worse. Give them space to feel their feelings—at least 15 minutes. Take that time to think about what happened.
3. **Return once you're calm and apologize again.** Explain that you tried to do the right thing at the moment, and you made a mistake. You meant well and you are sorry. (Your motive matters as much as your actions.)
4. **Do something small to show you care,** like tidying up. Take responsibility for your actions; talk to someone you hurt when they are ready. Don't hate yourself for what you did; remember that very little is completely unforgivable.
5. Once everyone's calm, **listen and do what they say** is needed to make it right for them. Don't deviate from their instructions, (unless they tell you to take a long walk off a short cliff or are just being mean), and let them approach you if they don't want to talk when you first approach them. Take constructive instruction, but not personal criticism (someone just calling you an idiot isn't helpful).

Finally, keep your RSD in check. Remember not to take what people say personally, especially if they're the hot-headed type. They have the right to react too, but that doesn't mean that you're automatically the worst person ever for reacting the way you did. Even if people tell you to "get out," it doesn't mean that they don't love you—it might even become an endearing story that you laugh about together one day.

Good luck.

Les Steed is an ADDitude contributor, former international news journalist, and podcast host.

“How Rejection Sensitivity Casts a Cloud Over My Marriage”

By Elizabeth Broadbent

I am staring at my husband. I am just staring, not blinking, narrow-eyed, mouth a straight line, standing across the room and fixing him with a look.

He tells me to stop. He says I am not accomplishing anything with this. He says I just need to accept that I yelled too much at the kids because I was stressed, and that's okay; everyone does it sometimes. He is not gaslighting me—I admitted I did it and felt guilty and sad and awful and terrible about it. And I apologized to the kids. So, it's over and there's nothing else left to do but move on. But my ADHD comes with rejection sensitivity—a.k.a. rejection sensitive dysphoria. And it can be a beast.

Stop staring, he says. Stop. Just stop. When you feel upset like that, just walk away.

I cannot stop. I know I am not accomplishing anything. I am so, so angry right now. I am livid. I am raging. It's one thing for me to say I feel sad and guilty. But it's a whole other issue for him to agree with me.

Because, by doing so, he is saying I am a bad parent.

He is saying I am a terrible parent who lost control.

He is saying I should not have kids.

He is saying, when he tells me to walk away, that it would be better if I were not around my children.

Of course, he is not actually saying any of these things.

But I hear them. I hear them as if he is shouting them at me. I feel them like a punch in the gut. This is what rejection sensitivity means. In my house, we all have ADHD. But I have a bad case of RSD, and my husband does not. In my case, it means that I have an extremely difficult time taking any type of criticism whatsoever.

A good marriage is built on honesty. That means, at times, gentle and constructive criticism from your spouse. I can't take it.

I Curl Inward

A lot of the time, when my husband offers up suggestions for family improvement—“Hey, maybe we should enroll the kids in some sports programs,” for example—I clam up. I don't initiate a discussion about the pros and cons of the idea, and I don't offer my input. I just curl inside myself.

There's a line from the poem *Fiddleheads* by Maureen Seaton: “When you hurt me, I evolved like a backboned sea creature, translucent/nervous system sparking along in the meanest deep where I was small enough not to care ...” I think of this every

time I stop talking and cross my arms as if to hold myself inside and feel like the worst person in the world for not thinking of this beforehand. I might feel like I am right, and he is wrong, but I cannot offer up suggestions about the mundane like a rational person at that moment. I am too busy feeling rejected and alone.

I Lash Out

Sometimes, when my husband asks something as simple as, “Did you water your plants today?” which he doesn’t particularly care about and is just part of the background patter of marital conversation, I hear something else.

I hear you are irresponsible. I hear you do not take care of your things. And I feel the anger rising. I snap. “Of course, I did! I always water my garden! I take good care of it!” And he is left baffled. “What did I say?” he asks. “What’s wrong? Did you have a bad day? Are you okay?” And it might evolve into a fight. Which I pick, almost every time.

I Pick Fights—Because It Is Easier

Psychologically, we pick fights with those we love because we are hurting and angry at ourselves, and we want to stop that anger from clawing at our insides. If we can get mad at someone else, we can deflect our hurt and anger outward, and suddenly the hurt isn’t hurting so badly. Or at least, it hurts differently, in a way that doesn’t feel so damaging and broken.

We’re mad and disappointed in our spouse instead of ourselves. This can erode a relationship, especially an ADHD relationship. Luckily, my husband knows I do it, calls me on it, and walks out of the room. I have been known to both follow him and keep arguing (if the kids aren’t around) or dissolve into a puddle of tears (if they are). Then we can move into something constructive.

I Snark Out

Sometimes, when my husband makes a suggestion I don’t so much lash out as snark out. He might say something like, “Man, I need to do the dishes,” and I hear, “You should have done the dishes,” even though according to our household division of labor this is not my job and I never touch them. “Oh, I’ll try to fit that in between my bon-bon consumption and *Days of Our Lives* tomorrow,” I bite back, even though he knows I spend my days loving, feeding, homeschooling, policing, and cleaning up after three children.

Not a constructive way to deal with life, and something that leaves him stuttering for an answer. To me, he’s telling me I should have done the dishes for him, and I’m lazy for not fitting them into my busy schedule. To him, it’s an offhand comment.

I Stomp Off

Sometimes, it all gets to be too much. Maybe there are too many little things I can interpret as criticism, so much so that I feel unwelcome in my own home. *I feel so attacked that I can't function as a parent or spouse*, whether I've curled up inside myself or lashed out. So, I stomp out the door to Target or Goodwill and go shopping—sometimes compulsively. I buy stuff we don't need, and I feel momentarily better about life. Except when I come home, my husband will ask what I bought, which I hear as an indictment, and which can start the cycle all over again if the shopping hasn't thoroughly calmed me down (it helps, I've found, to take a kid along for balance).

I Think My In-Laws Hate Me

Rejection sensitivity extends beyond my husband and into the rest of the family. I am utterly convinced my in-laws (excluding my father-in-law) hate me. Every comment, every request to re-organize the dishwasher I just loaded, any question about my home-schooling (no matter how innocent), any insinuation the kids should play in one room instead of another for fear they might break something priceless, is read by me as a comment on my inability to function as an adult with competent parenting skills. It sucks.

I know intellectually that they don't mean it. And they are truly nice people who do actually like me. But I fret and freeze and clam up and fake migraine headaches and sleep too much around them because I find their presence, at times, an excruciating march of rejection. This leaves my husband to run interference, to keep me calm, to cajole me into every single visit. It sucks. They are super nice and super sweet. But my RSD prevents me from feeling it.

I Make My Spouse Deal with My Parents, Too

My RSD is so severe that some days, I can't even talk to my own mother. For example, she moved to our town and needed help, because moving is stressful and busy and messy. I went over one afternoon to meet the plumber and, while I was there, broke down all her boxes and organized her linens. I instantly regretted it. She would hate it. She would hate me for it. I had so much internalized my RSD that I anticipate it from those I love.

So, when she called that night, I made my husband answer the phone for fear she would berate me for doing everything wrong. My mother is not the berating type. Of course, she was wildly grateful (I still think she rearranged all her linens while cursing my name). The constant need to deal with not only his parents, but also mine, can wear on him. He always has to be the adult while I'm the scared kid.

I Spiral Into Despair

RSD is often mistaken for any number of psychological disorders. But sometimes, when I feel rejected or criticized, I can't help falling into a spiral of despair and

misery that can culminate in tears, panic attacks, and the need to take medication to calm myself down.

My poor husband has to play both comforter and psychiatric nurse to these episodes. It's not fun, it's not pretty, and it's not conducive to an equal partnership when one person might fall off the deep end at any moment.

I Suffer Suicidal Ideation

Sometimes, my RSD gets so bad that I feel like the world would be better off without me. Let me be clear: I would never harm myself, because I cannot stand the thought of hurting my children. But that doesn't mean I don't think about it. That doesn't mean that sometimes I don't want to. And when that happens and I voice the thought, he goes into panic mode.

Is this bad enough to call the doctor? Does he need to take my pills away? Can I be left alone? He often has a panic attack himself at the thought of losing me. I'm feeling guilty and rejected and unloved and so terrible I think I don't deserve to live, and the person who loves me the most is scrambling to keep me safe. It's not healthy for either of us.

Basically, RSD can strain a marriage to the breaking point. I'm lucky. I married a man who will stick by me through anything, who loves me deeply, and who was aware before our marriage that I had psychiatric issues, whatever labels psychiatrists have decided to slap on them over the years. He knew what he was getting into, and he's able to see the person behind the RSD: The woman who loves him deeply and who acts out not because of malice, but because of despair and fear.

I don't go on an RSD tear every day. Or even every other day. For long stretches, I hold it together, and I try my best to hear the words people are saying, rather than the words I hear. But sometimes, I can't help it. Sometimes, the words twist and turn like a knife in the back. Then I start to lose control. The RSD takes over. The strain on my marriage begins. And I am lucky—damn lucky—to have married a man who can cope with it.

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The following *ADDitude* experts and authors contributed to this chapter: Elizabeth Broadbent; Alan P. Brown; William Dodson, M.D., LF-APA; Peter Jaksa, Ph.D.; Lisa Kaufman, LCSW; Sandy Maynard; Joel Nigg, Ph.D.; Tamara Rosier, Ph.D.; Sharon Saline, Psy.D.; and Les Steed.

CHAPTER 3

Motivation: Overcoming Procrastination & Getting Things Done

Chapter 3: Motivation: Overcoming Procrastination & Getting Things Done

Why the ADHD Brain Chooses the Less Important Task — and How CBT Improves Prioritization Skills

By J. Russell Ramsay, Ph.D.

“Procrastivity” and Its Role in ADHD

A combination of “procrastinate” and “activity,” the term “procrastivity” aptly describes a tussle common among people with ADHD who are always busy but never seem to make headway on life’s important goals. At its root is an implementation problem: The individual knows what they need to do, but they won’t or can’t do it, so they keep occupied with more palatable but less critical tasks.

Filing taxes, for example, is a high-priority, strict-deadline task that an adult with ADHD might put off for re-seeding the lawn. While a worthwhile activity if the grass is indeed bare, this gardening is not critical, especially when April 15 looms. If tending to the lawn is the priority task, on the other hand, some adults with ADHD might opt to watch or read the news in a bid to stay informed. Productive? Yes, but low on the scale of priorities.

Procrastivity can especially affect people with ADHD, as the disorder, at its core, is a struggle with executive functions and self-regulation. Completing everyday tasks and learning how to prioritize is often more difficult for people with ADHD compared to their neurotypical peers—and all that backup effectively creates a breeding ground for procrastivity.

Why do some tasks that would be otherwise avoided suddenly become more appealing in the face of higher priority to-do items? And can the ADHD mind be trained to steer clear of this low-hanging, time-wasting fruit? This is the conundrum of procrastivity and the promise of its match: cognitive behavioral therapy.

Using CBT to Address Procrastivity

Cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT)—a type of brain training—has been shown to help patients manage their ADHD symptoms and improve functioning. CBT as an ADHD therapy aims in part to reframe the often negative perceptions patients with ADHD have of themselves—a result of living the ADHD experience in a neurotypical world—by providing coping strategies, tools to manage negative expectations and emotions, and analysis of behavioral patterns that interfere with the strategies.

Sometimes, however, procrastivity prevents patients with ADHD from following through on the strategies and approaches discussed in CBT sessions, thereby rendering fallow the very tools they need to solve the underlying problem. But by dissecting procrastivity into its root causes and manifestations, its elements can be used to employ CBT techniques that help ADHD patients actualize the important work.

Procrastivity Inside the ADHD Brain

What are the key differences between the small, unimportant tasks that ADHD patients tend to choose over the more critical, deferred ones?

1. **Manual focus:** Often, the lower-priority task is physical and less cognitively demanding than the higher-priority task. Getting the lawn mower out of the shed, starting it up, and pushing it to the lawn is less cognitively challenging than preparing taxes—a nebulous and mentally taxing, so to speak, activity. This also explains why some patients opt to read when faced with a daunting writing task.
2. **Familiar script:** Individuals are more likely to tackle tasks with a pre-existing “menu.” Laundry and other household chores that can be done on auto-pilot tend to fall under this umbrella but writing a research paper does not.
3. **Time frame:** Procrastivity tasks often have a more firm and predictable time frame; there is little doubt about how long they will take. Deleting unread emails may take 10 minutes, but the same cannot be said for preparing a work presentation.
4. **Task progress:** Procrastivity tasks often have a clear measure of a beginning, middle, and end. Lawn mowing starts with removing the mower from the shed, and you’re halfway through when half of the grass blades are cut. It ends with the mower going back in the shed. But a task like filing your income taxes does not have crisp progress points; it’s more difficult to tell if you’re making progress, and how much.

Preferred procrastivity tasks tend to align with a patient’s own perceived efficacy. They will opt for it even if the activity being avoided may actually take less time and effort.

Harnessing Procrastivity Insights in CBT

With procrastivity pulled apart, clinicians can harness the attributes that draw patients to low-priority tasks to create a CBT-based priority task plan that includes behavioral, emotional, and other implementation strategies:

Behavioral Approaches to Productivity

1. **Attach manual, step-by-step descriptions to must-do tasks.** This strategy allows the individual to engage steadily and progressively in the priority task. “Mow the lawn,” therefore, becomes “go to the garage,” followed by “take out the lawnmower,” and “Set the mower height.”
2. **Lower the bar on progress.** This strategy associates the priority task with time, another task, or terrain. This can mean working on the task during commercial breaks only or focusing on the activity for 600 seconds rather than 10 minutes. The goal of the technique is to make the priority task “doable” by changing how time around it is conceptualized.
3. **Define time by start and end.** The aim of creating a “bounded” work period is to reduce the cognitive load associated with priority tasks for patients. Ambiguous work periods are more overwhelming than the work itself. But having your patient work only until the hourglass (probably the best tool because of the ability to “see” time) needs to be turned over can help.

Emotional Approach to Productivity

1. **Reframe discomfort.** Another cognitive reframing technique that helps remind your patients that they do not have to be in the mood to do something to do it. Having patients acknowledge their discomfort aloud can also help, demonstrating that the feeling isn’t necessarily tied to action.

Implementation Strategies for Productivity

1. **If X then Y.** Studies show that putting tasks in this structure can help patients develop executive functioning cues. If I can sit at my desk, a patient might say, then I can work on paying bills for 10 minutes. The desk may eventually become a visual cue for patients, where they associate it with being able to work for 10 minutes.
2. **Tipping point.** Create a plan to identify and handle points during a task that maintain workflow. This includes the starting point, a method for handling interruptions, and thinking of how to re-engage in a task after a break.

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CHAPTER 3: MOTIVATION: OVERCOMING PROCRASTINATION & GETTING THINGS DONE

What's My Motivation? (No, Seriously, I Need to Get Started.)

Feeling unmotivated is a big obstacle for adults with ADHD. While they can't "try harder" or "just do it" like their neurotypical peers, they can enlist their creative problem-solving abilities to get stuff done. Here's how.

Tackling a to-do list when you lack motivation is not impossible, but it takes a lot of energy. For some, it feels physically painful. Spending our days trying to complete tasks we are not motivated to do makes us feel bad. It's a feeling that knocks many of us back to the couch, raising the white flag and surrendering ourselves to failure once again.

You Can Conquer Your Lack of Motivation

Not being able to get things done when we feel unmotivated ranks up there with other things humans can't do—breathing underwater, licking our elbows, or sneezing with our eyes open. Granted, a few people can manage to-do lists without any inspiration, but not many of us can pull off getting started.

So, how can we eliminate those negative feelings and get motivated? What gets our juices flowing so we can get up and do what we want or need to do? Simple—do something that feels good or pleasurable. People with ADHD need to learn to tap into the meaning, importance, or worth of the task at hand.

6 Strategies for Overcoming Lack of Motivation

Motivation Hack #1: Celebrate Small Successes

First, to feel less down on yourself, plan to do something rewarding several times a day. This is not an option; it is essential to have little successes, no matter how small, every day. Do something creative or pleasurable. It will recharge your battery. You may enjoy listening to upbeat music, talking to a friend, going outside, or spending 15 minutes working on a hobby. Make a list of 10 things you enjoy and refer to it often.

Motivation Hack #2: Remove the "Shoulds" or "Supposed tos"

You may notice that you use "should" and "supposed to" only when trying to do something someone else considers important. "Should" and "supposed to" are motivation killers and must be eliminated from your vocabulary. You can minimize "shoulds" by turning them

CHAPTER 3: MOTIVATION: OVERCOMING PROCRASTINATION & GETTING THINGS DONE

into “wants.” Think about the “unmotivating” task before you. Ask yourself, “What, if anything, about this task is OK with me? What piece of it might I enjoy?”

A common “should” is doing the laundry. Seeing this tedious chore as a “want” might mean noticing how you enjoy the scent of your favorite detergent as you put it in the washer. You don’t look forward to doing the laundry, but you like the smell of the fabric softener sheet. Or maybe you enjoy the warmth of the laundry coming out of the dryer. Or maybe you love that sense of accomplishment when the laundry baskets are momentarily empty. Focusing on the “want to” changes the “should” into “I want to do the laundry because I like the way it smells right out of the dryer.”

Motivation Hack #3: Give Yourself Permission to Delegate

When you face a difficult task, tap into your creative ADHD brain for inspiration. Ask yourself: Is this something I have to do or is there someone else who could do this easier and who would find it rewarding? Another person might enjoy doing a task you dread. Give yourself permission to let go of what you don’t do well and let someone else do the chore or task. For instance, dry cleaners are brilliant at doing laundry, and grocery shopping can be turned into a new experience when done online or completed by a spouse, teen, or neighbor in exchange for doing something for them that they don’t enjoy, like gardening in the backyard or walking a dog.

Motivation Hack #4: Tailor Tasks to Your Interests

If the task cannot be eliminated as a “should,” and you are the only person who can complete it, make it more bearable by asking, “How can I do this in a way that works for me? What might make it feel worthwhile?” People with ADHD do things differently. Going grocery shopping with a friend would be fun if you get to socialize. Shopping late at night, when there are fewer people, minimizes the agony of waiting in lines. Shopping at a different store might turn picking up groceries into an adventure.

Motivation Hack #5: Turn Your Boring Tasks Into Exciting Games

Use your ADHD imagination and ask yourself, “How can I make this boring task fun or rewarding for me?” Turn it into a new game: Challenge yourself to get the best deal by using coupons; time yourself to get in and out of the store in under 30 minutes. When you are done, treat yourself to a new fruit, bakery item, flower bouquet, or beverage.

Motivation Hack #6: Ask the Right Questions

If you’re faced with motivation challenges and don’t know where to start, ask yourself the following questions:

CHAPTER 3: MOTIVATION: OVERCOMING PROCRASTINATION & GETTING THINGS DONE

- What excites or reenergizes you?
- What recharges your batteries?
- What old beliefs about what you “should” do might not be true?
- Who else can do this task easier than you?
- Think about a time in your past when completing a similar type of task wasn’t so hard. What was different? Can you bring some of those elements into the situation now?
- How can you break the task into more manageable pieces?
- How will you reward yourself when you complete this task?
- What would you need to let go of to allow someone else to take it over?
- What needs to change to turn this “should” into a “want”?
- What are you good at?
- What negative self-talk do you notice that you reframe?
- What about this task is important or meaningful to you?
- When is the best time for you to do the task?
- What support do you have to get the task done?
- What obstacles are preventing you from completing the task? Which of these can you eliminate?
- How can you make the task fun, interesting, or enjoyable?

The key to putting the meaning back in motivation is to let go of the way it works for everybody else. Use your out-of-the-box thinking to devise fun, interesting, and rewarding ways to motivate yourself to complete a task.

This article was written by Laurie Dupar, PMHNP, RN, PCC, a senior certified ADHD Coach, trained psychiatric nurse, and founder of the International ADHD Coach Training Center.

5 Perfectly Awful Ways to Motivate an ADHD Brain

By Tamara Rosier, Ph.D.

Many people with ADHD have less reliable access to our prefrontal cortex (PFC) than do neurotypical people. Life's details are managed in the PFC. It is a calm, rational butler, directing behavior in a Siri-toned voice: "Sir, your keys are on the table," or "Madam, you must leave now if you want to arrive on time."

However, those of us with ADHD can't rely on our PFC butler for planning, short-term memory, working memory, decision-making, and impulse management. So we go to our emotional centers, in the limbic system, to remember things, make decisions, and motivate ourselves. We use our emotions to help us to think, remember, plan, and act.

Anxiety: "I Need to Stay on High Alert"

We use anxiety to increase performance. It produces the impetus to make us move, to act. When we forget things that aren't in our focus, anxious thoughts hold them in our memory. The anxiety-alerting system works something like this: Someone gets out of the car and says, "I need to remember to lock my car." Their thoughts race on: "I need to listen for the beep. What if I double-clicked my key fob, and it actually unlocked the car? Someone could steal my stuff. What is in my car? Oh, my son's iPad. I don't want that stolen. He would be furious—and I can't buy a new one right now. Lock car." Anxiety makes the individual lock their car.

Individuals with ADHD compensate for lack of focus with racing thoughts, nervousness, and worry. This is especially true for those with undiagnosed or untreated ADHD. If our logical motivation is a faint flame reminding us that we "should" get to a task, we pour gasoline—anxiety—on that flame, and we become motivated. The drawback, as it is with each of our emotional tricks, is that motivating ourselves with anxiety is exhausting.

Avoidance: "I'll Do a Different Task, Not the One I Should Be Doing"

When our anxiety gets too high, a circuit breaker trips because too much power is being drawn from the emotional part of the brain. Then we turn to another tool, avoidance. Avoidance directs us to do a different task, usually one that is less important. This misdirection soothes our twitchy limbic system, calming our anxiety. We don't want to think about the task that makes us anxious, so we temporarily forget what we don't want to do.

"I used avoidance like it's my job this week," a client says. Although she had work projects due, she decided to repaint her bathroom instead and dived into redecorating websites at her office. Avoidance lets us feel productive by accomplishing a different task. "At least my bathroom will look nice. I have wanted to do that for a while," she reasons.

Procrastination: “It’s Like I’m Dodging a Bullet. It’s a High”

Procrastination is similar to diverting interest, with anxiety added, to initiate a task. Here is how it works: I need to do a particular task, but there is no reason to do it immediately, so I wait. And wait. And wait—until it becomes impossible to accomplish on time. And then, like a superhero, KaPOW!, anxiety rushes in, and the task finally gets done.

Procrastination as a motivator doesn’t produce our best work. But it does increase the pressure to do something. My college-aged clients often brag, “This 25-page paper was assigned at the beginning of the semester. I did it in 10 hours! I barely ate or used the bathroom and pulled an all-nighter!” Some celebrate their heroic feat, others feel ashamed, but they all had motivated themselves by procrastination. The feeling is like dodging a bullet—and it is a high.

Anger: “When I Get Mad, I Am Moved to Act”

Anger can help us do that stupid little task that has been haunting us for days or months. The flare of anger makes us feel strong and pushes us to do what we want to get done. “Stupid winter, stupid weather, stupid Michigan,” a client mutters as he prepares his garage for the winter. The weather had already turned cold, and snow was on its way. He needs an hour to put away warm-weather things, like garden hoses and deck furniture, and prepare his snowblower. “I didn’t consider my flare-up of anger as trying to motivate myself,” he says later, “but I had to get mad to clean the garage.”

Shame and Self-Loathing: “I Focus on My Flaws to Keep the Momentum”

When all else fails, we turn to shame and self-loathing to motivate ourselves. These aren’t quick fixes like anxiety, avoidance, procrastination, and anger. Instead, these dirty tricks are a slow-burning irritant to our emotional well-being.

People use shame to motivate themselves to accomplish their daily tasks. One client talks about using shame to get things done at work and at home. She says, “To finally start a project I’ve been putting off, I imagine how disappointed my supervisor will be if I don’t finish it in time. At home, I remember I have only one chance to give my kids a good childhood. I have to get it right, or I’ll screw them up.”

Shame can lead to self-loathing, a strong dislike of yourself, your actions, or your ADHD. Self-loathing creates false beliefs about us. Disguised as discipline, self-loathing makes us too miserable to motivate ourselves. A middle-aged male client explains how he uses self-loathing to improve his financial situation: “I hate the fact that I don’t have more money. I hate feeling like a loser. It drives me each day.”

I often see self-loathing in my practice. With coaching, clients learn to see it in themselves. A mother of two children with ADHD noticed her children's use of self-loathing. One day she heard her youngest express disgust with himself after failing to complete a task. She knelt and looked at him, saying, "We don't do that in this house." He replied, "OK, then, I'll go outside." His response shows that motivating ourselves with self-loathing can become a habit.

Develop zero tolerance for shame and self-loathing because these dirty tricks will only harm you. Listen for those deeply negative thoughts. When you pay attention to the worst voices in your head, you'll be fascinated—and disheartened—by what you hear. Acknowledge them, and then be kind to yourself.

When one of my clients hears them, she says, "Oh, it's you again. Why are you here?" Everyone has doubts and ugly thoughts—it's how you handle them that matters.

Catch Yourself Using Dirty Emotional Tricks

Doing daily tasks, managing time, and looking like a grown-up is hard for people with ADHD. A lawyer-client explains, "I love the complicated parts of my job and do them well. The partners at the firm love me for that. It's the little, boring things that exhaust me." She uses emotional tricks to help her do those tasks.

As you wake up, imagine that your battery is fully charged. As the day goes by, your charge will slowly decline, opening the door to using emotional tricks. They drain your battery rapidly and leave you feeling physically and emotionally exhausted.

Retrain your thinking to become aware of these tricks. Try these techniques:

- **Set an alarm each hour.** When the alarm goes off, write down an emotional trick you have used or were tempted to use at work or at home. Look for patterns.
- **Reframe and challenge your negative thoughts.** An ADHD coach can help you.
- **Seek accountability.** Ask your spouse, significant other, or close friend to tell you when they see you using these tricks.

The Everyday Rationales That Let Procrastination in

By Ari Tuckman, Psy.D.

We all push undesirable tasks, unwittingly or not, into the future. It's how our minds protect themselves, particularly in stressful situations, and make life easier for the moment—it isn't an immediate threat; it's a problem for another day.

These optimistic predictions, or rationalizations, sometimes work. It is possible to do that task or project tomorrow. The seeds of possibility are there. But the odds of getting to the task as promised aren't so good, especially for people with ADHD, who are more likely to struggle with procrastination and time management.

But before we overcome procrastination, we must first identify the common pretexts and justifications that actually interfere with getting things done. Here are some that you may recognize, paired with remediation strategies.

“I Can Do It Tomorrow”

Putting things off for later is tempting, especially when you're tired or overwhelmed. Often you can do it tomorrow. But sometimes that's true only in theory. Unexpected events can derail the best-laid plans. And perhaps you forget something else that also needs to be done tomorrow, so there's less time than you thought.

If you catch yourself putting something off, take a moment to think about everything you need to do later. Check your schedule—and write down a specific time for doing the task so you won't forget. If you're procrastinating because you don't feel like doing it now, remind yourself that you will be no more excited about doing it tomorrow.

“It'll Only Take a Minute”

It's tempting to knock off a quick chore or something fun before getting into something meatier. After all, it will only take a minute, so what's the big deal? The problems come when you underestimate how sticky that quick task is—sending one email leads to reading the next one, which leads to clicking that link. Which leads to wasting time you don't have.

Before patting yourself on the back for being efficient, pause to ask how likely you are to get stuck. What are your stickiest activities, where the only way you would get out in a minute is if you were abducted? Be careful with these and avoid them when you have something important to get to. I had a client who would get fascinated by an NPR story while making breakfast, only to get lost in a deep dive and be late for work. We discussed not turning on the radio until they got into the car.

“I Don’t Need to Write That Down”

This is also known as “I’ll definitely remember that.” You dismiss things that should be put into a schedule or to-do list. I know, writing things down is slow and annoying, and it breaks your flow—I have a parade of teenagers through my office who swear to this. Unfortunately, getting called on the carpet when something falls through the cracks (again) is pretty disruptive, too.

Uncertainty fuels self-doubt and sleepless nights when your mind churns over what will blow up tomorrow. Remind yourself that the small inconvenience of writing notes can save you giant headaches later. Pause to think about how much better it will feel when you check off that upcoming task versus how bad it feels to be caught in possible problems later.

“I Can Stay Up a Little Longer”

After busy days, it’s tempting to stay up late to squeeze in some fun. The problems of tomorrow morning don’t exist at midnight, so let the good times roll. Or maybe the goal is to catch up on work that wasn’t done earlier in the day. I had a client who would routinely stay up too late finishing homework. She would talk herself into believing that it wouldn’t take that long—but since she was always tired from staying up late, everything took longer.

Be honest with yourself about how much sleep you actually need. When you’re tempted to stay up late, think vividly about how hard it will be to get out of bed and how the next day will be long and painful. Resist the temptation to stay up “just a little longer.”

Overcoming Procrastination: Our Choices Spill Forward

Stressful situations make bad decisions more likely, and bad decisions, like dominoes, create more bad situations. An irregular sleep schedule, for example, makes it harder to get anything done efficiently, which spills over into other facets of our lives.

What’s more, even when our optimistic justifications actually work out, they can make us feel like imposters doubting our successes and fearing that we will be outed. When they don’t work out, it’s even worse—we feel ashamed that, yet again, we didn’t live up to our expectations.

It’s important to watch for these excuses or first dominoes—the ones that take the rest with them. If you left a task undone, own it, fix it, and make amends. Set yourself up for success by telling people beforehand what you will do, using social pressure as a motivator. Remind yourself of how good you will feel knowing that you are prepared for tomorrow.

Even if you’re not perfect at preventing undesirable scenarios, making them a little less bad will create a difference you can feel. Partial progress is a worthy goal.

Stop Dodging That Dreaded Task! Nine Ways to Halt Avoidance Procrastination

By Sharon Saline, Psy.D.

Cleaning out your car, returning phone calls, filling out paperwork—it's easy to rattle off dreaded tasks we despise, but it's much harder to motivate ourselves to complete them.

Most of these tasks start small, say following up on an email, and then grow (in our minds or in real life) to overwhelming proportions as time marches on, deadlines slip by, and late fees mount. In time, we find ourselves alone—staring up at a dark mountain that triggers feelings of impending doom and inevitable failure. *“I’m just going to fail, so why bother?” “I’m not sure I can do this.” “I’ve done this before, and it didn’t work out. Why would it be any different this time?”*

Success! You avoided the task. But instead of celebrating, you berated yourself with negative self-talk for your inability to do the activity you can't stand: *“Others can do it. Why can't I do it?” “I’m never going to measure up.” “I can’t do things.”*

What Is Avoidance Procrastination?

You convince yourself to avoid a dreaded task but feel terrible for skirting it. The guilt is real, but you can't stop repeating the same behaviors. This vicious cycle is called avoidance procrastination, and it is common in individuals with ADHD.

It's not that the task is actually terrible; you just have an incredibly distorted perception of its difficulty or unpleasantness. Avoidance procrastination or “procrastivity” paralyzes you with dread and fear of several things: embarrassment, failure, discomfort, disappointing yourself or others, etc.

This is because people with ADHD have “not-now brains.” Many have real challenges with focusing on anything other than the present moment. Everything is “now” or “not now.” Because the “now” moment feels terrible and endless, imagining things will feel better once you finish a hated task is tough.

Often, it's problematic to start a task because it seems too big, and that “bigness” feels unpleasant or overwhelming. This could be due to the cognitive elements, energy required, or the emotional weight of the dreaded task. Perhaps you say things to yourself like: *“This is too complicated for me to accomplish,” “I’m too tired to take this on right now,”* or *“If I don’t do this right, something terrible will happen.”*

If you are wondering how to stop procrastinating, it's simple: Follow these steps.

Step #1: Break It Down

The Number One solution for avoidance procrastination is breaking down a task into tiny, manageable pieces. For example, decluttering is an issue for many people with ADHD. They convince themselves to delay or dodge the task because they don't know where to begin, there's too much clutter, it's a waste of energy, or life is just too busy. They are right; decluttering is too big. It needs to be broken down into smaller chunks. Start with one closet or sock drawer, or delete emails that aren't directly addressed to you.

Take a moment and consider a task you dread and why it's so unpleasant. How can you break it down? If you can't break a task into small enough steps that you can do, then the pieces aren't tiny enough. Ask for help if you don't know where to begin. There's no shame in doing this. Everybody has things on their to-do lists that they avoid.

Breaking down tasks is no easy feat. "Now/Not-now" brains struggle with the executive function skills needed to start and finish a task—namely initiation, time management, organization, planning, motivation, and prioritization.

In addition, ADHD brains naturally have lower amounts of the neurotransmitter dopamine. Dopamine helps control the brain's reward and pleasure center. It's hard for a neurotypical brain to work up excitement about cleaning the litter box; it's going to be twice or three times as hard for an ADHD brain to do such a low dopamine task. The benefit of cleaning a litter box for maintenance can seem inconsequential or boring.

You are naturally much more motivated to complete high-dopamine tasks such as gaming, exercising, or meeting a friend for dinner—something interesting and rewarding. If the litter box gets to an unbearable level of toxic odors, then you'll be more motivated to clean it because the reward is inherent and immediate. The bad smell will go away.

Step #2: Prioritize the Urgent and Important

Your list of dreaded tasks most likely dwarves your list of pleasurable tasks. In this case, you need to prioritize. Do a brain dump by writing down everything you have to do. Create a brain dump notebook and decorate it with stickers or different color markers to enhance its appeal. Rank each task's urgency ("What will happen if I don't get this done soon?") and its value ("How important is it to get this done soon?").

You can do this by using the Eisenhower Matrix decision-making tool, which determines what tasks deserve immediate action, long-term attention, delegation skills, etc. Just be careful not to mark every task as urgent. Because cortisol floods and activates ADHD brains to

engage in an activity when the deadline fast approaches crisis levels, it's easy for people with ADHD to live in the urgent and important quadrant. However, this quadrant is best reserved for emergencies and crises. Otherwise, you will feel drained and tapped out 24/7.

Step #3: Make a Plan

When you repeatedly complain, ruminate, or delay, you hurt yourself. Just talking, thinking, and revisiting how you're supposed to get something done does not help you move forward. Without taking the next step of creating a plan, you're developing a negative story about your inability to do something and increasing your anxiety and your insecurity. This is a form of self-sabotage.

Many people with ADHD skip this step because they feel it's not fun or it seems like a boring waste of time. Plus, making the extra effort to create and follow through on a plan is not what avoidance procrastination tells us to do. Avoidance procrastination says that we don't need lists and that preparing is stupid. But it's not stupid! The right-sized list helps break down unpleasant tasks into smaller pieces.

Remember when you needed to write a research paper in school and surrounded yourself with a stack of open books? You had to search from book to book to find the best facts or quotes to include in your paper. It took hours to gather enough content and many more hours to write it up.

What if you had first created a document listing the books and the page numbers where specific information lived? You could have organized your notes on one subject in one document and another topic in a different document. Instead of the time-consuming process of scanning resources as you wrote, you could have quickly scanned the docs to gather whatever information you needed.

Step #4: Make Your Plan Smaller

I have a client who used to make to-do lists with 40 or more items each. He crossed off two or three things he did each day but felt like nothing was accomplished. Defeated, he would avoid the other items on the list.

A list with a million little to-dos only increases avoidance procrastination because no one wants to tackle a list of a million little things. It's intimidating and overwhelming and doesn't promote a sense of achievement.

I told my client to brain-dump all his to-dos. Then he selected five from the list that he wanted to complete. He listed those on a separate sheet of paper. He placed his original brain dump out of his eyesight and only focused on the five-item list.

The following week, he admitted that the shorter list worked much better because when he crossed off two or three items, he no longer felt bad about himself. He had accomplished something.

If you get stuck while narrowing your lengthy to-do list, focus on the most urgent tasks and do those first. Then go back and select five more things that may not have a time element but are important to you.

Step #5: Schedule & Set a Time Limit

Avoidance behavior ushers in dread. You genuinely don't like doing the task, so you need to set aside a specific time for it because that window will not miraculously appear in your day. It's highly unlikely that you'll say, "I finished dinner. I need something to occupy my time productively. I'm not going to spend an hour on social media. Instead, I'll clean up the mud room because that seems like a good idea." Haha.

Turn this avoidance around. Schedule the task for when your brain is fresh and awake, perhaps in the morning or around lunchtime. Or, if you regularly get a second wind after dinner and feel inspired before watching your show, do it then.

Step #6: Do One Thing at a Time

To tackle avoidance procrastination, complete one task at a time and allow yourself to feel a sense of accomplishment when you have completed it. For example, if you need to declutter your kitchen, start by clearing the counters or just one. Look at your counter and see what's on it that isn't needed. Then make a list. Where will the mail go, old newspapers, trash, etc.? You can say, "Today, I'm only going to do mail and trash." It's okay to limit your activities by your capacity. Next, gather some storage boxes and garbage bags. Get to work by sorting through the stuff. Whatever is not mail or trash stays until tomorrow when your plan deals with that.

Step #7: Delegate & Develop a Routine

Delegation helps when you feel overwhelmed. Imagine it's dinner time, but you can't make dinner because the kitchen is a mess, and the table is dirty. There's nowhere to eat and nothing to eat on because the dishes are dirty. Where do you start?

Remember: Do one thing at a time. Maybe you order pizza, and while you wait for it to arrive, you work on the dishes and have your children, partner, or roommates help you clean the table.

Delegating tasks gives you some reprieve and could lead to a new routine or habit. Maybe whoever cooks dinner doesn't do the dishes in your family. Perhaps whoever sets the table also clears it.

You can develop a routine for yourself, too. You could do the after-dinner dishes before you watch television. Create a routine that makes sense and keeps you engaged. Gamify it with music, dancing, or talking with a dear friend.

Step #8: Replace Shame, Self-Sabotage, and “Shoulds” with Support

All people struggle to do the things they don't find naturally interesting or rewarding. The difference is that individuals with ADHD have difficulties with motivation, persistence, initiation, and completion, making dreaded tasks much harder to accomplish. (Remember the deficit of executive functions?) ADHD brains also must deal with the emotional side of avoidance procrastination. This manifests as self-sabotage, self-loathing, and shame.

We create “I should do this” messages in our brains. But when you don't want to do what you think you should do, you interfere with whatever progress you are making. You tell yourself that *“It doesn't feel like I'm doing it the right way,”* or *“I'm not doing enough,”* or *“I'm not doing this task as fast as I should,”* and so on.

Often you call yourself “lazy.” But you are not lazy! Laziness implies that you don't want to do something because you don't care, which is different from caring about something but being unable to do it.

It's difficult to bring yourself to do something on your own. If you feel stuck, contact a trusted friend or family member. Maybe a friend can come over for a cup of coffee and talk you through a task or keep you company while you work on it? If proximity is problematic, you can schedule a Zoom, Google Meet, or FaceTime call with a friend.

I do this with my writing group. In the beginning, we share our goals. Then we simultaneously work on our projects with our cameras and volume off. Knowing that we support each other helps us get through any onerous tasks. And at the end of our meeting, we each say what part of our goal we accomplished.

Using the steps above and understanding how you procrastinate and what you tend to avoid will empower you to complete your most dreaded tasks.

This weekend, think of a task you hate and break it down into small chunks. Then work on it for 10 minutes, give yourself a sticker or a pat on the back, and go on to something else.

How to Set Intentions to Crush Procrastination

By Timothy Pychyl, Ph.D.,

Contrary to rampant misperceptions, procrastination is not a time-management problem. Procrastination is an emotion-management problem. Procrastinators use avoidance to cope with the negative feelings around a task—and about themselves.

In a way, we can think of procrastination as that petulant 6-year-old, alive and well in all of us, whose catchphrase is, “I don’t wanna!” Daily planners, timers, and similar tools, although necessary, are not sufficient to address the underlying emotional issues behind needless stalling and delaying.

Setting intentions that specify where and when we’re going to do a task (also known as implementation intentions) is one overlooked but effective strategy to decrease procrastination. Concrete intentions help mitigate frustration and overwhelm around an undesirable task and carve out a clearer path forward.

To reduce procrastination, build intentions around conditional statements like, “If/when I am in situation X, then I will do Y.” Putting the cue for action into an environment like this (in situation X) is very helpful for getting outside of our habits and even establishing new habits. Research has shown that these implementation intentions are most effective when we consider the following elements:

- **Time:** Too often, we banish undesirable tasks to “sometime tomorrow,” “over the weekend,” or “soon.” Vague, poorly defined time frames relieve us of accountability—we feel no pressure to live up to the plan. We can think of these as anemic intentions. They lack strength or motivational force. Instead, specify a time and a place when you intend to act—something like “this Saturday morning at 10 a.m.”—to tackle the task.
- **Environmental cue:** Research published in the *European Review of Social Psychology* shows that specifying a cue for an action (the “X” in the statement above) increases follow-through. Think: “This Saturday morning, when I have finished my coffee (the cue), I will do Y.” Another benefit of an environmental cue is that it frees up working memory, a known deficit in ADHD. If the cue is an event that will undoubtedly occur, we don’t have to work so hard to remember it.
- **Action:** Avoid broad, abstract actions like, “I am going to finish the project.” Instead, state specific actions like, “I will read the next five pages.” Concreteness is an important aspect of effective intentions. Vague actions often add confusion and increase feelings of overwhelm around a task. It’s also difficult to feel a sense of accomplishment or hold ourselves accountable for vaguely defined actions. In addition, a concrete action, no matter how small, brings the task to the present and adds a sense of urgency, making

it more likely that we'll act on it today. Even a little bit of progress on a goal is enough to feed motivation and make us feel good. Clearly, delineated actions also allow us to stop—if we don't feel like doing more, we don't have to.

The Hard Truth of Procrastination

Just because we set intentions, complete with specific cues and concrete actions, doesn't mean that we'll always feel up to the task. The 6-year-old inside of us fights hard to avoid frustration, so we have to expect this resistance and act whether or not that 6-year-old feels like it. We don't have to “be in the mood” or “feel like it” to take action. One person once told me: “For a chronic procrastinator, that's a bitter pill to swallow. But I've found that the more I embrace this hard fact of life and put it into practice, the less I allow my anxiety, frustration, and craving for immediate mood fixes to dictate my actions in the moment.”

Timothy Pychyl, Ph.D., spent nearly three decades as a faculty member in the Department of Psychology at Carleton University in Ottawa. He gained an international reputation for his research on procrastination. The content for this article was derived, in part, from his ADDitude webinar, “Stop Procrastinating and Get Things Done.”

How to Get Things Done Without Getting Bugged Down

What's keeping you from crossing things off your to-do list? Try these solutions to everyday productivity problems.

Every day we are confronted with infinite social media updates, interruptions, and distractions that feel impossible to ignore, while one thing remains finite—time. Here's how to tackle nine common productivity problems that keep us from getting things done.

1. Too Much Information

Information always comes at us; capturing it is essential—and difficult. We used to say, “Write it down, write it down,” but in the era of too much information, there are better ways to write things down—besides writing on your hand.

If you need to save verbal information, little bits of advice, websites people throw at you, or things you want to remember, call it into your voicemail and leave yourself messages. Your smartphone's voice recorder app can come in handy for this. Another option is to convert verbal information into text using an app like Dragon Dictation, Google Keep (Android, iOS), and Evernote (iOS, Android, Windows, Mac).

2. Too Distracted To Finish

Distractibility and executive function challenges prevent individuals with ADHD from completing chores and tasks. If interruptions—a phone call or a request from your spouse or child—distract you from a task, hold on to a physical artifact (or keep one in your line of sight) to remind you of what you were doing. It will refocus your attention quickly when you return to the task. An unopened envelope may remind you that you were opening mail before being interrupted. Even a blank sticky note will remind you to return to what you were doing before.

3. All Chores Seem the Same—Boring

If you're putting off cleaning out a closet—is there anything more boring?—think about what you'll gain from completing the task. Better yet, write the gains down—reclaiming money you left in those handbags, making the space to see what you own, and getting a tax deduction for donating clothes to charity are all ways to invest yourself in the outcome.

CHAPTER 3: MOTIVATION: OVERCOMING PROCRASTINATION & GETTING THINGS DONE

Consider changing your environment. For example, book a hotel room to do your taxes. You can spread out the receipts and papers on the floor and won't have to worry about the dog trampling over them. You can relax in the pool or use the exercise room during breaks. Maybe you would work better in a quiet place like a library or would prefer the noise of a coffee shop.

4. Ignoring a To-Do List

An old organizational standby is to schedule tasks. This differs from a to-do list, which will only get you so far. Yes, it's important to make a list of tasks to do, but it's equally important to enter your to-do list into your calendar and set a specific date and time for getting stuff done. You have a 40% to 50% chance of doing the tasks on a to-do list, but it's 70% or more if you schedule it.

5. Trouble Starting

Don't get overwhelmed about where or when to start. For example, there is no ideal time to tackle clutter. It doesn't matter where you start; begin at any spot in a room. After you start, continue in some kind of logical order. If you start on the left side of the room, keep going to the left. If you start on the top shelf of a cabinet, work your way down.

6. Paralyzed with Worry

The internal distraction of worry plays more on people with ADHD than on neurotypical people and prevents them from getting things done. To combat this, at the start of the day, do the first three things that worry you the most, to get them off your plate. If you do any part of what is worrying you, you'll break the inertia caused by your anxiety and can keep moving forward.

7. Unable to Prioritize

Just take a shot at prioritizing your tasks. If you use 1s, 2s, and 3s, and that's too narrow, add 4s. If you use A, B, and C, and that's too narrow, add a D. Adding colors is good for setting the priorities of your to-do list. Use yellow, green, and red because we know what those mean.

Create a three-column to-do list. One for "now," another for "soon," and a third labeled "fat chance." "Now" could be this week or within the next two days. Making "now" signify "today" to finish a task is too rigid. "Soon" could mean the end of the week. "Fat chance" could mean "whenever."

8. Missing Deadlines

Schedule extra time to finish a task. Rather than trying to precisely estimate how long a

CHAPTER 3: MOTIVATION: OVERCOMING PROCRASTINATION & GETTING THINGS DONE

task will take, just say, “I’m going to need 30% more time for everything I plan, no matter what.” Just pick a number—20% more, 50%, and allot that. The worst that could happen is that you finish it early.

9. Mail Mismanagement

To cut off junk mail at its source, log on to catalogchoice.org and have them alert marketers to stop sending you stuff. Designate only one place for mail to land, maybe the dining room table. Yes, it piles up quickly, but at least you know where it will be when you decide to tackle it. Don’t open junk mail! It can contain four to seven pieces of paper. Unopened junk mail should go straight into the recycling bin.

This article was written by Judith Kolberg, founder of the Institute for Challenging Disorganization (ICD). The content for this article was derived, in part, from her ADDitude webinar, “ADHD-Friendly Ways to Organize Your Life!”

CHAPTER 3: MOTIVATION: OVERCOMING PROCRASTINATION & GETTING THINGS DONE

Self-Test: How Seriously Do You Procrastinate?

How bad is your tendency to procrastinate? We all put things off, but if procrastination affects your life, the first step is understanding your behavior and ADHD brain.

How do you stop procrastinating? First, assess the situations and ways in which you put things off. Do you procrastinate when you feel overwhelmed? Bored? Unsure of the next steps? Take this self-test to gauge your level of procrastination and get a clearer view of exactly when and how you're most likely to punt.

1. I pay bills at the last minute or after they are due.
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
2. I tend to delay finishing things, even when I know they are important.
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
3. When traveling, I arrive at the airport at the very last moment.
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

CHAPTER 3: MOTIVATION: OVERCOMING PROCRASTINATION & GETTING THINGS DONE

4. I return phone calls days after I received them—or not at all.
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
5. I vow to start earlier but end up shopping for gifts in a last-minute rush.
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
6. When I'm asked to RSVP to an event, I tend to wait rather than respond promptly.
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
7. When I go to bed at night, I am stressed about everything I did not accomplish during the day.
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

CHAPTER 3: MOTIVATION: OVERCOMING PROCRASTINATION & GETTING THINGS DONE

8. I start new projects but often don't finish them.

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

9. I am late to appointments or events.

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

10. Even when I have an important deadline, I start working at the very last minute.

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

11. Important decisions are stressful, so I avoid making them for as long as possible.

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

CHAPTER 3: MOTIVATION: OVERCOMING PROCRASTINATION & GETTING THINGS DONE

12. I have difficulty leaving the house on time in the morning.

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

13. My to-do list contains the same items for days on end. I just don't do them.

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

14. When something important needs to get done, I find less important things to do and waste time.

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

15. I plan to meet friends or attend events at the last minute.

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

CHAPTER 3: MOTIVATION: OVERCOMING PROCRASTINATION & GETTING THINGS DONE

16. When I'm working, I waste time by checking my email or social media sites.

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

Results: Assign the following values to your answers: Very Often (4 points), Often (3 points), Sometimes (2 points), Rarely (1 point), and Never (0 points). The higher your point total, the greater the likelihood you show signs of procrastination. (Maximum value: 64 points)

Note: *This screener is not a diagnostic tool. It is designed to determine whether you demonstrate symptoms of procrastination. If your score is 48-64, that means you answered "Often" or "Very Often" to most of the questions and could benefit from seeing a trained healthcare professional for help with procrastination.*

CHAPTER 3: MOTIVATION: OVERCOMING PROCRASTINATION & GETTING THINGS DONE

What Causes Procrastination? And What Causes It to Stop?

Getting started on a task—particularly a dreadful chore or daunting project—can feel physically and mentally unbearable. Here, *ADDitude* readers share their challenges with motivation, procrastination, and task initiation.

Procrastination is an age-old problem that is amplified in people with ADHD. From executive dysfunction to emotional regulation challenges, ADHD symptoms and traits increase the likelihood that we'll procrastinate and put off tasks—especially ones that tax, tire, bore, or overwhelm our ADHD brains. What's more, those same symptoms and traits create hurdles to overcoming procrastination. Strategy after strategy proves to be no match for ADHD procrastination, according to *ADDitude* readers.

We asked nearly 1,000 attendees during Michele Novotni, Ph.D.'s *ADDitude* webinar, “Which of the following strategies have you tried to combat your procrastination?” Here are the answers they gave:

- Break down tasks into smaller steps: 22.46%
- Create a timeline and/or deadlines: 20.84%
- Rely on external tools (e.g., alarms, productivity apps): 17.41%
- Minimize distractions (e.g., body double, accountability partner): 14.04%
- Reframe negative self-talk: 10.41%
- Use rewards or increase task appeal: 12.05%
- Other: 2.79%

Comments and questions from webinar attendees provided more insights into what causes procrastination, its connection to ADHD, and the strategies that have actually helped combat procrastination:

ADHD Procrastination Cause: Overwhelm

“I live day-to-day with this ‘anxiety fog’ as a result of my procrastination. I may not know specifically what needs to be done, just that I need to do something. This weighs

CHAPTER 3: MOTIVATION: OVERCOMING PROCRASTINATION & GETTING THINGS DONE

on me, creates guilt, and takes away from activities that are supposed to be enjoyable. I realize the ultimate answer is to avoid procrastination—but how?”

“I have a hard time staying motivated to get through my backlog because it’s hard to see a light at the end of the tunnel. **If I finish one task, my ‘reward’ is the next set of tasks. I just want to give up.**”

“My big issue with being overwhelmed is sticking to the small steps. **I look at a big problem, and my eyes glaze over.** I can’t even start.”

“I have a few tasks/projects that are extremely overdue. **The longer I put them off, the harder they are to get done.**”

“I’ve procrastinated on tasks that I’ve dreaded, thinking I can’t do them. But afterward, I realized the task was actually quite easy. Now, when I feel that dread, **I try to remember how I felt when I completed a similar task.**”

“I get frazzled by where to start and how to start. **I overthink the whole process before I even begin.** I feel ashamed that such small things can be utterly paralyzing.”

“**Any task related to money causes me immense stress.** There is a huge mental block between knowing I need to do the task and being able to do it.”

ADHD Procrastination Causes: Paralysis, Decision Fatigue, and Task Initiation Challenges

“**My therapist said I’m ‘frozen.’** As a world-class procrastinator for most of my life (I’m 90), I know I can’t afford to waste time. It’s incredibly precious, and I’ve still got a lot to accomplish. And even though I know this, I am still frozen.”

“I am a graduate student and have difficulty getting started with my (mountains of) reading. **But once I start, time flies by.** What are some ways I can ease the transition?”

“**One person I know lights a candle at her desk to signal, ‘Now, I am working.’** She can take a break when the candle reaches a certain level.”

CHAPTER 3: MOTIVATION: OVERCOMING PROCRASTINATION & GETTING THINGS DONE

“Breaking things down is sometimes more complicated due to decision fatigue and overwhelm. I feel my brain has too little computer ‘RAM’ to consider everything and make a rational decision.”

“If I only had one thing to tackle, I know I could do it, but when there are 20 things, it feels impossible.”

“I am very linear: I can’t start a task until everything else is finished. I also find it hard to break big tasks down into manageable steps. Organizing and completing paperwork is the hardest for me to start.”

“Starting tasks feels infinitely more difficult than finishing them. In physics, static friction is always a greater force than kinetic friction; a still object takes more force to move than an object already in motion.”

ADHD Procrastination Cause: Perfectionism

“Planners, time blocking, reward programs—they didn’t work because they were too loose for my autistic brain, but too regimented for the ADHD part of my brain that felt like a failure when it wasn’t perfect.”

“I have the time to do something, but I am just not ‘ready’ to do it because I don’t feel like I can do it perfectly, so I will wait until I am ‘inspired’ to do it perfectly.”

“I took years to finish undergrad because I saw my final thesis as this insurmountable task that would expose me as a fraud.”

“I am a big fan of the strategy of committing to perform a task poorly, which I discovered when trying to write a report. Just write, I tell myself, even if I know it’s bad. It is much easier to go back and rewrite, as my mind quickly finds a way to make it better.”

“I’m a serial procrastinator. Even before I start a task, I’m convinced that I won’t be able to do something right, or it will take too much time. For example, doing the dishes; I always feel like it will take an hour, when in reality, it usually only takes 10 minutes. Then the sinks get filled and piled on the counter, and it takes half an hour or more.”

CHAPTER 3: MOTIVATION: OVERCOMING PROCRASTINATION & GETTING THINGS DONE

“I’m a bit of a control freak, so I’ve always tried to file my taxes on my own, but after another year of procrastinating until the last possible day, I finally hired an accountant to take care of it.”

“I have a hard time starting a task because I get so overwhelmed when I see what needs to be done. Then **when I get started, my perfectionism kicks in, and it takes forever to finish**. I want to execute the task flawlessly since I know it probably will be a while until I do it again (considering how long it took to get started in the first place).”

ADHD Procrastination Causes: Lack of Motivation and Consistency

“So, I can plan, take baby steps, and all that. **My issue is consistency** on these baby steps every day.”

“I get bright ideas and have the energy to get started on them, **but then the energy dwindles, and it is a fight to continue**. I have to use a reward system to keep myself going.”

“There are lots of great virtual body doubling groups out there. Focusmate.com, for example, allows people to work virtually one-on-one, too. (There is a fee, but they allow you to do a few sessions each week for free.)”

“They’re not for everyone, but **task lists help me tremendously**. The physical act of marking a line through a task on a list is rewarding.”

“Finding the motivation to start something is excruciating. **Hyperfocus helps, but I spend days beating myself up for being behind on tasks**. I’m trying to cut myself some slack and accept that it is just how my brain works, but 54 years of conditioning is hard to reverse!”

“I have trouble getting motivated, especially if it’s for a task that I really don’t want to but have to do. **Most of the time, it’s a self-esteem problem**; I never think I’m good enough, so even if I want to try, I never do because I’m afraid I’ll fail.”

ADHD Procrastination Cause: Distractions

“My phone is a major part of my daily job because I work in social media. It’s also a huge distraction. **I find myself getting stuck in other apps** and not doing my actual work on the phone.”

CHAPTER 3: MOTIVATION: OVERCOMING PROCRASTINATION & GETTING THINGS DONE

“Advice for not going down the **rabbit hole of the Internet** when trying to complete a task?”

“While writing papers, even if I enjoy it, **I end up being distracted by one piece of information and veering off**, and I find it difficult to get back on task/subject.”

“**My main distractions are my own thoughts.** How do I cope with that?”

“My OCD says: ‘Before we start, let’s tidy up our workspace, organize our diary, and get today’s admin out the way.’ My ADHD says: ‘Yes! Let’s tidy up our workspace, but let us also rearrange the bookshelf, de-clutter our cupboards, donate old clothes, do some laundry, feed the dogs, cook lunch, wash the cars, tend to the garden, **worry, think, worry.**’”

“I heard about ‘**anchor points**’ recently, and I think it is a really great method. You pick a very specific task to focus on (e.g., tidying the kitchen sink or bed). When you inevitably get distracted, you remind yourself to return to your anchor point.”

ADHD Procrastination Cause: Implementation Problems

“**I create a beautiful plan or schedule but cannot execute it.** At the end of the day, I go off of intuition. I cannot grow with this method. Ritalin doesn’t help anymore.”

“I know many of these [procrastination] strategies and interventions, but **my ADHD brain has so much trouble implementing them.** It’s a real conundrum.”

“Does **anyone else deal with ‘rebellion’** from the plans or structure that they create for themselves?”

ADHD Procrastination Cause: Getting Lost in the Weeds

“I’ve tried to break tasks down and create timelines, but then **I get bogged down in setting out the timeline in too much detail!**”

“I become overly obsessed with getting every detail to the point where that ends up taking all the time. **It’s like the Hydra—every time you cut off a head, a new one grows.**”

“What do you do when you have **ADHD and OCD and you hyperfocus on small details**—font size, heading numbering, etc.—instead of the content?”

CHAPTER 3: MOTIVATION: OVERCOMING PROCRASTINATION & GETTING THINGS DONE

“I’ve been using Google Assistant to help keep me on track and cognizant of when a task needs to start and finish.”

ADHD Procrastination Cause: “I Work Better Under Pressure”

“Many of my college clients complain that they just aren’t motivated to start a paper or project until the due date is near. **That’s when they rush to get it done.** Most of them get As or Bs, so the cycle continues.”

“Historically, **my most productive workdays were the three to four days before I left for vacation.** Amazing how many things got done.”

“A deadline *I* set does not help. **I do not have the same sense of urgency for my own deadlines.**”

“**I get it done under pressure, but I feel exhausted afterward,** and, of course, that doesn’t make me feel productive or responsible.”

“I have real difficulty starting mundane tasks, like dishes, laundry, etc. Exciting tasks, like writing an interesting paper or painting a portrait, are daunting too. **I need to be up against a deadline,** and I always procrastinate until the very last minute.”

ADHD Procrastination Causes: Lack of Clarity and Time-Estimation Challenges

“**I am bad at estimating my time for a task.** It discourages me after I go over the time frame I initially set and compare it to how long I took.”

“**My procrastination can manifest as the false belief** that I’ve got lots of time, even when it’s not true.”

“I know what needs to be done, **but can’t figure which to do first,** so I do nothing.”

ADHD Procrastination Cause: Boredom

“**How can I maintain motivation when something stops feeling like a novelty** and isn’t urgent (like cleaning out a room or any other necessary long-term project)?”

CHAPTER 3: MOTIVATION: OVERCOMING PROCRASTINATION & GETTING THINGS DONE

“Because I procrastinate on paying bills, submitting medical invoices, and other paperwork, procrastinating is actually costing me money because I do what I enjoy first instead of what is tedious, but earns me money. **How can I be best inspired to do what I hate first?**”

“If I approach a task calmly, **it helps me settle into a process, especially with routine, mundane things.** This makes a task tolerable, if not enjoyable.”

“**I avoided opening all my snail mail** for a few months by putting the letters in a drawer until I got a letter stating I would have to go to court if I didn’t pay a bill. Following this, I contacted all my billers and requested paperless billing.”

Expert Q&As with Timothy A. Pychyl, Ph.D.

Q: “I am fraught with guilt and shame when procrastinating. How can I stop feeling this way?”

Guilt and shame are closely tied to procrastination, and many people struggle with these feelings when they choose to delay tasks.

Choice is key here. Procrastination is troubling because we recognize that we have decided to delay a task that must be done and expect that the delay will be costly. That is what makes procrastination a deeply existential issue—it is ultimately about choosing not to live the life we want. Sometimes, this realization alone sobers us right up.

Mindfulness is hugely important to overcome procrastination and its accompanying feelings of guilt and shame. Mindfulness helps us develop a non-judgmental awareness of the emotions that crop up when we face various tasks, which helps us cope with them. If you feel overwhelmed at the thought of doing a task, you might say to yourself, “I’ll come back to this when I don’t feel so overwhelmed,” and procrastinate. But, if you take a non-judgmental stance, you might say, “Isn’t it amazing how overwhelmed I feel right now?” We’re less likely to react with avoidance when we acknowledge our negative emotions without judgment.

Mindfulness teaches us that we can have an emotion but need not be that emotion. Mindfulness shows that negative emotions and accompanying thoughts will pass, as all thoughts and emotions do. Mindfulness also builds attentional and emotion-regulation skills, which may help relieve ADHD symptoms.

Self-compassion is also important. We won’t always avoid procrastination, but we must forgive ourselves when we do not meet our expectations or intentions. In fact, we’re more likely to try harder at the next opportunity when we practice self-forgiveness.

The next time procrastination and its negative thoughts come around, acknowledge them, but know that you do not have to react to them. You can choose to respond as intended. That is how you will begin to take ownership of your life and overcome procrastination.

Q: “All the joy is in planning. Then my motivation evaporates. Why?”

Beginnings are exciting because they hold so much promise. For many people, beginnings are the best part of any process. Our options are open, and we feel creative and optimistic. It’s the middle and end that cause trouble.

In thinking about the beginning, middle, and end of our projects, researchers define three key stages: inception, planning, and action. The issue you describe relates to the action stage of projects, which is much different than the earlier planning stage.

Research shows that meaning is needed to carry out the early stages of a project. A lack of meaning at a task's inception or planning stage makes the task aversive and hinders engagement. However, brainstorming and planning will not be a chore if a project is meaningful and enjoyable.

In contrast, once we get to the action phase of a project, meaning is no longer the main driver of forward momentum or the defining feature of task aversion. Structure is. Uncertainty around structure and how to carry out the project fuels procrastination. Could it be that you feel immobilized when you get to a project's action phase because you're not sure of its next steps?

If you do have a sense of structure for the project, your loss of motivation might be related to overwhelming and negative feelings around seeing it through. That avoidance becomes procrastination. Sometimes, these emotions—frustration, anxiety, and self-doubt—only come out when the “rubber hits the road.” So even if you have a plan of action, you have to be ready to deal with the inevitable resistance—the “I don't want to” feelings. Several strategies—from setting effective intentions to practicing self-compassion—can help you carry on despite these uncomfortable feelings.

It is also important to understand the difference between procrastination—characterized by avoidance as a coping strategy—and other forms of delay. With ADHD especially, needless delay could come from symptoms of inattention, like disorganization and forgetfulness, that make it difficult to prioritize and create structure around projects. Understanding why you're experiencing unwanted delays in your life is crucial to adopting an appropriate strategy for more timely and effective goal pursuit.

The content for this article was derived, in part, from the ADDitude webinar, “Stop Procrastinating and Get Things Done,” with Timothy Pynchyl, Ph.D.

“The Sweet Spot of Procrastination”

By Stacey Turis

I procrastinate a lot. I don't tell you that with shame, just as I don't apologize for the color of my eyes. I was given what I was given: brown.

In college, I rebelled and covered my trusty browns with gray contacts to use my blue-eyed friend's ID to get into bars. I also thought that gray made me look exotic. Note: People with ADHD should not be allowed to stick anything in their eyeballs that requires insertion and extraction consistently. Sometimes, I left the contacts in for days; sometimes, my eyelashes karate chopped my attempts at shoving them back in, and more than once, I rocked one gray eye and one brown, acting like I was born with some magical eye mutation.

No matter how hard I may have wished for gray eyes or blue eyes or green eyes or cat eyes, at the end of the day, they still came out brown, so I decided to work with what I have.

That's how I approach procrastination—not as a character flaw but as a tool in my trusty ADHD toolbox. You have to know how to manage it, instead of letting it manage you. I call it working the sweet spot—when you've left enough space in the deadline that you aren't killing yourself with stress, but that it is close enough to get your brain's attention and participation.

Sometimes finding the sweet spot is tough, though. Sometimes you don't have time to find the sweet spot, and you just need to get your crap taken care of. With ADHD brains, our challenges lie mostly in getting things started. Once we get past our own mental paralysis, we kick some serious butt. And once we start accomplishing something, we get that little dopamine reward from our brain, which feels good and makes us want to accomplish more. Here are a few ways to achieve that natural high and get your crap done.

Take the three suckiest items with the shortest completion time from your to-do list and do them. Commit to only three things, and you take some of the pressure out of the equation to conquer your whole list. I hear you saying: “Stacey, I have 27 items on my to-do list, and they all need to be done today.” I laugh and say, “Stop tricking yourself. You won't complete 27 items, and if you overwhelm yourself with unrealistic expectations, you'll shut down and won't complete one item. Three checks off your list are better than none.”

Set your timer for free time. When I'm working on something I'm not engaged with, I fight the constant need to get up and attend to random and unnecessary things around the house, like making sun tea or straightening the pillows on the hammock. I eliminate that pressure when I set the timer on my phone for an hour

of work, which I'll follow with 10 minutes of free time. At least, I tell myself that. Most of the time, when the hour is up, I don't want to stop, so I keep working and that free time is just pie in the sky that keeps my brain from feeling like someone has her thumb pressed on it.

Work with your natural rhythms. Morning person, night person, we love to categorize things and judge them as good or bad. I know many night people who feel guilty because they're less productive in the morning, which society deems to be the only acceptable time frame for productivity. Thank goodness that's not the case. We'd all be in big trouble if the fire, police stations, and hospitals had banking hours. Go with your own flow.

Finally, stop looking at your damn phone. There is nothing less productive than being so tied to your phone that you have to interrupt yourself every three minutes to check your (insert social media preference here). Give yourself a break from your phone daily. There is a danger of using it to disconnect and escape from your environment, emotional engagement, and responsibilities. The phone is one of the biggest threats to productivity and personal connection.

Learning how to sit with yourself and others and how to be fully present in your life are beautiful techniques that can help you become more grounded, productive, and free-spirited in your endeavors—whether following a passion or attending to the boring, everyday stuff.

Stacey Turis is an ADDitude contributor and the author of Here's to Not Catching Our Hair on Fire.

“A 12-Step Program for Procrastination”

By Jason Thomas, L.E.P.

As a mental health professional, one of the biggest challenges I see in my patients is procrastination. Everyone procrastinates, including myself. One of my shortcomings is folding laundry. I'll take one article of clothing out of a packed dryer and shut the door rather than fold a whole load. As you can imagine, this makes my wife's head explode.

Procrastination is annoying, but the problem is larger than that: The more we do it, the more habitual and tough it is to break the procrastination habit. Charles Duhigg, the Pulitzer Prize-winning reporter and author of books on productivity, explains that habits are formed and reinforced with a predictable pattern: Cue, routine, reward. It may look something like this:

- Cue: Sitting in front of my computer thinking about writing my report.
- Routine: Watch videos on YouTube instead.
- Reward: Anxiety is reduced in the moment (key words being ‘in the moment’). I will probably feel worse about neglecting to do my report later, but that doesn't really enter the equation in the present.

Habits can follow a similar pattern. For example:

- Cue: Feeling insecure in a social setting.
- Routine: Going for a drink.
- Reward: Feeling better in the moment.

While the effects of drug or alcohol abuse are more immediate and life-threatening, for sure, chronic procrastination can result in painful consequences with poor work performance, lost opportunities, and/or health concerns. Piers Steel, who teaches human resources and organizational dynamics at the University of Calgary, suggests one way to stop procrastinating is to follow what people do in recovery with their particular vice—putting off one thing after another for days, even weeks before pulling it together.

As someone in recovery, I can relate to this approach and often use it when working with teens with ADHD. The 12 steps were originally developed to treat alcoholism and have been adapted over the years to successfully address a wide range of issues such as Al-Anon (family and friends of alcoholics), Gamblers Anonymous, Nicotine Anonymous, Narcotics Anonymous, Overeaters Anonymous, etc. The language of the 12 steps may not directly apply to the chronic delaying of tasks, but the general themes can be helpful. I use these themes as a framework for breaking a bad procrastination habit.

Group 1 (Steps 1-3): Theme—Honesty, Hope, and Faith

This is where we admit we have a problem with procrastination, admit it's causing major difficulties in our lives, and become willing to accept help.

Actions:

- Identify the problems procrastination causes.
- Identify the ways you have tried to manage your procrastination in the past and decide if these really worked (Hint: Would you be reading this if they did?).
- Play the tape out to the end: If you continue procrastinating, what future problems do you see happening?
- Write a new happier ending: How might things be different for you if you change your procrastination habit?
- Become willing: Are you willing to try a new approach to combating your procrastination?
- Ask for and accept help: Are you willing to accept help with your procrastination?

Group 2 (Steps 4-7): Theme—Courage, Integrity, Willingness, and Humility

This is where we explore our procrastination habits and why they occur. We also discuss this with another person and begin to act to change problematic behavior patterns.

Actions:

Make a list of common things you put off.

- What feels unfair or annoying about each of these things?
- How do the above feelings impact you?
- What parts of these situations are you responsible for, and what parts are out of your control?
- Can you accept the things that are not under your control and take responsibility for those things that are under your control?

Now look over your list and identify your common patterns of behavior and triggers that lead to procrastination.

- What are your cues to begin procrastinating? These might be your location, time of day, your emotional state, particular people around you, or what you did right before you started procrastinating.
- What is your common procrastination routine? For example, I start watching YouTube videos or look at social media.

- What is my immediate reward for procrastinating? For example, I avoid writing that difficult report and immediately feel better.
- Now that you have a better idea of the cue, routine, and reward, introduce changes to that pattern. For example, if I know my cue is to turn on my computer in my office to start paying online bills, I can move my computer to the dining room table or perhaps go to a coffee shop (location change).
- Discuss what you have discovered about your procrastination habit and your plan for change with a trusted person. Choosing a non-judgmental adult, such as a relative, mentor, or mental health professional, is best.
- Many people seek a professional to help them break their procrastination habit and learn additional strategies.

Group 3 (Steps 8-9): Theme—Self-Discipline and Forgiveness

Here, we take responsibility for the negative impact of our procrastination—on ourselves and others—and try to make it right. This phase really is about forgiveness and releasing shame.

Actions:

- Make a list of people (including yourself) your procrastination has negatively impacted and note how. For example, *Jenny, because I didn't finish my part of the group project in time, and our boss reprimanded us. Or myself, because I missed the window to return an item of clothes that don't fit and now I can't get a refund.*
- Take steps to fix the situation caused by your procrastination. This might be taking some corrective action or simply apologizing and committing to do better in the future.

Group 4 (Steps 10-12): Theme—Perseverance, Spiritual Awareness, and Service

This is the maintenance phase of combating procrastination, through monitoring our behavior, aligning with our values, and acting in ways that serve others.

Actions:

- Now that you are on your way to breaking your procrastination habit, you will want to stay vigilant. Monitor your procrastination behavior and promptly correct the situation with yourself and others whenever you slip.
- Identify your personal values and live by those daily.
- Try meditating every day. Even if it's for five minutes or less. This will help strengthen your ability to monitor behavior and regulate the emotions that drive procrastination.

- Use your new behavior patterns to help others in small and large ways, and where appropriate, share what you have learned about combating procrastination with others.

One of the key missing components traditionally found in a 12-step program is frequent social support. As such, you may find it helpful to buddy up with someone who also struggles with procrastination so that you can support each other's efforts toward positive change.

While some tasks will inevitably be avoided or delayed occasionally, you do not have to go down the slippery slope into a procrastination bender. And if you do find yourself on a bender, try not to judge yourself too harshly. As they say in recovery, *"We strive for progress not perfection."* Once you notice you're delaying, jump back into Step One again and resolve to break the procrastination habit. Or, as my wife likes to say, "Just get back in there and fold the whole load, please."

Jason Thomas, L.E.P., is a licensed educational psychologist and mindfulness teacher living in Los Angeles.

“Stop. Procrastinating. Now.”

By Gretchen Rubin

How many times a day do you try to work yourself up to tackle some undesirable task? If you're like me—several. Nothing is more exhausting than a task that is never started, so I've come up with some tricks to stop procrastinating and prod myself to get moving:

1. Put yourself in jail. If I feel pressure to jump in and finish something in a rush, and therefore can't bear to start, sometimes I pretend to put myself in jail. If you're in jail, you have all the time in the world. There is no reason to hurry, no reason to cut corners, or to try to do too many things at once. You can slow down and concentrate.

2. Ask for help. This is one of my most useful Secrets of Adulthood. Why is this so hard? I have no idea. But whenever I have trouble getting started because I don't know exactly what to do, I ask for help. I'm amazed at how much help I get.

3. Remember that most decisions don't require extensive research. I often get paralyzed by my inability to make a decision, but by reminding myself that one choice isn't much different from another choice, I can get started. Also, I try to identify a knowledgeable person and follow whatever that person does.

4. Take a small first step. If you feel dismayed at the prospect of a chain of awful tasks that you have to accomplish, just take one step today. Tomorrow, take the next step. The forward motion is encouraging; before long, you'll see yourself speeding toward completion.

5. Suffer for 15 minutes. You can do anything for 15 minutes, and 15 minutes, day after day, adds up surprisingly fast. That's how I finally dug myself out of a crushing (if virtual) load of digital photos. Fifteen minutes at a time.

6. Do it first thing in the morning. The night before, vow to do the dreaded task. Get everything ready—any phone numbers or information you need, files assembled, everything ready to go. And the next day, at the first possible moment, just do it. Don't allow yourself to reflect or procrastinate. This is particularly true of exercise. If you're tempted to skip, try to work out in the morning.

7. Protect yourself from interruption. How often have you finally steeled yourself to start some difficult project, only to be interrupted the minute you get going? This makes a hard task harder. Carve out time to work.

8. Remember, work is one of the most pernicious forms of procrastination. Pay attention to the amount of time you spend working on tasks you dislike. If you feel your life consists of going from one dreaded chore to the next, you might be better

off figuring out a way to avoid some tasks. You're unlikely to be happy or successful when every aspect of your life or job is a big drag. Don't accuse yourself of being lazy or a procrastinator, but ask, "What's making this so difficult?"

On the other hand, novelty and challenge, as uncomfortable as they may be, do bring happiness. The chore that feels onerous today may give you a huge boost of satisfaction tomorrow when it's behind you. It's good to keep that in mind.

Gretchen Rubin is a podcast host and author of The Four Tendencies, The Happiness Project, and Better Than Before.

“I Am an Excellent Starter. The Trouble Is Finishing.”

By Jill Finnessy

I am an excellent starter. The trouble is I am not much of a finisher.

In the nooks and crannies of my house, you can find any number of creative projects I’ve begun with vim and vigor. I have a stack of unfinished books on my nightstand. My desk is filled with thank you notes I wrote months ago, brimming with warm sentiments of gratitude that will never reach the intended recipients. I have a plantless planter in my dining room, a box of frames that sit pictureless, and a slew of half-written articles and stories lingering lifeless in the abyss of my laptop.

I lose steam before I get to the finish line. I’m running out of juice for this blog post right now. I’m thinking of closing my laptop and folding laundry while I watch the rest of *60 Minutes*. I could at least finish that.

If it’s not about losing steam, it’s about memory. Unless I’ve explicitly written it down or left it lying out to see, I will completely forget what I was working on the day before, not to mention weeks or months before.

At 42 years old, I have given up on so many wonderful ideas. It’s hard not to give up on myself sometimes, too—especially when my cynical inner voice says, “Oh, you think that’s a good idea? Don’t kid yourself. You’ll never finish it.”

Beginnings are delicious and full of excitement. But there is no real satisfaction without completion. I want a finished product, a publication, the glory of a checklist full of checkmarks. But with an ADHD brain that struggles with poor working memory, extended focus, and slogging through the mundane, it’s challenging to get to The End of anything.

To be clear, it’s not like I don’t know what completion looks like. In fact, I hadn’t realized that I had developed tricks to get to the end zone over the years until I started teaching them to my son, who also has ADHD.

5 Tips to Finish What You Start

1. Outsource your brain. Life requires a lot of upkeep, thought, and mental planning. Trying to keep it all in your head won’t work. (And ADHD doesn’t help.) So use calendars, lists, alarms, reminders, and other external tools to help free up your brain space and organize your time around what you want to accomplish.

2. Say no frequently and without guilt. Say it with me: I do not need to be on that committee. I do not need to complete that Airbnb review. I do not need to make the meatballs from scratch.

3. Set up a track-and-reward system. I hate keeping sticker charts for my kids (add them to the list of things I start but never finish), but there's something incredibly satisfying about checking a box and reaping the reward. While I don't have an actual sticker chart for myself, I do keep a weekly list of to-dos that I check off as I complete. The more checkmarks I gather, the closer I am to a cookie break or a show on the couch.

4. Make time your benchmark. Some projects are lengthy, lasting days, weeks, or months. Give yourself credit for the time you dedicate to a project on a given day, even if it's just a few minutes. I did not finish writing this blog post in one day, but I did spend an hour working on it. Time to watch Netflix and eat chips and salsa.

5. Forgive thyself. I am not maliciously forgetting the coupon envelope when I go shopping. Could I have set a reminder to defrost the chicken the night before? Yes. But can I turn back time? Nope. Breakfast for dinner it is!

Beginnings are beautiful, hopeful, and bursting with potential. But when too many beginnings pile up, we feel their unfinished presence like a stack of unpaid bills, gnawing at us, taunting us, and reminding us that we lack follow-through.

Sometimes we need to appreciate beginnings for what they are: Tiny experiments that can fizzle out or blow up in our faces. That does not mean that we failed.

It's a balancing act between self-discipline and self-forgiveness. I have to trust that if it's important, it won't let me abandon it; the unfinished task will call me back and make me find time for it. And if it doesn't call me back, then maybe it was only meant to be a beginning—a step towards something else more worthy of a sticker and a well-earned reward.

Jill Finnessy is a freelance writer and mother of three boys. She has taught high school and college level English and is currently a University Supervisor for student teachers.

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CHAPTER 4

Prioritization & Planning: Tackling Indecision, Time Blindness, and To-Do Lists

Chapter 4: Prioritization & Planning: Tackling Indecision, Time Blindness, and To-Do Lists

How ADHD Warps Time Perception: Strategies to Stop Wasting and Start Managing Time

By Ari Tuckman, Psy.D.

“Lost time is never found again.”—Benjamin Franklin

No one knows this better than someone with ADHD, who may lose, mismanage, underestimate, squander, and search for time daily. After all, warped time perception is a core facet of ADHD.

That translates into poor time management in the moment, and problems organizing toward the future. It means perpetually wasting precious time, falling into unpredictable hyperfocus, and turning your back on that onerous task—again. For various reasons, ADHD minds struggle to “see” time and “feel” the future. As such, the most useful time-management strategies for ADHD brains make time salient to the mind’s eye and pull the future into the present, which is felt the most.

Looking at ADHD as being about the use of time will change how you understand and manage it.

Why Time Management Eludes ADHD Brains

Time Management Requires Attention Management

Effective time management prioritizes future goals over present needs or wants. It charts daily steps that predictably and reliably lead the way toward a desired destination.

As such, solid time management requires attention management—a defining difficulty of ADHD. It also demands dynamic attention regulation, wherein our attention shifts fluidly and frequently based on how it relates to our goals.

On one end of the attention regulation spectrum is difficulty resisting distractions. Phone notifications, random (and ill-timed) down-the-rabbit-hole Internet searches, and other distractions work hard to hijack our attention from the task at hand. To resist immediate bits of stimulation and maintain focus on future goals, we need to practice potent response inhibition—another skill affected by ADHD.

At the other end of the attention regulation spectrum is hyperfocus, wherein intense absorption in a task becomes a type of distraction in itself—one that causes time to fall by the wayside. The antidote to unproductive or unhealthy hyperfocus is constant internal monitoring—*“Do I keep my attention on what I’m doing, or do I shift to something else?”* But this self-awareness, too, is impaired by ADHD.

ADHD Minds Are Trapped in Now

Our individual time horizons determine the proximity of a task or event before we act on it. (In other words, how close in time must a deadline be to hit your mental radar? A week? A day? Twenty minutes ago?) Generally, the closer a task is in time, the easier it is to pay attention. We won’t pay as much attention to a task that is further out in the future.

ADHD time horizons are typically shorter than those of neurotypical people. Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D., noted that for people with ADHD, time is all but split into two parts: the “now” (what’s on our radar) and the “not now” (what’s beyond our radar).

According to Dr. Barkley, this relationship with time causes “myopia to impending future events.” In other words, planning feels impossible for people with ADHD because they don’t see the future as clearly. They take action toward a future goal (the not now) only when that distant goal moves into the present (the now). By then, frantic scrambling is often required to finish the task before it’s too late, much to the stress of others who see the future sooner.

ADHD and Temporal Discounting

If short time horizons explain why people with ADHD can’t “see” the future, temporal discounting explains why they can’t “feel” it.

Temporal discounting is why so many of us, ADHD or not, struggle to delay gratification. We delay a restful night’s sleep to squeeze in a few more episodes of an exciting show. We delay starting on a project, knowing it will mean stress, cramming, and all-nighters later on. We pass on healthy habits, even if we know those habits will serve us in the future.

It's hard not to select immediate payoffs over delayed rewards of greater value. That's because we generally “feel” the present more than we feel the future. The pleasures of the moment outweigh the pain of the future.

That feeling is multiplied in ADHD brains. “Now” is a siren song that tempts people with ADHD to maximize the moment, future costs be damned. The pain or pleasure of the present is felt even more strongly than is the pain or pleasure of the future—until the moment of reckoning comes.

Temporal discounting helps to explain why ADHD is so often thought of as a performance disorder. Knowing what to do is the easy part. The hard part is turning intention into action, which requires feeling the future more fully and being motivated by it to sacrifice in the present.

How to “See” Time and “Feel” the Future: Time Management Solutions for ADHD

Time blindness, short time horizons, and greater temporal discounting work together to shine a spotlight on “now” and hide “tomorrow” in the shadows. Organizing toward the future is difficult when it's nowhere to be seen.

Follow these time-management strategies—with intention—to help manage attention, dislodge from the present, and stretch your time horizons to feel the future.

To Manage ADHD Attention

Reduce Temptations

Every interruption is like a roll of the dice—you never know if you'll be able to get back on track. Sheer willpower is too unreliable to resist these time-wasting distractions; you need rules and systems. If you're tempted to check social media during your workday, for example, keep your phone away from you, or at least on silent mode. Make use of web-blocking tools to take willpower out of the equation.

Make the Right Stuff Stand Out

As you preemptively reduce and eliminate distractions, elevate the tasks that need your focus.

Don't Rely on Your Internal Clock

People with ADHD don't understand time as clearly as they should—*What's due when? How long will that task take? How long have I been doing this task?* Is it time to leave yet? But that's OK, if you supplement internal abilities with external tools, beginning with plenty of clocks within easy eye-shot.

Analog clocks are best because they make the passage of time more visible. Make an intentional choice to look at those clocks and think about what time means—*Should I keep doing what I am doing? Is it time to do something else?* Success starts with self-awareness, but it requires intention.

Consistently Use a Planning Tool That Works for You

I often recommend that my clients put to-do list items into their schedules. Tasks tend to languish on to-do lists (“Is now the time to do that?”). By planning to take action at an actual time, you are more likely to do a task and less likely to merely react to whatever comes at you during the day.

Scheduling tasks also allows you to see the big picture: the time you have in the day and the tasks beginning to fill that time, reducing overcommitment. Block out chunks of time for each task rather than having a list of tasks to be completed. If circumstances change or something isn’t completed, no big deal—move it to somewhere else on your schedule.

As you add information to your planning tool, include important information pertinent to each task or event—like addresses, phone numbers, and video conferencing passwords—your future self will thank you. Set reminders on your phone or use a simple kitchen timer (sprinkle them liberally throughout your house or job).

Remember, schedules are not blood oaths. If the stars don’t align, you can always move the task later. Also, don’t over-commit if you’re unsure where to sneak a task into your schedule, as this will only lead to hesitation and anxiety. Remind yourself of your future self to increase motivation to accomplish your goals within a specific time frame.

Your schedule is for you and you alone. Your schedule is supposed to help you accomplish more of what you want to do. Being forced to use a planning tool (even the impression alone) kills the motivation to use it. Knowing that the schedule is for *you* might motivate you to stay consistent.

Whether you use a digital calendar, productivity app, or paper planner, the best scheduling system is the one you use consistently. The more you use a system, the better it works. Even partial usage leads to tangible benefits.

To Feel the Future

Engineer Consequences

Temporal discounting elongates the space between action and consequence. That’s why waiting for natural consequences—far off on the horizon—doesn’t work for people with ADHD. Rig the system by shortening the space between the present and the future.

- **Make consequences immediate** to increase motivation to act on tasks and adhere to your plans.
- **Make rules for yourself**, e.g., “I can’t watch my favorite show until I spend at least 30 minutes paying bills.”
- **Make consequences frequent.** One-on-one check-ins with your boss every other day rather than weekly, for example, might help you stay on track and increase productivity. Cater to your boss’s self-interest (you will hit their deadlines) to increase buy-in.
- **Externalize consequences.** Aim for salient consequences that you will actually feel. For example, tell your friend that dinner is on you if you’re more than 10 minutes late to meet them.

Pause and Picture

You can compensate for temporal discounting by pausing to visualize how you will feel in the future if you do (or don’t) act now.

- **Picture consequences as vividly as possible.** Ask yourself: “How will I feel during the big work meeting a week from now if I don’t give myself sufficient time to prepare? Worried? Ashamed?”
- **Lay out the pros and cons of action and inaction**, e.g., “If I wait until the eleventh hour to get this done, I risk losing time with my family or a restful night’s sleep.”
- **Think of yourself in two forms: present-you and future-you.** How does the latter feel about the former? “Do I want to do this now?” is the wrong question because the answer is always the same. (“No, I don’t want to do this.”) The task will never be appealing whether it’s far away or due ASAP. That’s why it’s better to consider how future-you will feel based on present-you decisions.

The content for this article was derived, in part, from the ADDitude webinar, “Why Is Time So Slippery? Understanding Time Blindness in People with ADHD,” with Ari Tuckman, Psy.D.

CHAPTER 4: PRIORITIZATION & PLANNING: TACKLING INDECISION, TIME BLINDNESS, AND TO-DO LISTS

We Don't See Time; We Feel It

Always late? People with ADHD experience time differently—and lose track of it easily. Here's how you can improve your sense of time without losing who you are.

Our internal clocks weren't put together by a Swiss watchmaker who sees time as a series of seconds and minutes, one coming precisely after the other. Some experts think that individuals with ADHD perceive time not as a sequence but as a diffuse collection of events that are viscerally connected to the people, activities, and emotions involved in them.

Several problem behaviors result from our novel perception of time:

- procrastination
- missing deadlines
- doing things in the wrong order
- underestimating the time it takes to do tasks

The good news is that there are exercises and strategies that can improve our sense of time. You can avoid time lapses in your life, as these three adults with ADHD did.

No Structure at Home

Problem: Susan tried to plan her life at home, but things went wrong because she couldn't estimate how long tasks took.

Solution: We started by playing a guessing game to improve her ability to estimate how long activities took to complete. She bought a stopwatch/timer and wore it around her neck. Then she estimated how long it would take to perform certain tasks at home and at work.

If the timer went off before she finished, she set the stopwatch to record how long the task took above her original estimate. After a week of doing this, she discovered a pattern, which helped her plan better. Her estimation of projects at work was usually accurate, but she underestimated tasks at home. When her time was her own, mostly at home, decision-making and prioritizing interfered with her ability to plan well. Her tasks at work were routine and didn't require decision-making or prioritizing. Structure at work kept her on track, and lack of structure at home threw her off.

CHAPTER 4: PRIORITIZATION & PLANNING: TACKLING INDECISION, TIME BLINDNESS, AND TO-DO LISTS

So Susan created more structure on the home front. She outlined a routine to handle basic household chores before preparing dinner every night. She streamlined her weekend structure by slotting chores and recreational activities into her Saturday schedule. She gave herself Sunday off.

Problem: For Jill, time felt anything but linear. “In my brain, everything’s either now or not now.”

Solution: Jill began to break down her day into a beginning, middle, and end. She listed what she usually did during the day and assigned each task to one of five slots:

1. Morning Wake-Up
2. Morning Work
3. Afternoon Work
4. Evening Personal
5. Bedtime

Tasks that required the most focus were done in the Morning Work slot, and those that required the least were done in the Afternoon Work slot. By doing the same types of things at about the same time each day, Jill gradually began to feel that her days did have a beginning, a middle, and an end.

When she found herself distracted by personal tasks at work, she’d say, “Oops, this is not the time to do this. These things should be done in the Evening Personal slot. I can do them when I get home from work.” She saw her day as a progression of events, which improved her sense of time. Planning things became less confusing when she separated her to-do list into personal and work chores. Her day became more linear.

Losing Track of the Minutes

Problem: Gerry loses track of time during transitions from one activity to another, especially at work.

Solution: I asked Gerry to tell me what kept him from getting up and leaving. “I turn off my computer, get ready to leave, and when I get into the car, I look at the dashboard clock in horror, realizing I am already late for dinner,” Gerry says. After looking at his departure

CHAPTER 4: PRIORITIZATION & PLANNING: TACKLING INDECISION, TIME BLINDNESS, AND TO-DO LISTS

in more detail, he realized that, on his way out, he talked with colleagues about a baseball game or updated someone about an unimportant matter. In Gerry's mind, these chats would take only a couple of minutes, but they turned into a half-hour.

Gerry's family eats dinner at 6 p.m., so he must leave work at 5:30 p.m. to be home on time. To do this, he set his computer alarm for 4:45 p.m. and 5 p.m., giving himself 15 minutes to wrap things up, and then a half-hour of wiggle room before leaving for home. On hectic days, he uses the half-hour to talk with supervisors and coworkers about project details. On calmer days, he makes it home a half-hour early to help cook dinner and play with his kids.

Gerry sets his watch alarm to make sure he doesn't miss his 5:30 p.m. deadline. When the alarm goes off, Gerry raises his hand and says, "Gotta get home for dinner! I'll catch you tomorrow."

This article was written by Sandy Maynard.

Wasting Time on Social Media? Six Ways to Stop Doomscrolling

For individuals with ADHD, the lure of the Internet and social media are especially difficult to resist, thanks to traits like impulsivity, hyperfocus, and time blindness. To avoid wasting time on screens, move intentionally—not as a passive observer.

Are you wasting time on social media? Do you lose hours upon hours of your time aimlessly doomscrolling and rotating through social media apps? Does the Internet regularly suck you in to a timeless abyss?

You are not alone. Social media is designed to addict, entertain, provide immediate feedback, and deliver dopamine hits in response to every tap and click.

The online world's addictive nature is also why so many people, especially those who struggle with mental health issues, purposely or accidentally get lost in it to avoid uncomfortable feelings like loneliness, anxiety, and boredom. For individuals with ADHD, the lure of the Internet and social media are especially difficult to resist, thanks in large part to traits like impulsivity, hyperfocus, and time blindness.

To avoid wasting time on screens, act with intention, instead of being a passive observer. The six Ls can help you find balance and become more deliberate with your screen time.

1. Learn

Before going online or turning to a social media app, define what you want to get from that particular experience. Ask yourself: *What do I want to learn?* Determine a goal before you engage to avoid impulsive and/or passive scrolling for hours. Consider writing down your specific goal or question before you connect as a visual reminder of your purpose.

2. Later

Similarly, actively think “later” when tempted to fall into the rabbit hole of an unrelated Internet search or social media side quest. If something else tries to distract your attention from your intended goal, ask yourself: *Is this important, or can it wait?* Bookmark the page, save the post or the video to your Favorites. Then, in a future online session, review that link to learn that information.

CHAPTER 4: PRIORITIZATION & PLANNING: TACKLING INDECISION, TIME BLINDNESS, AND TO-DO LISTS

3. Lessen the Lures

Social media apps (and the Internet) are designed to attract and retain your attention. To escape their trap, try the following:

- Disable notifications for most apps on your phone and computer.
- Avoid following or subscribing to too many social media accounts and profiles to limit notifications.
- Make sure to enable a pop-up blocker on your computer and phone.
- Keep your browser windows small to cut off distracting visuals (like ads) and links.

4. Limits

Limiting your online/social media use is probably the toughest of the Ls to implement, but it's the most crucial. (The Internet won't set limits for you, though there are apps and programs on browsers and devices designed to limit screen time or block access to certain websites.)

- Decide how much time you'll spend online. (It's best to set and follow consistent daily social media/Internet time limits.)
- Set a timer every time you go online. Try to set a timer on a device other than the one in use, and physically place the device a distance away. That way, you'll have to interrupt your Internet use to turn off the alarm. If the idea of a timer doesn't work for you, try creating a playlist timed to your allotted screen time use. You'll know your time has ended when the music stops.
- Consider how many platforms and websites you will allow yourself to use during your time online—another way to add intention to your Internet use.

5. Lump

Try to lump all your screen time use into one time of day. Perhaps screen time could be a reward once you've wrapped up work or have completed tasks and chores. Or maybe you'll only allow yourself to scroll through social media while you are exercising on a stationary bike or walking. Either way, avoid scheduling these time blocks first or last in your day, as the light from screens could interfere with your sleep-wake patterns.

CHAPTER 4: PRIORITIZATION & PLANNING: TACKLING INDECISION, TIME BLINDNESS, AND TO-DO LISTS

6. Leave It

Take a vacation from the Internet by unplugging for at least a full day each month. Fully stepping away from social media and screens can help you recognize other activities in your life that are beneficial and rejuvenating. Make sure to reconnect with others and with yourself when you disconnect from the Internet.

This article was written by Mareen Dennis, MA, LPP, a Licensed Psychological Practitioner who works in the University of Kentucky Department of Psychiatry.

CHAPTER 4: PRIORITIZATION & PLANNING: TACKLING INDECISION, TIME BLINDNESS, AND TO-DO LISTS

Time-Management Tips for ADHD Brains

We are tuned into the clock on New Year's Eve. The rest of the year? Not so much. Time management is a lifelong challenge for many people with ADHD. These tips and tricks from *ADDitude* readers can help.

Missed deadlines, perpetual lateness, underestimating how long a task takes—people with ADHD have many admirable traits, but time-management acumen is rarely one of them.

Here, *ADDitude* readers share how their relationship with time impacts their lives and the best time-management solutions for them.

Time-Management Solutions

“The Waze app will tell me when to leave if I schedule a drive in advance with arrival time noted.”

“I use a false (early) date for deadlines.”

“The Gmail ‘Schedule Send’ option is life-changing. I can write and respond to emails late at night and schedule them to send the next morning (when I otherwise may or may not remember to send things).”

“I log appointments and deadlines in multiple places like my bullet journal, phone calendar, office calendar, etc. The more times I repeat something, the better I remember it. Even if I forget to write something down, with three calendars, it's probably in at least one.”

“I text myself reminders. I hate notifications, and I always check to clear them. Although sometimes I open my reminder text message before realizing what it is, and I have to re-text myself.”

“I let other people help me. I give them complete permission to point out the time, send me reminders, and share their observations about my time management (without being annoyed about it), and I thank them when they've done so.”

“My paper calendar is truly my second brain. I work a deadline-driven job and need to physically turn pages and write down important reminders that I can visualize.”

CHAPTER 4: PRIORITIZATION & PLANNING: TACKLING INDECISION, TIME BLINDNESS, AND TO-DO LISTS

“My best solution is the Sleep for Android app, which is militant about getting me out of bed. You can’t just turn off your phone—it requires me to scan a barcode in another room to make the alarm stop! I set it to play crashing waves, so I don’t loathe it too much.”

“I use smart home devices. When I put my laundry in the washing machine, I tell Alexa to remind me to check it in 30 minutes. If I have to leave the house at 8 a.m., Alexa reminds me to get ready to leave at 7:45 a.m.”

“Time Is Sneaky”

“Time is like a sink faucet with a drip that you’ve tuned out and forgotten about. Then you walk into your bathroom and step in a puddle because that faucet drip has become a flood!”

“Time is a completely fluid concept to me—as are deadlines, appointment times, and basically anything scheduled. I’m chronically optimistic that I can do *one* more thing so I don’t forget later—because I will. Then I’m 15 minutes late and struggling to get grace from those who don’t understand.”

“Hyperfocus often consumes so much time that I can forget to eat, use the bathroom, or even stand up and move around to ward off stiffness. I have to set alarms on my phone to be forcibly pulled out of the time blindness and brought back into the world. I set three alarms leading up to the time I absolutely must leave my house, reminding me that I must leave in 15, 10, and 5 minutes.”

“I have been utterly time-blind my entire life. It takes a conscious effort not to succumb to the magical thinking that a week’s worth of tasks can be fit into one day. I’m a writer, and I’ve missed or pushed—with great anxiety—more deadlines and appointments than I can count. I’m also dreamy and have great difficulty with task-switching. This means that time between tasks disappears into a black hole. I would get many years back if I could retrieve that time.”

“When I try to be on time for an outing or appointment, one of two things usually happens. Either I am slow to move from breakfast to getting up and prepping my way out the door, or I would have been on time if not for the two ‘unexpected’ details or phone calls that ‘got in my way.’ In short, I’m terrible at time management.”

“I can spend two hours or eight hours with a friend, and it feels the same. I have to ask my friends when our activity will end, or I’ll just stay there indefinitely. I can also get sucked into

CHAPTER 4: PRIORITIZATION & PLANNING: TACKLING INDECISION, TIME BLINDNESS, AND TO-DO LISTS

a game, book, T.V. show, etc. So, if I have something else to do that day, I set the alarm about an hour before I need to leave. I also build a buffer into my schedule to allow time for the things I've forgotten (keys, water bottle, or the thing I promised to give to the friend I'm meeting)."

"I have a terrible time when appointments are booked months in advance. My daughter has orthodontist appointments every two to three months. I add them to my calendar but often fail to remember them until the day or the day before. I repeatedly book client meetings or appointments before and after the visits, which do not allow for the drive time. Then, I have to cancel or make last-minute rearrangements. This is stressful, upsetting to my clients, frustrating to my daughter, and unprofessional. I have since started to block off the appointment plus drive time. I also block off a chunk of time the week before to review my schedule, check for these inevitable blind spots, and adjust as needed."

"Time is very sneaky. It passes painfully slow at times and, at other times, evaporates without warning. To be on time, I must plan out every task I need to complete, blocking out each task for a specific amount of time. Then I continuously check my list and time. It is exhausting! Still, more workdays end where I did not accomplish anything I had planned due to not keeping continuous tabs on time."

"To me, something that happened three days ago feels like it was a week ago, or something that happened one week ago feels like it was one month ago. Sometimes what happened five years ago feels more like last year. The day-to-day passing of time is easier for me to have a concept of because I have clocks everywhere (including in the shower!). I look at them probably every five minutes."

"My family has threatened to tell me to meet them places half an hour earlier than I needed to get me there on time. I laugh at it because there isn't much else to do. It's also hard because I need to prepare for things like work at least two hours earlier than anyone else would just to get there on time. **I hate that my internal clock is so messed up** that I look like I can't do things in a timely manner."

"My friends know not to schedule anything with me unless they have much of the day free because I'll inevitably be late. If there are solid plans at a certain time, they'll text me when I need to leave to ensure I'm on my way. I understand how disrespectful it is to take up people's time and not be available when I'm needed, but it's not a conscious choice. **It's extremely frustrating to live in a world driven by clocks when I have no concept of the passage of time.**"

CHAPTER 4: PRIORITIZATION & PLANNING: TACKLING INDECISION, TIME BLINDNESS, AND TO-DO LISTS

“I realized how bad my sense of time was when it became a repeated conversation in our house for me to say, ‘It’ll take about five minutes to get there.’ Then my husband would look at me funny and say ‘...or closer to 20 minutes,’ and he’d always be right. I genuinely have no idea how long things take. This makes it wildly difficult for me to get places on time. **I will be there! But I will probably be 5 to 15 minutes late.**”

“I struggle to time how long a task will take. I postpone something because I think it will take 20 minutes, but in reality, it takes two minutes. I plan to leave the house at 1 p.m. At 12:30 p.m. I’m still watching some series on Netflix, and it seems like I have plenty of time. Or I’m ready at 12 p.m. because I started to get ready at 11 a.m. **I either overestimate or underestimate; there is no in-between.**”

“I have a great relationship with time because I have worked on it. **I use my other senses and engage the whole body.** For example, when cooking, I get off the couch 30 seconds before the buzzer rings. Maybe I can smell that cookies are done? I backward plan events with an estimated time plan to stay on track. Lateness is rude to me. I can’t be late. When people are late for me, it disappoints me. You can be late tomorrow but not today (smile).”

Expert Q&A with Ari Tuckman, Psy.D.

Q: “Why am I terrible—and oddly inconsistent—with time estimation?”

Your time-estimation difficulties point to the maddening inconsistency and unpredictability that characterizes ADHD. Making it worse is that when you estimate time correctly just once, the world expects you to get it right every other time.

ADHD itself causes inaccurate time estimation. Time blindness warps and bends the internal ruler you use to measure how long something takes. Your estimates are off because your units are inconsistent. How an hour “feels” to you may not be how neurotypical people feel that same unit of time. Similarly, an hour’s worth of productivity can vary a lot from one hour to the next.

Another factor complicating time estimation is the tendency that people with ADHD have to stretch a task to fill the available time. If you have three hours to complete a task, for example, it will likely take you that long to complete it. At the same time, if you had just an hour to do the same task, you would also manage to complete it in that timeframe.

Some tasks have less variability than others, like mowing a lawn versus writing a research paper. One way to improve time estimation for recurring tasks is to measure them a few times. You don’t need to time it to a T; a ballpark estimate works just fine. Be sure to measure with intention. Note how often you get distracted, for example, and how much time that adds to the task.

For tasks where time estimation is more nebulous, your best course of action might be simply giving yourself a set amount of time to chip away at the job. Set yourself up for success by gathering everything you need for the task and anticipating and eliminating distractions ahead of time.

Another rule of thumb: Always give yourself more time than you think you need. Chances are you underestimate more than overestimate how much time you need. Don’t fall victim to the planning fallacy if you know your tendency is to undershoot.

The content for this article was derived, in part, from the ADDitude webinar, “Why Is Time So Slippery? Understanding Time Blindness in People with ADHD,” with Ari Tuckman, Psy.D.

Expert Q&A with Leslie Josel

Q: “I’m a work-from-home mom with no daily structure. Will a daily routine keep me from feeling overwhelmed?”

I love this question! I often tell my clients that establishing routines and rituals can bring more ease and increased productivity to their lives.

Here’s how I explain establishing routines to my coaching clients: Planning, organization, and time management all require ongoing, conscious, active brainpower. Routines, almost by definition, do not. Think of a routine as “I plan it once, and I’m done.” In other words, a daily routine allows you to move through your tasks without thinking about what’s next.

Routines are great tools for fighting procrastination because they give your brain a break from consciously planning and preparing specific to-dos, which means fewer things will get in your way of accomplishing the work that requires effort.

A funny thing about routines and rituals is that sometimes they form naturally without much deliberate thought. Brushing your teeth before (or after) you wash your face is a routine you probably just fell into one day. The same goes for putting on your socks and shoes. Other routines take considerable thought and effort. When students receive their new class schedule at the beginning of a school year or semester, they need to devise all-new routines to support the structure of their days. The same applies to adults.

Ritual vs. Routine

What’s the difference between a routine and a ritual? I describe a routine as something you perform at a planned time and put on your planner or calendar, such as doing laundry every Tuesday at 7 p.m.

However, a ritual is an order or procedure you follow when working (or preparing to work) on a task or activity. For example, your prework ritual may look like this:

- pour coffee
- scan planner and task list for the day
- switch on the desk lamp
- turn on music
- light candle
- gather materials needed to begin a specific work task

While these examples may make them sound very different, routines and rituals are both effective tools to help you form habits. And the best way to prove their effectiveness is to show you what could happen without them.

Why Are Routines and Rituals Important?

Let's say you don't have a set schedule for laundry. It's 9 a.m. on Monday morning, and you're about to dive into your work report that's due at 11 a.m. You feel two hours gives you ample time to complete it. As you head to your home office, you glimpse your laundry basket overflowing with a week's dirty laundry. Naturally, you decide to put a load in before considering whether you can manage both simultaneously. "What's the big deal?" you think.

Here's why it may be a big deal: It takes 15 minutes to start the laundry after sorting, emptying pockets, presoaking items, etc., giving you a late work start. Forty-five minutes into work, you interrupt yourself to move the wash to the dryer, hang clothes to dry, search for more hangers, and begin another load. Soon, the washer and dryer beep again, indicating more laundry. Once completed, you sit back at your desk and realize it's now 11 a.m. You're feeling overwhelmed because you are only halfway finished with your report. Doing laundry seemed innocent enough, right? But you've now lost time to the rinse cycle, causing unexpected consequences. One small decision threw your morning off track, and the ripple effect continued into the afternoon.

However, if you had an established laundry routine on Monday nights, you could have focused solely on your report and worked straight through without interruption.

Now I'm not saying that you need to have every moment of your life planned down to the minute. None of us can live that way. But establishing and sticking to certain routines can make your life easier, save precious time, take the guesswork out of how to get things done, and provide a sense of calm and control.

Bonus tip: The Habit Hub is one of my favorite apps to help incentivize forming routines. The Habit Hub encourages you to create a daily habit by reminding you to perform a task and track it when it's complete. The app makes a visual "chain" showing each day the task was completed. As the chain gets longer, it incentivizes you to keep at the task, so you don't break it. You can organize your to-dos into categories and customize each according to how often you're supposed to do it. It's incredibly flexible and makes setting up and staying in a routine a breeze.

Leslie Josel is an ADHD-academic and parenting coach, founder of Order Out of Chaos, and an ADDitude contributor.

“The Day I Learned Why Time Is Such a Mystery to ADHD Brains”

By Stephanie Wilson, CNC

How often do you show up late to the events and responsibilities of your life? Forty percent of the time? Half? If you can't say 100% of the time, then I win. I am the Queen of Lateness.

Or I was.

I used to be late for practically everything. And take it from the Queen: Being late stinks. It's a self-sabotaging act that gave me decades of anguish, hurt, and frustration. I knew the heartache of lateness like I knew the jewels on my crown. I'd have given anything not to wear that crown, to be a commoner who—gasp—gets to appointments *a few minutes early*.

Following is the story of how I changed my lifelong habit of lateness practically overnight. No, this is not a clickbait story. It's the sharing of fundamental tools that us late and time-blind folk don't realize are out there. It's my “eureka” story.

Step #1: Time Yourself

My lateness was “cured” in 2007 at the start of the recession. My job as a tech recruiter was on shaky ground, so I pivoted and started a cleaning and residential organizing company. My sweet cousin recommended my services to her friends, who hired me. With my company and reputation now connected to my friend and family circle, I had to avoid failure at all costs. Lateness threatened it all, which meant I had to find a solution.

How was the Queen of Lateness supposed to undo a lifelong habit? I started with the only thing I could think of—measuring time itself. Rather than assume how long it took me to do something, I actually tracked myself. If you've never done this, I can tell you the results will shock you. It shocked me to learn that grabbing coffee, putting on my jacket, walking to the car, setting up my GPS, and backing out of my driveway took 10 minutes, not zero minutes, which is the time I always allotted.

This is what got me to realize why time was such a mystery to me and other folks with ADHD. Though the clock is always ticking, we don't often account for the little, almost automatic tasks—picking out an outfit, looking over notes before a meeting, making a quick lunch—that undoubtedly use up time. Ten minutes to get out of the house may sound like small peanuts, but when you add up all the other unaccounted-for tasks throughout your day, that time significantly adds up.

Time yourself, and you'll see that it takes longer than “half an hour” to go from waking up to getting out the door. Google Maps can give you a good estimate of

how long it takes to get from Point A to Point B, but it can't tell you how long it takes to park, pay the meter, walk to your destination, and get inside the building. Trust me on that one.

Step #2: Accept the Numbers

This discovery, which had been hiding in plain sight all this time, shattered my world of lateness and gave me the key to a world where punctuality was possible.

But there was one last door to unlock before I truly internalized punctuality. Though I now had proof of how long tasks really took, it somehow wasn't enough to change my ways. I had to willingly drop my prior assumptions and adjust to reality. I had to accept that most things will take longer than I think (or hope). I had to go from an expert bargainer with time to one who submits to it.

At first, I protested when my time estimations, freshly calibrated, told me it would take two hours to do something I assumed I could do in one hour. But that skepticism was replaced with joy when I did what time told me to—*and I was early*. I became the newly crowned Queen of Punctuality. Guess what this did for my reputation and my serenity? Guess what it did for my self-concept?

I'd love for you to see what this new life feels like. When you do, you will bow to me and thank me until the end of time, which is further away than you might think.

Stephanie Wilson, CNC, is an ADHD coach living in Northern Virginia.

“7 Reasons Why You Need Analog Clocks”

By Mareen Dennis, MA, LPP

You take a look at the time, and you're confident you have plenty of wiggle room. Then, out of nowhere, you're running late once again for work or an appointment or a deadline you've long seen coming. Time crept up on you with little or no warning—just like yesterday and the day before.

Time blindness, or a lack of awareness of the passage of time, is a common difficulty among many people with ADHD. Research has shown that time awareness hinges on available attention dedicated to detecting it. Individuals who are easily distracted by other stimuli, as is the case with ADHD, find that the continuity of time is outside of their consciousness.

The solution, therefore, is to externalize time as much as possible. Instead of relying on an internal tracking system, people with ADHD need to literally “see” time. How? I recommend a good-old analog clock—or five.

Analog clocks may seem obsolete in this digital era, but with more technological distractions and demands competing for our attention today, I've found this low-tech solution can really help manage our ADHD symptoms, balance our schedules, and keep us sane.

Analog Clocks: Benefits for ADHD Brains

- 1. Accurately detecting the passage of time.** The hands on the analog clock are constantly and consistently moving, giving you a true sense of how time works, and heightening your sensitivity to the true duration of minutes, hours, and days.
- 2. Ticking sound as an aid.** Hearing the ticking of the clock can also help you detect the consistent passing of time. Counting the ticks can help with the pacing and timing of tasks.
- 3. Five-minute chunks.** Clock faces show time in five-minute segments, making an easy, effortless framework for organizing tasks. It also provides another way to think of and chunk up the passage of time.
- 4. Marking the hour.** Many analog clocks can be set with a chime at the top of each hour to help you recognize the passage of each 60 minutes.
- 5. Parts to the whole.** The visual of the clock forms wedges that look like a pie chart representing parts (minutes) to whole (hour) relationships. Viewing time as an hour pie chart helps to break down tasks into smaller steps more intuitively. This can help improve accuracy in estimating the time needed for tasks and in pacing yourself for task completion.

6. Discourage procrastination. When you see how much time you have in the hour, you can recognize tasks that can be accomplished before the top of the hour. Commit to working on a task for 15 minutes and see how much you accomplish in that quarter of the hour.

7. Progress check. If you have a set amount of time for a task, one glance at the analog display shows you the start and stop times as well as the amount of time left. All in one quick glance. No need to do math calculations to know how much time remains! So, consider it time to get an analog clock for each room in your house. Try out various novel styles that will attract your attention and keep you informed of the time.

“Defeating Indecision—Decision-Making Made Easy!”

By Sandy Maynard

Our high-speed ADHD brains seem incapable, at times, of keeping things simple. We want to buy a new phone, so we go online to see what’s available, and we get a case of attention-surplus disorder. We dig up so much information that we can’t make a decision. We are overwhelmed.

Sometimes our difficulty making decisions extends to things that should be dealt with now—like a leaky faucet. We don’t know which faucet to buy, so we let the old one drip for months until we have a flood underneath the sink. But decision-making doesn’t have to be a challenge: Here’s how some of my ADHD clients became more decisive.

Consider Pros and Cons

Susan, a recently retired government employee, wanted to move back to a small town in North Carolina where her parents and friends live. She knew that it was the right choice, but instead of looking for a place to live, she spent weeks surfing for lighting fixtures, kitchen cabinets, flooring, etc. She came to me for help. We discovered two approaches that moved her forward.

The first strategy was to talk about the kind of house she wanted to live in. Hearing herself say things aloud made decision-making easier since she could rule out options. Renovating an older house or building a new one seemed attractive when Susan thought about it but lost its appeal when I asked, “How long do you think that will take?” She realized that a condo was a better choice.

The second strategy was identifying what she valued most—spending time with family and friends and staying active. She decided that having a large living/dining area to entertain company was more important than having three large bedrooms. And she wanted a condo near a bike path or a gym. This thinking narrowed her choices. One condo that she had ruled out now seemed more appealing. She bought it.

Think Long-Term, Big Picture

Terry, a recent graduate who is starting her first job, uses the same decision-making strategies. Before making any choice, she asks herself, “Which is the healthiest choice I can make for my physical, spiritual, and emotional well-being?” Before she identified self-care as being more important than financial success and professional accomplishment, deciding on anything was stressful. Terry worked late and regretted missing her yoga class or not spending time with friends. What’s more, staying late hurt her performance at the job the next day. “Making decisions based on what is best for me has helped me get my work done faster and better. Taking care of myself is the way to gain an edge professionally,” she says.

Make Choices with Confidence

Tom was clear about what he wanted. But he couldn't move forward because he feared it wasn't the "right" choice. I suggested that he list his fears and ask himself, "What's the worst that could happen?" As we discussed ways to deal with each thing that could go wrong, Tom realized he was smart enough, and emotionally resilient enough to deal with anything that might occur. This took the fear out of his decision-making.

Avoid Acting on Impulse

Because people with ADHD make impulsive decisions that sometimes backfire, deciding not to decide is a good choice, too. I sometimes realize several weeks later that many of my "great ideas" aren't worth pursuing. We don't need to attend to everything that pops into our heads. It's important to be able to make decisions, but it's equally important not to make ones that will take us off course.

Decision Do's

- Identify the problem.
- List the solutions and options.
- Discuss the approaches with others.
- Rank the options in order of priority.
- List the pros and cons of the top two or three.
- Choose the option you are most comfortable with and identify the actions needed to bring it about.
- Take a little time before moving ahead to ensure your choice wasn't made impulsively. While doing this, you may find that the second or third option is better for you. (That has happened to me countless times.)

“When Your To-Do Lists Loom Like Unyielding Mountains”

By Stephanie Wilson, CNC

Every day, I find myself staring at a giant mountain of things I need to do. Oddly, only some of what's on the so-called mountain is real, important, and valuable. Most of it is a lot of airy nothing, the result of funky thinking on my part.

Before I start my climb up the mountain, I stand at the base and squint up to the tippy top. *If I can just make it up there by the end of the day, I'll win.* I say this every day, but I've almost never gotten to the top of that mountain. I've rarely won.

Why? Is it because I'm an amateur mountain climber? Are we talking El Capitan here? What's the deal?

The deal is that my to-do lists—whether for today, this year, or my life—don't always reflect what I can do or what I *want* to do. I would need five of me to clear off my typical daily to-do list. My to-do list for life reads more like what five different versions of me want for my life, not just the single living, breathing me.

Why My To-Do Lists Go Awry

Sometimes, I lack clarity on what I truly need or want to do. The world, after all, is a big mountain of endless options. Other times, I'm cognitively inflexible and can't switch gears when life asks me to, so I miss out on the optimal trail. I'm left with a lengthier trek and a bigger mountain. Still, other times perfectionism comes through, disabling my mountain to grow. Finally, my old friend Time Blindness comes for a visit (actually, she lives with me permanently because that's ADHD), and suddenly, my current task stretches like the Appalachian Mountain range.

It's all so much fun.

Just kidding. It's cold on my mountain, and lonely, especially when the trek involves fretting, scrambling, forgetting, rushing, and rarely arriving at satisfaction.

How to Shrink To-Do Mountains

So, what are my options? Am I destined to be stuck climbing interminable mountains forever?

I am not. I have the option to be a curator of my time, effort, and intentions.

You're thinking, “That's easier said than done!”

Trust me, I get you. But I've found that noticing what's going on in me at the moment is the first step to whittling down my mountain to the approachable, achievable, well-suited hill that makes my life happier and calmer.

Each day, when I wake up to face what appears to be Mt. Behemoth, I kick it with my toe to see if it's real. I ask myself, "Steph, how much of what you insist you need to do today genuinely needs to be done?"

This is when the mountain raises a suspicious eyebrow because it knows that this question could lead to its shrinking. It's a big clue that I'm at the juncture of owning my decisions or giving that power away. We each hold our position, but only one of us can be in charge. Who will it be? Me, or this mountain of tasks, goals, and dreams that nobody, even in an alternate universe, could ever accomplish in a reasonable amount of time?

"Since I'm writing a story with a happy ending here, it's going to be me. But, full disclosure, the mountain sometimes gets the best of me. However, I've gotten so much better at calling the shots over time."

The first trick is to say, "This thing doesn't need to get done today." The second trick is to believe this deep to your core. When you reach advanced-level mountain shrinking, you'll learn that some tasks can simply be chucked off the mountain.

This is because there are channels of prioritization. One channel is for things that need to get done—the when, where, and how. The other channel is for things that need to get punted from our self-expectation mountain. When these channels become murky, climbing our mountain is no walk in the park.

But what is a lovely walk in the park? It's the serenity that comes when I narrow down my daily priorities to a list that my earlier self would have laughed at. "Are you kidding? That's a tiny list!" she'd have said. Old me would have fretted through her day and sulked at only being able to cross off, say, three things. Present me, though, feels empowered for crossing off the same number of items.

What I've noticed about adjusting to tinier, more doable plans is that as I accomplish what I set out to do and rack up the wins, I've grown a palpable confidence that says, "You can realize your dreams." These hill-sized goals lead us to mountains of accomplishment and happiness.

The following *ADDitude* experts and authors contributed to this chapter: Mareen Dennis, MA, LPP; Leslie Josel; Sandy Maynard; Ari Tuckman, Psy.D.; and Stephanie Wilson, CNC.

CHAPTER 5

Verbal & Non-Verbal Working Memory: Curbing ADHD Forgetfulness

Chapter 5: Verbal & Non-Verbal Working Memory: Curbing ADHD Forgetfulness

Why Working Memory Fails and How to Bolster It

Learn why ADHD brains so frequently struggle to keep on track, on time, and in control and what you can do to lighten your cognitive load.

Many experts today argue that ADHD is not, at its core, an attention problem, but rather a self-regulation problem exacerbated by weak working memory.

Our brains comprise two systems: the automatic and the executive. The automatic system guides 80% to 90% of our activities every single day; the executive system guides the remaining 10% to 20% and requires purposeful, regulatory effort. As many with ADHD know, this system of executive functioning can be exhausting; it requires frequent mental pauses and ceaseless self-regulation.

Executive function is so taxing, in part, because it comprises seven distinct brain activities—two of which are verbal working memory and non-verbal working memory (which hinges on visual and spatial acumen). Both types of working memory influence the amount of effort and type of actions required to modify what our brains would do automatically. The stronger your working memory, the less work your brain must take on with each new challenge.

According to Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D., the importance of working memory is growing within the study of ADHD. He calls working memory your brain's GPS—an essential system that guides and directs actions and is commonly weak in people with ADHD. Dr. Barkley explained this GPS theory in depth in a joint presentation with ADHD coach Jeff Copper during an Attention Talk Radio podcast. Dr. Barkley and Copper also shared strategies for strengthening your working memory and externalizing information so that your brain can effectively plan and coordinate tasks without expending extra effort.

CHAPTER 5: VERBAL & NON-VERBAL WORKING MEMORY: CURBING ADHD FORGETFULNESS

How Working Memory Powers Executive Function

Like a GPS booting up for a new voyage, the brain begins any new task by referring to its maps—those sensory images logged and stored in non-verbal working memory, Dr. Barkley says. It next tunes in to its instructions, the verbal commands and “inner voice” stored in verbal working memory. The visual images of the non-verbal working memory help the brain act, and verbal working memory becomes its guidance system.

When a brain stores and synthesizes both types of working memory effectively, it works like the Waze app or Google Maps—determining the relevance of new information as it arrives and altering the plan in real time to get us to our destination better or faster. It becomes a more powerful tool for self-regulation, goal-setting, and working around obstacles in our paths. But to an already overwhelmed brain, all this working memory can be a lot to process. Because of that, Dr. Barkley suggests a strategy called “externalizing” that gets the information out of the brain and into an external environment by transforming both the sensory and the verbal working memory into a physical manifestation. This helps the brain to become less taxed.

Pen & Paper

Digital isn’t always the best solution. Simply write things down with pen and paper to lessen the burden on your working memory. Yes, your phone is often nearby, but using technology for such memory tasks is “... misguided for ADHD in many ways,” Dr. Barkley says. Smart-phones, tablets, and smartwatches—which may be lost, drained of battery life, and not synced—could lead to more stress than they relieve.

Instead, Dr. Barkley says, “Let’s go low tech. Let’s go back to paper and pencil.” Use an ADHD-friendly notebook as an external storage device for your working memory. Use imagery, not just language; make to-do lists; keep your schedule; make goals—but do it on paper.

Use Tech Wisely

If you prefer utilizing tech, use it wisely. For example, Copper suggests snapping a photo of the outfit you’ve laid out for an upcoming trip so that you can recall it quickly from your offloaded, externalized working memory—now in the form of a photo—while balancing other priorities during your trip.

CHAPTER 5: VERBAL & NON-VERBAL WORKING MEMORY: CURBING ADHD FORGETFULNESS

Map It Out

Returning to the GPS metaphor, Dr. Barkley suggests creating a work (or mind) map. This works well for those who achieve better results with visual cues—particularly when working on longer written projects or reports. Creating an image of something can be easier and faster to retrieve because it can be instantly imagined. For example, sticky notes can make great low-tech systems, because they can be moved around as we think through an assignment, allowing for quick categorization, scheduling, detailing, and rearranging without expending more mental energy. Sometimes, a picture really is worth a thousand words.

Simplify Your Workspace

When it comes to controlling distractibility and impulses, working memory is often fragile. Dr. Barkley recommends limiting your workspace to only what's involved in the project. He even suggests that some professionals benefit from using two computers—one with games, social media, and the web, and one stripped down, for work only. A software application that blocks browsing is another tactic that can limit online distractions and keep projects—and working memory—on track.

Take Time to Discover What's Right for You

We can't all commit to the same systems and expect powerful, individualized results—one size does not fit all. According to Dr. Barkley, research shows that, in the average ADHD brain, verbal working memory is twice as strong as visual working memory. For some, however, this isn't the case. Artists, architects, and visually inclined people generally believe the opposite. (Some even find that their tactile, auditory, and olfactory senses may be harnessed to lighten the load on working memory.)

This article was written by Steph Alexander, a freelance writer who lives in Tennessee.

Working Memory vs. Short-Term Memory: What's the Difference?

By Sharon Saline, Psy.D.

There are three different types of memory:

- working memory
- short-term memory
- long-term memory

While there's some debate about this, it's generally held that short-term memory is super quick: It stores information briefly. Working memory is related to short-term memory, but it lasts slightly longer and is involved in manipulating information.

If someone tells you something and you write it down, it might not matter that your short-term memory is faulty because you don't have to hold on to that memory beyond documenting it. Working memory deficits become problematic if someone tells you something, and you need to hold on to the memory and do something with it but can't.

When things are flagged as emotionally important, they transfer down the memory line and are converted into long-term memories. This is why emotions and working memory are so intricately related. Short-term, immediate memory for simple tasks gets processed first. More complex and demanding information goes into working memory, and, if it's tagged with emotional importance or special relevance, it ends in long-term memory. It's a very complicated process.

People with ADHD often struggle with working memory. They may not be as efficient with it as they are with verbal comprehension or spatial thinking, for example. It's important to understand that working memory challenges, along with processing speed issues, can be a natural part of having ADHD. They don't cause ADHD; they come with it.

How to Improve Working Memory

Repetition can improve working memory. Pairing an action or movement with a word or phrase helps, too. I once had a client who needed to learn Spanish, so he created a special movement for each word to help him remember it.

If you're learning lines for a play, improve retention by reading and practicing the lines right before you go to bed and first thing when you wake up.

“Oh, I Forgot”

By Ari Tuckman, Psy.D.

You're in the shower, and you remember that you need to return your friend's laptop to him that evening. By the time evening rolls around, you have a million things on your mind—and the laptop isn't one of them. Or you're at work and realize you have to check the battery size of your daughter's electronic game. You write yourself a note about it. But when you get home, you need to take the dog to the vet, so the battery is forgotten while you tend to your furry friend.

Remembering to remember is tough for people with ADHD. The key to success is getting the timing right. You need to remind yourself to do a task at a time and place where you can complete it. Here are my tips for turning “I forgot” into “Did it already.”

- **Location, location, location.** Place an item in a spot that will be its own reminder. If you realize tonight that you need to take an umbrella tomorrow, place it in front of the door, so you can't leave home without tripping over it.
- **Text, voicemail, or email yourself.** Call or text your phone from work to remind yourself to do something at home, or vice versa. Or send an email to your work account while at home or from your phone while doing errands. You'll see the reminder at the place where you can act on it.
- **Leave notes at the site of the task.** Some tasks must be done at specific locations, such as the file cabinet at work or the kitty litter box at home. Tape a note in those places to remind yourself to act on the task.
- **Tie a string around your finger (sort of).** Use an out-of-place item as a reminder. Choose something odd, random, or out of place enough to catch your attention later and trigger what you need to do. The item shouldn't relate to the task: Turn a chair upside down to remind you to go to the bank.
- **Deliver emails and texts.** To remember to send a new email or text, start it by typing in the recipient and subject line. When I get an email I need to read later, I click “Reply” immediately. I don't need to remember to answer it because it's already sitting open on my computer.

The following article was excerpted with permission from Understand Your Brain, Get More Done: The ADHD Executive Functions Workbook, by Ari Tuckman, Psy.D. (Specialty Press, 2012).

CHAPTER 5: VERBAL & NON-VERBAL WORKING MEMORY: CURBING ADHD FORGETFULNESS

Improve Working Memory: Brain Training Tricks

Everyone occasionally loses keys or forgets an important date. But you may be dealing with poor working memory when it's a habit. Learn how checklists and routines can improve your memory skills.

Losing your keys, leaving your wallet in the refrigerator, forgetting your spouse's birthday, asking the store clerk to repeat the directions to the gift-wrap department. While these are examples of inattention, they are mostly signs of poor working memory.

What Is Working Memory?

Think of working memory as a shelf in your brain. Imagine you are going to the store. You need milk, eggs, and bread. While you're in the store, you suddenly remember you need cereal. You head to the cereal aisle, but the eggs fall off your mental shelf as you focus on the Special K. You arrive home with cereal, milk, and bread, but have forgotten the eggs.

Researchers disagree about the number of information “bytes” that can be held by the brain. Some say it's as many as seven items, and others claim it's four. You can increase your working memory capacity by grouping items together. A telephone number is typically 10 digits long, but we often break the number into three groups (555-555-5555), allowing us to use only three working memory slots to remember 10 digits.

When Do We Use Working Memory?

You use working memory daily: to read, write, plan, organize, follow a conversation, do mental math, or follow multi-step directions. It helps you stay focused on and engaged with a task.

The following are examples of how poor working memory affects your daily life:

- You want to join in a conversation, but when the other person stops talking, you forget what you want to say.
- You consistently lose your keys, cell phone, or wallet.
- You get lost easily, even when you were just given directions.

CHAPTER 5: VERBAL & NON-VERBAL WORKING MEMORY: CURBING ADHD FORGETFULNESS

- You have trouble following a conversation because you forget what the other person said.
- You have many unfinished projects because you become distracted and forget about the first project.
- You plan to do some work at home, but you forget to bring needed items with you.
- You have to reread a paragraph several times to retain the information.
- You miss deadlines at work because of your disorganization and inability to follow through on projects.

The first step to better working memory is understanding how memory works and accepting your limitations. That doesn't mean saying, "Oh, I forgot," to excuse yourself. It means developing and using strategies to compensate for forgetting.

Tips to Improve Working Memory

Reduce Multitasking

Focus on one or two tasks before moving on to the next task. For example, suppose you are getting ready to host a party in your home. You are overwhelmed with everything that needs to be done—shopping, cooking, cleaning, and setting up for the party. Focus on one area, such as shopping. Ignore the rest of the tasks until you are done shopping. According to a study at the University of Sussex, multitasking can shrink certain areas of your brain and is linked to shortened attention spans.

Use Checklists for Tasks with Multiple Steps

For example, create a checklist for your first hour at work. It could include listening to messages, returning calls, checking and answering emails, reviewing yesterday's progress, and checking in with the supervisor for important tasks to be completed immediately.

Develop Routines

Create a routine for returning home from work. For example, when you walk in the door, always put your cell phone and keys in the same place.

Experiment with Ways of Remembering Information

Write down six unrelated words. Try to remember the first two words without looking at the paper and add another word as you succeed. You may remember a list more easily if you create a song or make up a rhyme. Others find that visualization helps them remem-

CHAPTER 5: VERBAL & NON-VERBAL WORKING MEMORY: CURBING ADHD FORGETFULNESS

ber multiple items. When heading home from work, visualize yourself stopping at the store and picking up milk, cheese, bread, and yogurt. Imagine going to each section of the store. Because images are more powerful than words, you are apt to remember everything you need at the store as you follow your visualization.

Use Mindfulness

A study from Massachusetts General Hospital, Harvard Medical School, and the Massachusetts Institute of Technology found that daily mindfulness exercises increased recall and allowed participants to tune out distractions by regulating sensory input.

Add Exercise to Your Daily Routine

Some studies have shown that working memory increases with daily exercise. While the reasons for this aren't fully understood, scientists believe physical activity improves the health of brain cells. It can also indirectly affect memory by improving mood, helping you sleep better, and reducing stress—areas that can affect cognitive abilities.

This article was written by Eileen Bailey, a writer and advocate for people with mental health issues, learning differences, and conditions such as ADHD, anxiety, and autism.

Self-Test: Do You Have a Working Memory Deficit?

Take this self-test to gauge whether your short-term memory problems could be signs of a working memory deficit.

You use your working memory hundreds of times every day—from mentally preparing a shopping list before going to the grocery store to thinking about work projects. For people with working memory deficits, this area in their brains is more like a loosely woven basket where items consistently slip through the cracks. You go to the store with the list in your head—and come home having forgotten most of the items. You have a plan of action in your mind at the beginning of the day—and realize that you have not accomplished, or even thought about, several items on your list by the end of the day.

Take the following self-test to see if you show signs of a working memory deficit.

This self-test is for personal use only and is designed to determine whether you show symptoms similar to those of a working memory deficit. See a health professional if you have concerns about possible working memory problems. An accurate diagnosis can only be made through clinical evaluation.

1. You want to ask your friend something but must wait a few minutes before asking because they are on the phone. When the call is finished, you completely forget what you wanted to ask.
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

CHAPTER 5: VERBAL & NON-VERBAL WORKING MEMORY: CURBING ADHD FORGETFULNESS

2. You plan to complete some work at home only to discover you forgot to bring home several critical items.
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
3. You have difficulty following a conversation with a friend, forgetting what your friend said moments before.
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
4. When you complete a task with several steps, such as getting the trash, taking it outside, and putting a new bag in the trash can, you usually forget the last step.
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
5. When you read something, you usually reread the prior section because you can't remember it.
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

CHAPTER 5: VERBAL & NON-VERBAL WORKING MEMORY: CURBING ADHD FORGETFULNESS

6. You constantly misplace your phone and feel like you waste time every day looking for it and other misplaced items like keys or glasses.
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
7. You are often accused of not listening because you don't follow through on tasks you are asked to do.
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
8. You have difficulty remembering names of people you have met multiple times.
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
9. In the morning, you usually rush to get ready for work but often end up late.
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

CHAPTER 5: VERBAL & NON-VERBAL WORKING MEMORY: CURBING ADHD FORGETFULNESS

10. You have a hard time managing large projects. Even when you break them down into steps, you miss steps or spend too much time on unimportant tasks.

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

Results: Assign the following values to your answers: Very Often (4 points), Often (3 points), Sometimes (2 points), Rarely (1 point), and Never (0 points). The higher your point total, the greater the likelihood of showing signs of a working memory deficit. (Maximum score: 40 points)

Note: *This screener is designed to determine whether you demonstrate symptoms like those of a working memory deficit. A high score does not necessarily mean you have a working memory deficit. A score of 30-40 means that you answered “Often” or “Very Often” to most of the questions and should see a trained healthcare professional as there is a possibility that you are experiencing a working memory deficit. An accurate diagnosis can only be made through clinical evaluation.*

CHAPTER 5: VERBAL & NON-VERBAL WORKING MEMORY: CURBING ADHD FORGETFULNESS

Tuning Out, Drifting Off, Forgetting Names

Do you often get distracted when people talk? Do you forget people's names right after they introduce themselves? These strategies can help.

Many people find it hard to remember names. Practicing the following strategies will help you put names to faces.

Repeat, Repeat, Repeat

Repeat the first name out loud slowly and clearly as soon as it is given, saying, "It's a pleasure to meet you, Sandy."

Repeat the last name and say one of the following, "Maynard... Is that a French name?" or "Maynard, is that spelled with an 'n'?" or simply, "How do you spell your last name?" Take the time to repeat the spelling back to them. If it is an uncommon or difficult name to pronounce, repeat the name and ask them if you pronounced it correctly.

Associate the Name with a Visual

Practice associating the name with a visual image of something that rhymes with or is associated with the name. For example, when introduced to Sam Roberts, visualize a robber stealing a can of Spam from a grocery store, as 'Spam' rhymes with Sam, and 'robber' sounds like Roberts.

Maintain Eye Contact

Keeping engaged in conversation instead of drifting off can be a challenge. Maintaining eye contact with the person speaking will help, as will asking questions. Some people report that nodding to what others are saying helps them stay attentive.

Remember to Breathe

Responding impulsively has gotten us all in trouble at some point. The most important thing to remember is to take a breath. Most of us do not realize that we hold our breath or change how we breathe when we get excited, fearful, or stressed. Try to breathe deeply and slowly and take a long, deep "cleansing breath" before responding. Counting to three or even ten will also help.

This article was written by Sandy Maynard.

CHAPTER 5: VERBAL & NON-VERBAL WORKING MEMORY: CURBING ADHD FORGETFULNESS

“My Keys Were in the Fridge!” ADHD Stories of Wildly Misplaced Items

ADDitude readers share the most wildly misplaced personal items they’ve rediscovered.

Keys, wallet, cell phone—the list of our frequently used and easy-to-misplace items stretches on and on. Poor working memory makes it difficult for adults with ADHD to hold information temporarily, which means the milk might end up in the cupboard and the cereal in the laundry room.

We asked our readers, “What’s the most wildly misplaced personal item you’ve rediscovered, and where?” Here are some of our favorite answers.

“I was sitting in the airport with my family and started to panic because I lost track of my phone. I was frantically moving my hand around the seat, looking for it. **It was in my other hand.**”

“**I took the T.V. remote to the grocery store in my pocket.** The remote was as oblivious as I was.”

“**I have left my wallet at gas stations** or driven off with it on the roof of my car so many times in so many cities that it is now funny when strangers drop it off. One time I didn’t even know it was missing!”

“**I left a carton of eggs in my mailbox.** The mailman must have been surprised.”

“I garden almost daily and often find **my reading glasses in a pot or a bed of flowers.**”

“I lose my wallet, the remote control, and glasses several times a day. **I always check the laundry and fridge first.**”

“I’ve found my **phone in the freezer and the microwave.** I just laugh and keep moving—it’s a part of who I have always been.”

“We have a small remote device to open our garage, which I put in my pocket as I garden.

CHAPTER 5: VERBAL & NON-VERBAL WORKING MEMORY: CURBING ADHD FORGETFULNESS

One day, my partner asked where the garage opener was. **You know that ‘brain-rush’ feeling that comes with a flurry of images like life flashing before your eyes?** I tried to think through my actions calmly and soon realized I had zero recollection, so I said (in my best ‘responsible grown-up voice’), ‘I buried it, darling.’ A week later, my partner found it in a pile of soil at the bottom of the hill.”

“I left my car keys in the closet... and found them two years after I had traded in the car.”

“I’ve put the milk in the cupboard and the cereal in the fridge multiple times.”

“I always misplace my phone—usually at the bottom of my super-messy handbag—but more times than I’d like to admit, I have searched frantically for my phone when I am actually talking on it.”

“Once, I removed my hearing aids, put them in their case, and into the freezer. After looking behind several major appliances, multiple old suitcases, and bags of chips in a desperate quest to find them, I gave up and scheduled an appointment with the audiologist to get replacements. A few weeks later, my nicely chilled hearing aids turned up somewhere between the frozen peas and the chicken breasts.”

“Two years ago, I lost my glasses, and we spent weeks looking for them. This past year, I opened the box with the Christmas decorations, and there they were!”

“Once, while doing an inventory count, I was on a ladder checking the highest shelf in the warehouse for missing items. I didn’t find the items, but I did find a clipboard I had left up there 18 months earlier!”

“My son was going to a wilderness adventure camp, so we bought him hiking boots and other supplies. We got home and unpacked our purchases. He threw the empty bags and boxes into the recycle bin. Two days later—a day before trash pick-up—I went to throw something away and saw the brand new boots in the bin.”

“How I Improved My Memory with One Daily Habit”

By Tristan Hunt, BSc.

I began reading aloud to myself at bedtime some years ago in hopes of quieting the mental noise my ADHD brain made at night, which kept me awake. It worked! Reading aloud did help still my thoughts and improve my sleep, at least slightly. As the weeks passed, I also noticed that my overall reading speed improved, as did my focus on the material. Dyslexia keeps my ADHD company, so this was a welcome albeit surprising breakthrough, and it made me curious: Could I edge these cognitive lifts higher?

Beyond Bedtime Reading

I began experimenting by reading aloud for 50 minutes daily as part of my morning routine. This felt good as it built on the calm and focus I'd gleaned from my bedtime reading. To make things more interesting, I next tried to read the text aloud, remember it, then type it up. Like many of us with ADHD, my working memory has always been weak. But as I practiced this process—reading, speaking, memorizing, speaking, writing, repeating—I started to see some real gains.

One month after starting this routine, I saw some tangible benefits: As with my bedtime reads, the morning sessions made me feel calmer and more focused. My weak working memory got stronger. I could now recall not just a few words but whole sentences—sometimes even two! My reading and typing speed increased by around 20% (measured by the number of words I read and the number written up in each 50-minute session over a period of one month).

As the gains in my reading and typing took root, my mistakes with them diminished. My love of reading and writing grew. And in my job, I could work faster and more accurately. The enhanced focus, plus the increased reading and typing speed gained from my morning routine, carried over to my work and other areas of my life.

Four years after I began this morning practice, the gains are still growing and have become a non-negotiable part of my daily routine. When events force a temporary pause, say due to a business trip or vacation, I notice a brief decline in the gains mentioned. But, like returning to the gym after a holiday, your mental muscles can quickly recover with the gains restored after just a few days of concerted effort.

Activating My Task Positive Network

So why might this technique work? I believe this routine helps reduce my ADHD and dyslexia symptoms by activating my Task Positive Network, or TPN.

The TPN gets triggered when you pay close attention to something. (The opposite of TPN is DMN, or Default Mode Network, in which our thoughts aren't focused on anything.) My daily routine demands that I pay close attention to an interesting variety of things all at once—reading, speaking, memorizing, speaking, typing. It's a virtuous circle: The more time you spend in the TPN state, the greater your focus will be and, therefore, the more easily you can access your TPN.

Furthermore, researchers at the University of Waterloo, Canada, found that people who read aloud can see improvements in their memory, lending further credence to my little experiment.

Here's how you can try this technique yourself:

1. **Choose a text to read that *really* interests you**—a favorite magazine, book, script, story, or academic paper. The format does not matter so long as the reading captivates you.
2. **Find a quiet place where you won't be disturbed** and won't disturb anyone else as you read aloud.
3. **Place the text in front of you.** If the text is digital and you have two screens, use one to show the text and the other for writing it up
4. **Read the text aloud.** Keep your eyes focused on the page or screen in front, read the sentence, and hold it in memory. Then, look down at the keyboard and type as much as you can remember.
5. **Pay attention.** At every stage, give your total attention to what you are reading, remembering, speaking aloud, and writing down. Try giving it your all—you may even enter a flow state.
6. **Read it back.** When you've finished two 25-minute sprints, take another five-minute break, ideally away from the screen (stand up, take a short walk, skip rope, look outside, stand on a balance board, jog on the spot, have a stretch, etc.). Then return and read what you wrote as fast and clearly as possible in your most confident voice.
7. **Enunciate the words as you go.** Really focus on each word and sentence. Don't worry if you're tongue-tied when you start; the daily practice of this routine will reduce the verbal trip-ups as your accuracy, fluency, and confidence improve. See how many words you can read, remember, and write in 50 minutes!

This daily 50-minute routine is ideally done in two 25-minute sprints using the Pomodoro technique. But, you may want to try shorter sprints when you start and then build up their length from there.

As someone who loves reading and writing but has always struggled with both, this exercise continues to be a mainstay of every productive day I have. It demands effort, but this routine has mitigated my ADHD and dyslexia symptoms—honing my focus, clarity, and memory in really rewarding ways.

Tristan Hunt, BSc., is a music industry professional, coach, and mentor.

“We Live in the Kingdom of Forgetfulness”

By Elizabeth Broadbent

“I hate my ADHD forgetfulness!” says my seven-year-old. “I can’t remember anything.”

He was lamenting that he’d forgotten his plan to hold his pet snake that day. Meanwhile, I’m lamenting everything else: He can’t remember to take his backpack to the car and from the car to the classroom and then from the classroom to the car, without me doing it for him. And I have adult ADHD. So if we take his backpack somewhere, we will leave it there. It pretty much lives at a friend’s house until we go pick it up. I need to put an alarm on the damn thing or tie it to him or something.

I’m also lamenting that I have to make my coffee with freaking almond milk because I forgot to buy creamer. That’s if I remembered to buy coffee in the first place. If not, I’m stuck bundling children in pajamas into the car and driving to Starbucks. Then there’s breakfast: Did I remember to get bread for the kids and yogurt for me? If not, it’s another car trip to the local drive-through diner for eggs, bacon, and hash browns. They know me so well that they gave me a Christmas card with my name on it this year. This is disturbing for people who see me only without makeup on.

Then it’s school time—and I homeschool my kids. We’re usually pretty good about it, but there are always quirks: We have to find the book we’re reading. We have to find the pencil sharpener, the good paper. I now leave the official school record book in the same place every single time and update it every single day. Last year it got lost under the loveseat for two months, and I had to somehow reconstruct 14 days of learning. Luckily, it was only kindergarten, and I dated artwork.

After that, did I remember to do laundry? I have to fish out clothes for three kids and myself. It’s a question of whether they remembered to put underwear on under their pajamas, but I think that’s a boy thing unrelated to ADHD. And it’s depressingly hard to dress three kids in matching, clean, unstained clothing. I shoot for adorable, which means lots of layered shirts, so they have to remember which shirt goes on top and which goes on the bottom and put them on in the correct order (even if they’re laid out in the correct order, this seems bafflingly difficult). Then I have to remember if the cute plaid pants are clean and pick if I will put the kids in the plaid pants or the plaid shirt. If I let them dress themselves, they’ll wear pajamas. It’s probably because of all our pajama-ed morning outings.

And poor Blaise. He’s always losing his toys. LEGO people come apart and never go back together in quite the same way. Pretend kitchen parts (meant for the bedroom) end up in the living room. Hot Wheels find their garage under the couch. Markers get lost; favorite dinosaurs end up under the dresser.

Don't talk to me about our record with library books—not regular library books, but those stupid DK Star Wars books my kids seem to need to get by the bundle. I finally decreed that the books had to stay in the car. That way, at least I know in what general area they're lost. We'll probably have to pay for them anyway.

At least we don't lose the dogs, though sometimes I think my husband with ADHD fed them, and he thinks I fed them, and about mid-afternoon, they're barking and woofing at me and following me obsessively from room to room. I make sure to give them a special treat when that happens: bread, leftover chicken tenders, whatever my kids haven't eaten. This food is inevitably gluten-free and more expensive than heroin. In this house, even the dogs are accidentally milk- and gluten-free. We just have to get them off soy now, and we're golden.

At least I remember to feed the kids. Well, most of the time. They're growing, so they want five meals a day, and I'm programmed for three, so two meals get lost somewhere. They have to start whining before I'm offering a banana or toast or waffles or whatever I can whip up without much effort: apple slices, maybe, or fruit cocktail, both of which are universally reviled until put on the table. By that point, though, they hate everything until they eat. I have to remember kids need to eat three meals and two snacks a day—and when snack time falls. Also, granola bars in the car. I need to remember granola bars and juice boxes for the car.

We live in the kingdom of forgetfulness. It's like the Greek Isle of the Lotus Eaters, except with dog hair and laundry and credit cards (which I've lost). But somehow, we muddle along. Even when I forget Blaise's ukulele lessons three weeks running, with a personal text from the instructor, we manage. We do art and read books and take the dogs for walks. We're happy. We could probably use a planner. But I'd probably lose it, and stress out. So we're happy just the way we are. If only we could forget a little less.

This article was written by Elizabeth Broadent, an ADDitude contributor and blogger.

“Why Do I Keep Forgetting Things? Learning to Forgive My ADHD Brain”

By Les Steed

I recently had an awkward moment with a friend who quietly mentioned that I forgot his birthday. I've been a very busy bee lately and pretty knocked out after work due to a blur of meetings, new hands to shake, and new responsibilities to learn. I completely forgot. It's sad because he matters to me. There's no worse feeling than being forgotten—it shows a lack of care from someone who matters to you.

Why Do I Keep Forgetting Things?

Since the pandemic, I've avoided social media because it's not good for my self-esteem to see other people's highlight reels. (Why are some people seemingly on holiday every weekend for no reason?)

But with intentional and positive abstention comes ignorance around birthdays and party invites. It doesn't matter if I'm directly told something. I still forget what neurotypical people instinctively remember.

I get so engrossed in what's immediately in front of me and what I'm doing that sometimes little notifications about non-urgent things get lost among my endlessly shifting priorities. This is not to say I don't acknowledge them, but I have days where I realize it's no longer April but almost mid-May. Months fly by, and I don't notice that the seasons have changed until it gets suspiciously sunny or cold, and it's always cold here in England!

So, I do my best to keep putting things on my calendar. But sometimes I just forget. As a result, I've started adding personal to-dos to my work to-do list. If a friend's birthday happens while I'm on deadline, I can pick up on it at the end of the day. But there are always cracks and days when my working memory fails.

ADHD Forgetfulness

While much of my forgetfulness and other memory-related traits are related to my ADHD, a lot of it is simply being human—not a bad friend. I don't like hurting people, and I rarely do so on purpose. (One of my friends with ADHD has the same issues with being forgetful. I'll only hear from her every two months, usually with a flurry of messages starting with “Sorry, sorry, sorry, I'm so s***!”)

People are the most important part of my life. I write for an audience. I learn from conversations. I work with and for my colleagues, and I'm loyal as a dog to people who treat me well (and, unfortunately, sometimes to those who don't). So, when these forgetful blips happen, I beat the crap out of myself—the shame is pretty intense.

To mitigate this, I've learned that it's best to simply say "sorry" and send a friend a little something, even if it's just a late card with a corny joke. A small token gift doesn't make up for forgetting, but it does acknowledge them and ensures that the other person knows they matter to me.

Les Steed is an ADDitude contributor, former international news journalist, and podcast host.

“The Tower of Bottles in My Kitchen—and More Proof of Creative ADHD Problem-Solving”

By Stephanie Wilson, CNC

Some time ago, I came down for breakfast and discovered a curious stack of bottles in the kitchen. It was a resolute stack. It knew it wanted to be there. I knew I didn't want it to be there. One was a vitamin bottle, another an allergy pill bottle, and a third a prescription pill bottle. The three were stacked on top of one another in the middle of my otherwise pristine and shiny counter.

It drove me bananas.

Why was it there? I knew it was thanks to my husband, but why was he doing this? It was different than the way he usually left his things. This was intentional, and that bugged me even more. I thought, “He's standing there stacking this thing for the niftiness of it, probably admiring it for some physics or mathematical property and walking away without a care for how the house looks.”

Grrrr.

I unstacked the bottles and put them back in their little nook.

The next day, the stack returned.

This seesaw continued—him stacking, me unstacking.

I should mention that my husband and I both have ADHD. He's brilliant, unruffled, and messy. I'm creative, a worrier, and organized. We make a great team.

But the combination sometimes presents challenges, as with the enigma of the tower of bottles in the kitchen. What's more, even after our diagnoses (mine came well after his), I still spent so many years in the dark about ADHD and how we each manage it. That all started to change for me when I decided to become an ADHD coach.

An Annoying Habit? Or Creative Problem-Solving at Work?

In the midst of our stacking and unstacking, I happened to be in coaching training and learning about “externalizing” as a strategy for managing ADHD issues with memory and forgetfulness. Externalizing comes in many forms—paper and digital planners, buzzers, alarms, vibrating watches, timers, visual cueing—you name it, it's out there.

I marveled at these tools and admired those with ADHD who sought out these strategies, experimented with them, and incorporated them into their lives.

So there I was, admiring folks who used cues while, at the same time, over in my kitchen, getting peeved about The Stack and unstacking it.

Until one day, it hit me.

Wait a second. Is this—? Could it be—?

I went downstairs when I heard my husband making dinner.

“Honey,” I asked with curiosity, “why do you stack those pill bottles? I never really asked you.” He shrugged matter-of-factly.

“It’s a way to remember to take my pills. I’d been forgetting. If they are stacked, it tells me I haven’t taken them yet.”

I closed my eyes. Seeing how easy it was for me to assume and not delve further was stunning.

Truthfully, it never occurred to me there might be anything else to understand about my husband’s bottle stacking. Yet there I was, blind to something so remarkable.

Talk about humbling. Talk about how celebratory I suddenly felt, too, about living with ADHD.

ADHD Brains Are Solution-Oriented

There’s a creative current that runs through our ADHD self-management systems that we sometimes don’t see or acknowledge in ourselves. We come to the table with self-knowledge already in place, knowing through trial and error what has worked and what hasn’t, that we don’t often give ourselves credit for.

When my husband revealed his own self-care solution in the kitchen that day, I was so proud of him. I realized there is much yet for me to learn about him, myself, and others with ADHD.

I’m so ready.

So, if you see a tower of stacked vitamin and prescription bottles in the middle of my kitchen counter right now, please know that it is not due to madness or some passive-aggressive stunt. It’s due to brilliant self-awareness.

The following *ADDitude* experts and authors contributed to this chapter: Steph Alexander; Eileen Bailey; Elizabeth Broadbent; Tristan Hunt, BSc.; Sandy Maynard; Sharon Saline, Psy.D.; Les Steed; Ari Tuckman, Psy.D.; and Stephanie Wilson, CNC.

CHAPTER 6

Inhibition/ Self-Restraint: Managing Impulsivity & Distractions

Chapter 6: Inhibition/Self-Restraint: Managing Impulsivity & Distractions

Impulsivity and the ADHD Brain: Neural Networks, Explained!

Impulsivity is not rudeness or lack of self-discipline but a function of the interior signaling system of the brain.

ADHD weakens communication between different regions of the brain, contributing to inattention, impulsivity, and emotional dysregulation. Impulsivity, a primary symptom of ADHD, may impair your ability to stop and think about the consequences before speaking or acting.

The thalamus area of the brain controls response inhibition. It works like a gate—sending signals to allow or stop behaviors.

When the brain detects a red flag, its limbic-hippocampal connections relay a warning from the thalamus to the prefrontal cortex (the brain's control center that handles emotional expression and problem-solving).

In ADHD brains, the thalamus gate is broken. That means a person with ADHD may struggle to:

- Hold back a comment that may hurt someone's feelings
- Lack the self-restraint to rein in short-term desires such as eating candy or spending money

In other words, this is not simply rudeness or lack of self-discipline. It is a function of the interior signaling system of the brain.

CHAPTER 6: INHIBITION/SELF-RESTRAINT: MANAGING IMPULSIVITY & DISTRACTIONS

How to Hit Pause on ADHD Impulsivity

By Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D.

Do you feel like you're on an ADHD treadmill?

Deadlines at work come and go, unmet. Impulsive comments alienate friends and could possibly cost you your job. You're exhausted at the end of the day, and yet you feel that all your effort gets you nowhere.

ADHD medication can level the playing field, but you can do more. Just as eating healthy and exercising help insulin do a better job for diabetics, these five rules will complement ADHD meds for better symptom control.

Rule #1: Stop the Action

Your boss proposes doubling your sales goals for next year, and before you can bite your tongue, you laugh and say, "Are you crazy?"

Your neighbor buys a new lawn ornament and asks you if you like it. You tell him it makes his house look like a cheap motel. Now he's not speaking to you—again.

You see a gorgeous pair of designer shoes in a store window and rush in to buy them, even though every penny of your paycheck is already spoken for.

You don't give yourself time to think and measure your words and actions. Thinking means using hindsight and foresight to assess a situation and determine what you should say or do.

Strategy: Make a list of the situations in which you are most likely to behave impulsively. There are times and places where it's OK to be spontaneous and talkative, and other times when acting this way will cost you dearly.

When you are about to enter one of the situations you've identified, buy yourself a few thoughtful seconds by performing any of the following actions:

- Before you answer someone, inhale slowly, exhale slowly, put on a thoughtful expression, and say to yourself, "Well, let me think about that."

CHAPTER 6: INHIBITION/SELF-RESTRAINT: MANAGING IMPULSIVITY & DISTRACTIONS

- Put a finger over your mouth for a few seconds, as if you're considering what you're going to say.
- Paraphrase what your boss or family member said to you: "Oh, so you want to know about..." or "You're asking me to..."
- Imagine locking your mouth with a key to prevent yourself from speaking.
- Take a long drink of water from your water bottle.

Another strategy: Choose a slow-talking model (an actor, sports analyst, politician, etc.) and play that role. Slow it down. Practice speaking slowly in front of a mirror. This will give your frontal lobes a chance to get some traction, to get engaged, instead of being swept along on the tide of your impulses.

Rule #2: See the Past... Then Move Forward

When a problem arises, are you confused about what will happen or what to do? Do you beat yourself up for making the same mistakes again and again?

Adults with ADHD have weak non-verbal working memory, which means they don't draw on hindsight to guide their actions. They're not good at recognizing the subtle aspects of problems, and the various tools that might solve them. Many adults with ADHD hit every problem with a hammer, because, to them, all problems look like nails.

Adults with ADHD may find it hard to defer gratification—which you must do to save money or stick to eating healthy because they can't call up the mental image of the prize that lies ahead. You need a tool to make sure that what you learned from the past is accessible when you need it in the future.

Strategy: Stopping the action—as described in Rule #1—gives you the time to turn on the mind's eye. Once you've done that, picture a visual device—a flat-screen T.V., a computer monitor, or your phone—and visualize, on that imaginary screen, what happened the last time you were in a similar situation. Let the past unfold in colorful detail as if you're filming or replaying it.

The more often you do this, the more automatic it will become. What's more, you'll find that more "videos" will pop into your brain from your memory bank. You might think, "Wow, the last time I interrupted a meeting with a joke, everyone laughed at me, not at

CHAPTER 6: INHIBITION/SELF-RESTRAINT: MANAGING IMPULSIVITY & DISTRACTIONS

the punch line.” Or, “I felt guilty when I bought those expensive shoes several months ago, only to discover that my son needed books for school. I couldn’t afford them.”

Rule #3: Feel the Future

Many individuals with ADHD are time-blind; they forget the purpose of their tasks, so they are uninspired to finish them. If no one dangles a carrot in front of them, they may need some convincing to keep moving toward their goal. That’s why Rule #2 is important: It helps you learn from your memories to become adept at handling similar situations in the future.

But Rule #2 is not always enough. Some things have to get done because it is the right thing to do. ADHD sometimes makes it tough to grasp the moral imperative for completing a task. Imagining the negative consequences of not doing something is not a potent motivator for most people with ADHD. Imagining how great it will feel to get to your goal works better.

Strategy: Ask yourself, “What will I feel like when I finish this project?” It could be pride, self-satisfaction, or the happiness you anticipate from completing the project. Whatever the emotion is, work hard to feel it, then and there, as you contemplate your goal. Every time you sit down to continue working on the project, try to feel the future outcome.

Give this technique a boost by cutting out or printing pictures of the rewards you hope to earn from what you are doing. Place them around you while you work. They’ll enhance the potency of imagery and make the emotions you’re anticipating even more vivid.

Rule #4: Break It Down... and Make It Matter

ADHD makes the future seem far away. A goal that requires a significant investment of time, incorporates waiting periods, or requires a sequence of steps can feel overwhelmingly elusive. When that happens, many people with ADHD look for an escape route. They might call in sick at work or shunt the responsibility to a co-worker.

Figure out which situations will likely shut you down: Do you panic when someone gives you a deadline months from now? Do complex projects daunt you? Do you have trouble working without supervision? If so, you need some external motivators.

Strategy: Break down long-term tasks or goals into smaller units. If an end-of-the-day deadline seems remote to you, try this strategy:

CHAPTER 6: INHIBITION/SELF-RESTRAINT: MANAGING IMPULSIVITY & DISTRACTIONS

1. **Break your task into one-hour or half-hour chunks of work.** Write down what you need to get done in each period and run a highlighter over each step as you work on it, to keep your attention focused.
2. **Double your chances of success by making yourself accountable to another person.** Most of us care what others think of us, and social judgment fuels the fire to get things done. Make yourself accountable to a supportive coworker, supervisor, or mentor at work. At home, work with a partner, spouse, or neighbor.

After finishing each piece of work, do four things: Congratulate yourself, take a short break, call or text a friend or a relative to tell them about your accomplishment, and give yourself a reward or some privilege you enjoy—just make sure it's small and brief.

Rule #5: Keep a Sense of Humor

ADHD may be serious, but you don't have to be.

Strategy: Learn to say, with a smile, “Well, there goes my ADHD shouting out again. Sorry about that. My mistake. I have to try to do something about that next time.”

When you say this, you've done four important things:

1. You owned the mistake.
2. You explained why the mistake happened.
3. You apologized and made no excuse by blaming others.
4. You promised to try to do better next time.

Do these things, and you will keep your self-esteem—and your friends. Disowning your ADHD conduct, blaming others, or not trying to do better next time will cost you.

If you make ADHD an all-encompassing disability, your friends and family will treat it that way, as well.

Approach it with a sense of humor, and they will too.

12 Ways to Resist Impulse Buying: ADHD Shopping Secrets

Spontaneous spending—and financial headaches—are common among people with ADHD, who struggle with impulsive behaviors, poor planning skills, and other executive dysfunctions.

Impulse buying is an unrelenting temptation—because it's so easy and so instantly rewarding. Buying things on the spur of the moment triggers a rush of adrenaline and dopamine associated with positive emotions. It feels good, but not for long; stress soon follows when we realize the negative consequences of our purchases, namely, money problems.

Here are a handful of strategies to successfully put a lid on impulse buying—or at least limit it considerably.

How to Stop Impulse Buying with ADHD

- 1. Use cash only** when you shop in stores, and only take the specific amount that you are willing to spend per outing. This will help you focus on obtaining only what you need to purchase and prevent you from reaching for your credit cards or even your smartphone for payments.
- 2. Carry cash in moderate bills** (e.g., \$5, \$10) so you will be less tempted to break a bill for a small, unnecessary item.
- 3. Make it a rule not to buy anything in the checkout lane**, be it physical or virtual.
- 4. Limit the number of times you visit a store or shop online.** Only go if you have a list with a plan of what you intend to purchase.
- 5. Take someone with you when shopping in person.** If you find yourself shopping online, tell a friend immediately. Provide them with your shopping plan so they can help you be accountable for your buying.
- 6. Delete credit card and other payment information from places you frequent online**, especially where you frequently make impulse purchases (this includes eliminating credit card information from your virtual wallet). You'll be less tempted to make a purchase if you must fill out your information every time.

CHAPTER 6: INHIBITION/SELF-RESTRAINT: MANAGING IMPULSIVITY & DISTRACTIONS

7. **If you really want something, wait 24 hours before buying it.** Give yourself a day to answer these questions: Do I need this? Will it significantly improve my life? Is it worth the cost? If you can answer yes to all, make the purchase.
8. **Calculate the item's value compared to the hours you need to work to afford it.** Is it worth that much to you?
9. **Unsubscribe from all retail emails, newsletters, and texts** so you won't be tempted to spend money on unnecessary items.
10. **Try a month-long No-Spending Challenge**, during which you limit yourself to buying groceries and necessities.
11. **Allow yourself a treat purchase** that is within your budget and keeps you from feeling deprived of the joy of shopping. Keep the tags on your treat items for a day so you can return them if you change your mind.
12. **Visually remind yourself of your saving goals.** Put a picture of your saving goal on your phone's lock screen, fridge, bathroom door, and your car's dashboard to remind you that limiting impulse buying will be beneficial in the long run.

Controlling impulsive behavior can be difficult, but these tips can help make it possible. Happy saving!

This article was written by Mareen Dennis, MS, LPP.

Stop Spending So Much Money! An ADHD Budgeting Guide

Remember: A “deal” is only good if you can afford it. Resist overspending throughout the year by following this step-by-step guide for devising a budget that an adult with ADHD can actually stick to.

For most people—especially impulsive and energetic people with ADHD—the thought of creating a budget sparks dread and anxiety. What’s more monotonous and depressing than meticulously calculating exactly what you can’t afford? But figuring out a personal finance plan that you can live with doesn’t have to be torture. With our 10-step guide, you can create a plan that keeps you from spending too much money and leaves some room for the occasional splurge.

1. Define the Budget

Sit down and define what “budgeting” means to you and why you need it. Be honest with yourself and admit if you inherently hate the word. Then, reposition the budget as a necessary step that allows you to plan and not worry about having money to pay your bills. List 10 good reasons to create healthy spending habits, and then post it where you pay your bills. Individuals with ADHD thrive with specific action plans. Think of this as your financial to-do list.

2. Don’t Spend More Than You Make

The key to an effective budget? Spend less than your total income. It sounds simple enough, but it requires careful financial record keeping—not usually our strong point. For one month, record every purchase you make. Get a receipt whenever possible and print out receipts of online purchases immediately. Consider using an app that tracks on-the-go spending.

3. Tally Up Your Lessons Learned

During your month of tracking, use a money journal (this can be a spreadsheet, notebook, sticky notes, etc.—whatever works best for you) to increase your spending awareness—and question whether each purchase is worthwhile. Adults with ADHD are prone to overspending, especially during the holidays. Willpower alone can’t stop it. Instead, take five minutes a day to write down who you are buying for, and set a cap for how much you will spend. Record your feelings when you make certain purchases.

CHAPTER 6: INHIBITION/SELF-RESTRAINT: MANAGING IMPULSIVITY & DISTRACTIONS

4. Ask, “What Can I Change?”

Review your journal at the end of the month and look for patterns in your spending habits. Ask yourself:

- How did I overspend?
- How did I rationalize it?
- How do I define luxury vs. necessity?
- How did overspending make me feel?
- What would I have to change to stick to my budget?

5. Cut Costs

Certain costs, of course, are fixed. So look for discretionary places you’ve been splurging. Did you buy new books, even though your shelves are groaning under the load of unread ones? Did you buy another outfit, even though your closet is full of clothes you’ve barely worn? Did sale items lure you in? Or did you go crazy at the grocery store?

6. Devise Solutions

Try these ideas to avoid overspending:

- If your bank charges you excessive administrative fees, open a free checking account and set up automatic bill payment.
- Leave credit cards and extra cash at home if you’re making impulsive purchases.
- If ADHD treatment drains your wallet, research state programs that help cover the cost of medical expenses, plus tax deductions.

7. Create Your Budget

List all your fixed and discretionary expenses for a typical month. Aim to save 10% of your monthly income, and always have three times your spendable income (after taxes) in the bank just in case of emergencies. Then, adopt an attitude of gratitude. Your budget meets your basic needs, so you’re not “doing without.” You’ll be more likely to stick to the plan if it includes some fun spending.

CHAPTER 6: INHIBITION/SELF-RESTRAINT: MANAGING IMPULSIVITY & DISTRACTIONS

8. Plan for Budget Busters

No matter how well you plan, unexpected events and emergencies will pop up. The best budgets account for this. Take preventative measures to stave off big expenses. See a doctor regularly to manage your family's health. Complete routine maintenance on your home and car. Have extra money set aside, just in case, for when these events inevitably occur. Include the amount in your savings budget (See No. #7).

9. Organize the ADHD Way

Keep your financial documents in order year-round for the best tax refund. Use an ADHD-friendly system. Set up a monthly folder system to store critical financial records. Color-code any additional folders for the type of document they hold. Bribe yourself with a special treat to ensure that you organize the papers monthly.

10. Get Help When You Need It

Many people find using a computerized financial program like Microsoft Money or Quicken helpful. If you need help using the software or are overwhelmed by the process in general, consult an accountant or financially savvy friend.

“A \$400 Adrenaline Rush”: Stories of Impulse Buying with ADHD

If you’ve ever found a new shirt... an electronic gadget... or a vehicle too tempting to resist, only to regret the purchase later, you’re not alone.

Impulsivity due to poor executive functioning is one of the most common—and most expensive—symptoms of ADHD. It prompts individuals to open their wallets for unplanned purchases, which often go unused, and sometimes become a source of regret.

Here, *ADDitude* readers share their stories of impulse buys from big-ticket items (speed-boat, anyone?) to minor acquisitions (fetching fake eyelashes)—and how they felt after making their purchases.

“I have spent more than \$1,000 in a month on the Candy Crush game, just absentmindedly and impulsively clicking to buy more in-game currency. It wasn’t until I looked at my bank statement that I realized how much I had spent. I was so embarrassed.”

“A dog and a \$25,000 hot tub. The reason for buying? I have no idea. Regrets TBD.”

“I bought a fully functional factory time clock. It’s a gorgeous retro industrial green, and I thought it would be fun to punch in and out of un-fun tasks. But it’s really big and heavy, and it makes an annoying thumping sound, and of course, I didn’t think about where I could put it. So it’s hiding in my bathroom under the laundry hamper. But it’s so cool! I don’t need it, it’s in my way; I should regret it, but I don’t. I kind of like being the person who has this sort of thing hiding in the laundry.”

“I got it in my head that we needed a boat. A few days later, we overpaid for a used boat (\$18.5k!). It did get us through that summer, but we only used it once the following summer and not at all this summer. Luckily, we got almost all our money back when we sold it.”

“False eyelashes on Amazon!”

“In the last month, I’ve bought a brand-new cellphone (plus high-end accessories) and a spontaneous 10-day vacation. I regret doing both.”

CHAPTER 6: INHIBITION/SELF-RESTRAINT: MANAGING IMPULSIVITY & DISTRACTIONS

“Two days ago, I saw a road bike complete with new shoes. I bought my new hobby, filled with excitement but also a sense of failure hovering. Experience tells me that I will get all the gear and ride the bike twice, after which it and all its accouterments will become wall art in my garage. Sigh. **I am slowly learning, but it’s too late for this \$400 adrenaline rush.**”

“Most of my impulse purchases are food or snack-related. While not expensive individually, I’m sure **I’ve spent thousands on small unnecessary snacks** over the years.”

“Two pairs of black summer trousers, size Long. **I didn’t consider the expense then but felt guilty afterward;** my budget had no spare money. I decided I could make do with my jeans, so I returned them. It was a huge relief not to increase the debt on my credit card.”

“I saw the emotional last showing of the genius, Tony-Award-winning Broadway musical Company. That day, I decided to pay about double, including fees, for tickets. It was an amazing experience I will always remember. **I only regret not deciding sooner, to save money and stress!**”

Is Your ADHD Causing Social Slip-Ups?

By Ari Tuckman, Psy.D.

Have you ever had a conversation with a friend, coworker, or acquaintance that starts well but takes a turn for the worse? Your conversation mate suddenly signals that they have to take a call in the middle of an important point you're making or respond less and less to what you think are clever remarks.

Good social skills require attention. We need to notice the cues that tell us what someone thinks or feels. This social dexterity allows us to hold back comments so we can follow the conversation's progression. Without these skills, it's easy to step on toes and lose friends. Keep these strategies in mind to avoid social slip-ups.

Enthusiasm Overload

Steph, who is diagnosed with ADHD, learned this the hard way when she met her boyfriend's parents. Wanting to make a good impression, she eagerly participated in the conversation, only to find his parents getting quieter through dinner. In the car going home, her boyfriend pointed out that she cut his parents off to make her points. She was shocked that her enthusiasm had offended them.

People with ADHD know what they should do. They sometimes have trouble doing it. Steph knows why her boyfriend's parents didn't like being interrupted, but she couldn't adjust her behavior because she didn't realize she was doing it. Her boyfriend's parents were not enamored of her.

Steph talked to her boyfriend about the pressure she felt to make a good impression, and how she hadn't realized that she was interrupting. She fixed the situation by sending them a thank-you card for the dinner and writing a note explaining that her excitement to meet them had gotten the best of her. She ended on a positive note, telling them she looked forward to getting together again.

As she thought about it, she realized that she interrupts others when excited or nervous. She talked to her boyfriend about it, and they agreed that he would tap her under the table if he noticed too much enthusiasm. This gave them both more confidence that future outings would go better.

Miscommunication on the Job

Social situations at work are harder to address because we don't have a partner nearby to nudge us. Fortunately, most people have only a few behaviors that they repeat. If you can identify two or three ways you get into trouble, you can notice when they happen.

Think about what supervisors have noted in your evaluations as areas to work on. If you have a coworker you trust, ask for their candid advice.

When Roberto did this, he was told that he looked like he was lost in thought during conversations and meetings. This made others think that he was bored. Roberto took this information to heart and thought about ways to look more engaged.

When he caught himself drifting off, he made a point of showing that he was engaged in the conversation by making eye contact. If he felt he had missed too much, or the other person was offended at his seeming disinterest, he'd say, "I'm sorry, I got caught up thinking about what you said in the beginning and missed the rest of your comments. Could you repeat them?" This showed his supervisor and coworkers that he was indeed interested in what they said.

Canceling Commitments

James knew that he bit off more than he could chew, but he didn't realize how often he did this until a friend angrily pointed out that he always canceled plans at the last minute. As James thought about it, he realized that he had the same problem at work as in his personal life—lots of projects and activities were interesting at the moment, so he would agree to them too quickly, without thinking about how they would fit into his existing commitments.

James made a two-part plan. The first part was to make sure he put commitments on his phone calendar. The second part was to resist agreeing to anything new (no matter how interesting) without first checking his calendar and honestly assessing whether he could fit it in. He still occasionally took on too much, but it happened less often, which made a big difference in how people thought of him.

Don't Be Defensive

Getting advice from a friend or family member, solicited or otherwise, is a good way to learn about our social blind spots. People with ADHD, though, are generally quick to get defensive when it comes to receiving advice. Here is a constructive way of looking at feedback from others:

- Remember that no one likes getting negative feedback, but if the feedback is accurate, it will save you more pain later.

- Ask yourself whether the person is giving the feedback with good intentions and is trying to be helpful.
- Ask yourself whether you have gotten similar feedback from others. If so, it is more likely to be accurate and reasonable.
- Stop yourself from responding and listen to what they are saying. Ask for specific examples to ensure that you understand what they mean.
- Remember that it is your choice to follow the advice, but also remember that the benefits will be yours as well.

How to Break Your Habit of Oversharing

Oh, no, you've said too much. Again. If you often find yourself in TMI mode, use these tips to control ADHD impulsivity and stop oversharing in social settings.

Do you impulsively unload private details to new acquaintances? Do you feel an inexplicable urge to break awkward silences or build connections by divulging intimate, sometimes inappropriate, information about yourself? Do you find it difficult to stop oversharing, even when you know that you're making others uncomfortable?

Neurodivergent minds like ours are prone to oversharing because we love to immediately zing with people. We enjoy giving, sharing, and feeling like someone is our best friend within five minutes of meeting them. We want to convey to others that we're an open book. That we're sincere and authentic. A lifetime of challenges with social skills and making friends can also drive us to overshare in a desperate bid for connection.

Even if you exude high-quality friendship material, oversharing, as you know, isn't the best way to show it. In fact, it often backfires.

Curbing your habit of oversharing will come with time, but doing so requires patience. Use these eight strategies to help you reel in your speech and share mindfully.

How to Stop Oversharing

1. Get to the root of it. Think back to moments when you've shared too much. Did you do it because you couldn't stand the silence? Because you were nervous and dysregulated during the social interaction? Because you underestimated your intimacy level with the person or group? Did you even realize it was happening, or did someone point it out? Is it a combination of factors? Recognizing circumstances and situations that lead to oversharing is the first step to breaking the habit.

2. Go into "social spy" mode. Not sure what counts as oversharing? Try picking up on what others share about themselves and the varying degrees of familiarity in a group. Notice the unspoken rules that govern these conversations, and how others respond when someone discloses a detail about themselves. If a trusted friend was part of the conversation, ask them later if they felt someone overshared and compare your answers.

CHAPTER 6: INHIBITION/SELF-RESTRAINT: MANAGING IMPULSIVITY & DISTRACTIONS

3. Gamify it! Challenge yourself to ask a certain number of questions before you start talking about yourself. You will reduce your chances of oversharing and be in a better position to bring up relevant topics for discussion.

4. Think, “How much do I trust this person?” Before you share an aspect of your personal life, pause and consider your level of familiarity with the person. Are they a friend, or are they becoming a friend? Put yourself in their shoes: If they were to share what you’re about to share with them, would it make you feel uncomfortable, given your current level of familiarity? (Tip: Carry something in your pocket to remind you of this question!)

5. Assess your emotional state to gauge your susceptibility to oversharing. A heightened or dysregulated state may make you more likely to, for example, vent to the receptionist about an earlier fight you had with your spouse as you check in for your doctor’s appointment.

6. Practice telling tighter stories. There’s nothing wrong with sharing stories. But you risk oversharing if you tend to go off on a tangent. Before you share, ask yourself: “What do I want others to take away from my story? What’s its point?” If you catch yourself going down the rabbit hole mid-conversation, don’t fret. Gently steer yourself back and chuckle it off.

7. It doesn’t have to be all or nothing. Perhaps the detail or story you want to share verges into oversharing territory. Rather than throw it out completely, use it to inspire a more neutral talking point.

8. Don’t beat yourself up. Changing a habit takes time. Remember that you’re in practice mode each time you enter a conversation. You’re not expecting perfection; you’re just working on a small piece of the puzzle. You’ll have good days and days when you’ll tell the person at the post office your life story. That’s okay. Tomorrow you’ll do better.

This article was written by Caroline Maguire, M.Ed., ACCG, PCC, the founder of a social emotional learning methodology that breaks down the complexity of human connection into easy, actionable steps, and the author of Why Will No One Play with Me?

The Body-Brain Connection: How Fidgeting Sharpens Focus

By Roland Rotz, Ph.D., and Sarah D. Wright, A.C.T.

“Focus!” “Mind over matter!” “You can do anything if you really want to!” “Just try harder!”

Anyone with ADHD has heard these exhortations and has probably shared them with others struggling to concentrate. The ADHD brain is indeed a powerful force for success.

But we know that relying on the brain can be frustrating and, at times, demoralizing. Our ADHD brains aren’t our most reliable asset—allowing distractions to break our focus. But what if there were strategies that could prime our brains beyond “just trying harder”?

There are. Research suggests that the body affects the brain as much as the brain affects the body. In his book, *Spark*, John Ratey, M.D., shows that physical activity—even something as small as fidgeting the hands—increases levels of the neurotransmitters dopamine and norepinephrine in a similar way that ADHD medications do. Both chemicals play a key role in sharpening focus and increasing attention.

It’s true that many people are successful only when they do one thing at a time, but for adults with ADHD, the opposite is usually true. We need to respect the fact that there is neural diversity, that different people have different ways of doing things—not from preference or contrariness, but from need.

Be Deliberate

Fidgeting must be deliberate to be effective. Intentional fidgets allow you to self-regulate ADHD symptoms in a controlled, constructive fashion. An effective fidget doesn’t distract you from a primary task because it is something you don’t have to think about.

For example, doodling while listening to a work meeting helps you better absorb what’s being said. Walking while talking helps the mind tune in to a conversation without missing a beat. We encourage respectful fidgeting—something that doesn’t bother others.

For example, drumming your fingers or clicking your pen during work would distract coworkers; wiggling your toes inside your shoes would not.

Experiment with a variety of strategies and try different fidgets. Listening to music while reading may work wonders for one adult’s focus, while another may prefer keeping their hands busy—squeezing a rubber ball or fiddling with a ring.

Fun and Functional Fidgets

Here are nine fidgets worth trying:

- 1. Get active.** When you get restless and find you are tuning out an important conversation, try walking and talking. Any non-strenuous activity, like doing a jigsaw puzzle together, will also work.
- 2. Use multicolored pens and pencils.** This fidget works well when reading something lengthy or for comprehension. (You can underline words as you read.) Scented markers may also help.
- 3. Keep hands busy.** This facilitates focus when you are listening, talking, or thinking about how to answer a tough question. This could include, beaded bracelets, paper clips (they bend into interesting shapes and can be linked together), a small, smooth stone—or worry rock (placed in your pocket, it allows you to fiddle without others knowing), and clothes with interesting textures or doodads.
- 4. Tune in.** Listening to music helps adults stay on task when studying or reading. Choose music that is appropriate to the task.
- 5. Chew gum or suck on candy.** This helps when you need to concentrate for an extended period. If gum is not an option, sucking on a hard candy will do the trick, and it may be less distracting.
- 6. Beat the clock.** Set a timer for 20 minutes, and race to get as much done as possible before the alarm goes off.
- 7. Stand up, move around, or stretch.** The movement will give you a reset and help you focus.

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Sarah D. Wright, A.C.T., is an ADHD expert, life coach, and co-author of Fidget to Focus, with Roland Rotz, Ph.D.

How to Focus at Work When You're Bored, Distracted, or Tired

Distracting coworkers. Messy desks. Monotonous work. Focusing on the job isn't easy when you're bored, overwhelmed, tired, or distracted. Here, *ADDitude* readers share their tricks for finding focus at work.

"I keep a notepad and pen in my pocket to jot down random ideas or tasks that float into forethought. This combats distraction by allowing me to keep a record of tasks that aren't an immediate priority."

"I list three things that are the priority to get done this hour/half hour. When I finish, I do three more things. One item is not interesting enough to keep me focused."

"I walk a lap around the office before sitting down to focus on a report."

"I tend to be a 'piler' of papers. The 'touch a paper only once' rule doesn't work very well for me. What does work is **putting a sticky note on each paper in the pile with the next step for that piece of paper.** Maybe it says, 'file in bills,' or 'make three copies,' or 'take to the office.' This makes that pile seem less intimidating because I know I won't have to think so hard when I get to it."

"I work in a noisy office with cubicles. **I have a small desk fan that provides just enough white noise to 'drown out' most of the people talking.** It works wonders. Instead of hearing every conversation and being tempted to join, I have to strain to hear."

"I have a **voice recorder** that I use to record ideas or tasks that I must do."

"I go to work 30-45 minutes early, shut my door, and get work done when it is quiet with no distractions."

"When I have a list of tasks to do, **I complete the 'fun' tasks first.** Doing so helps 'rev up' my brain with enough positivity to more easily muscle through the remaining 'boring' tasks."

"I use a **stability ball** at work; I notice the difference when I don't."

CHAPTER 6: INHIBITION/SELF-RESTRAINT: MANAGING IMPULSIVITY & DISTRACTIONS

“I place a small piece of the scratchy side of Velcro on the table next to me. When I’m drifting or foggy, I just rub my finger on it, and before I realize it, I’m back in the zone.”

12 Ways to Maintain Focus All Day Long

“Why can’t I focus?” You learned long ago that good intentions don’t magically translate into concentration—particularly when a task is boring, difficult, or even critical. These 12 ADHD-friendly strategies will help you develop the muscles for real, sustained attention.

You’ve crafted your to-do list. You’ve gathered your supplies. You know what you need to do. And yet when the time comes to complete the task, your brain drifts off.

Why is focus—both finding it and pulling it back when it starts to stray—so difficult for people with ADHD? The answer lies in brain chemistry: ADHD brains are naturally low on dopamine and norepinephrine, which control brain arousal and attention levels. Other people may find that they can “buckle down” and force their brains to focus when a situation calls for it. For people with ADHD, the advice to “just focus” is maddening; it simply can’t be done.

You can’t force focus, but you can create an ideal physical and mental environment for it to thrive. The key is working with (not against) your ADHD brain. Follow these 12 tips to get started.

1. Remember the Zeigarnik Effect

The “Zeigarnik Effect” is the principle that unfinished tasks are harder to get out of your brain than are tasks that haven’t been started. This means that starting a project—even if you work on it for just 10 minutes—will make it harder for your brain to forget or dismiss it. If you find yourself daydreaming instead of getting started, set a timer for 10 minutes and do something (anything!) during that time. Once you start, the big, scary project will turn into an unfinished task—meaning your brain will latch onto it and figure out how to get it done.

2. Use a Daily Focus List

Write down your major priorities at the beginning of each day. This is a great way to block out annoying distractions and periodically refocus your attention. A daily focus list—a short, bulleted outline of three major and three secondary priorities— isn’t a “to-do list” but a grounding tool that keeps your head out of the clouds and focuses on what’s really important.

CHAPTER 6: INHIBITION/SELF-RESTRAINT: MANAGING IMPULSIVITY & DISTRACTIONS

3. Create a “Parking Lot”

Racing thoughts and hyperactive imaginations mean that ADHD brains are easily thrown off course by passing thoughts about dry cleaning or returning Aunt Linda’s phone call. Deal with sidetracking thoughts—and the anxiety they can create—with a “parking lot,” an easily accessible place to dump unneeded thoughts until a more appropriate time. The parking lot could be a notebook, the notes app on your phone, or a sticky note stuck to your desk.

4. Identify Your Triggers

When the ADHD brain gets stressed, it jumps into fight or flight mode. This looks like a lack of motivation: You abandon your piles of laundry or half-done taxes and binge-watch Netflix. Break this cycle by identifying the triggers that cause you to feel overwhelmed. For some, it’s hunger; for others, it’s too many conflicting priorities. Getting a handle on the causes of your overwhelm won’t be enough to deter it every time, but you’ll be better equipped to anticipate its arrival and plan accordingly.

5. Go with Your Flow—Not Just the Flow

ADHD comes with plenty of superpowers (like hyperfocus), but you can’t always predict when they’ll kick in. Respect your brain! Recognizing when you’re “in the zone”—and able to tackle tasks that require attention and focus—is as important as recognizing when your brain is foggy. When you’re totally out of it, give yourself permission to shift your attention to a less demanding task, like filing papers or folding socks. You’ll get more done in the long run.

6. Look for Positive Distractions

“Distraction” need not be a dirty word. Certain diversions can help you get more done in the long run. Take, for instance, exercise: Stepping away from a project to go for a walk might seem like avoidance, but physical activity actually boosts the brain and can help you operate more efficiently when you return. Seek out the positive distractions that work for you; good examples include meditation, a quick dance break, or a creative art project. If you’re nervous about getting lost in your distraction, set a timer—and stick to it.

7. Forget Perfection

Hyperfocus isn’t always a force for good. Sometimes, it leads people with ADHD to obsess over small, unimportant details—and kill their real productivity in the process. Work on letting go of perfectionism and settling for “good enough.” This is a journey, not a destination.

CHAPTER 6: INHIBITION/SELF-RESTRAINT: MANAGING IMPULSIVITY & DISTRACTIONS

So, don't expect your perfectionist tendencies to disappear overnight—but you can expect to reduce your anxiety, build your self-esteem, and improve your productivity along the way.

8. Buddy Up

Recruit an accountability partner—someone you talk to daily, weekly, or monthly—to help you prioritize goals, chart progress, and celebrate successes. Accountability builds focus—and, in the long run, creates change—because everyone (particularly someone with ADHD) thrives on being able to say, “Yep, I did it.” A partner—whether it's an ADHD coach, a close friend, or even your mom—can help get you where you want to go.

9. Set Aside Planning Time

Lack of planning is one of the biggest focus drains; staying in the zone is hard when you don't know exactly what you're supposed to be doing! Even one minute of planning can save you as much as 40 minutes of work, so it's important that you schedule regular, short planning sessions to sketch out priorities and deadlines for the upcoming days or weeks. Of course, nothing is set in stone—priorities can shift, and emergencies can arise. But having even a general sense of your goals and a plan for how to achieve them—even if you get thrown off course—works wonders for retrieving your focus from La-La Land.

10. Find Clarity

The greater your clarity, the easier it is to stay focused and get things done. If you're having trouble paying attention to a project, ask yourself these questions to expose the root of the problem:

- What do you want to achieve?
- Whose expectations are driving this project—your own or someone else's?
- Do you understand what you need to do?

Getting a handle on your expectations will make it easier to ignore distractions and maintain a positive mindset.

11. Set Deadlines

Ever wonder why you do everything at the last minute? It's because deadlines are actually neurologically useful to the ADHD brain—they eliminate competing priorities and boost

CHAPTER 6: INHIBITION/SELF-RESTRAINT: MANAGING IMPULSIVITY & DISTRACTIONS

adrenaline, making it easier to dive into hyperfocus and crack down on a task. However, not every task comes with a clear deadline, so you need to create your own. These could be deadlines for each phase of a project, e.g., “On Tuesday at 4 p.m., I’ll pick up the paint supplies from the hardware store,” or for the project itself, e.g., “The bathroom needs to be painted by February 1.” Post your deadlines prominently and set frequent reminders to increase your likelihood of following through.

12. Acknowledge—Then Dismiss—Negative Thoughts

Rumination is the enemy of focus. Repeatedly dwelling on, say, a recent argument with your spouse can block out other important thoughts, making it nearly impossible to get anything done. Trying to block out negative thoughts entirely, however, usually backfires. Instead, acknowledge your natural thought patterns, and plan when you can give them the attention they deserve. Tell yourself, “Yes, the argument last night upset me, and my feelings right now are valid” to help you manage strong emotions and circular thought patterns—without letting them hold back your focus.

This article was written by Susan Lasky, BCC, SCAC, a productivity/ADHD coach and professional organizer.

“The Willpower Workout: Five Ways to Stop Impulses and Distractions”

By Avery Walsh, ET/P

Our world is filled with endless opportunities for immediate gratification—instant messages, one-click purchases, streaming services available 24/7, and so on.

For ADHD brains with weak executive functioning, modern life sabotages our attempts to control impulsivity and distractions. Over time, this constant battle against short-term temptations depletes our willpower and weakens our ability to prioritize long-term goals.

For us, the willpower to resist distractions comes down to habit. With practice and repetition, you can boost your willpower, little by little, every day. Here's how.

How to Increase Willpower:

1. Notice urges when they arise. The emotions behind an urge can tell us a lot. What might you be avoiding when you suddenly pick up your phone to check TikTok or grab a handful of chips from the pantry? Work? Stress? Conflict?

While it may sound counterintuitive, one of the most effective tools for increasing willpower is simply “sitting” with a feeling or urge. When it hits, stop and take a moment to “be” with the feeling. With a long, slow breath, breathe in the strong emotion, and then blow it out—as if it were a mist or stream of bubbles floating away.

2. Practice waiting. When you find yourself drifting from a planned activity, stop and ask: Is this action intentional or impulsive? Is watching this YouTube video a plan I made in advance, or am I suddenly streaming out of boredom, sadness, or avoidance?

The act of intentionally waiting is a wonderful brain-builder. Set a time limit before jumping into an unscheduled, impulsive activity. Give yourself 30 minutes before streaming that new Netflix show or 24 hours before making an online purchase. Often, you'll notice that the act of waiting, even just for a few minutes, makes an activity less appealing and exciting.

Like sitting with an urge, pausing before giving in to an impulse may seem downright impossible. Start with just one or two small impulses a day, especially those that hit you most frequently. With practice, you'll improve your ability to delay intentionally.

3. Bring a focused activity into your daily routine. The possibilities are endless here. Any activity or hobby that “arrests the attention and satisfies the soul,” as the late philosopher and psychologist William James put it, will do. This can be focused breathwork or meditation, knitting or needlepoint, drawing or painting, model building or baking, or even running. This practice helps train the brain to remain centered and calm in daily life. (If it requires you to put your phone away, all the better.)

4. Reward yourself for not giving in to distractions. Plan your treat: “When I finish doing a task I put off, I can [insert favorite activity here].” Then do it. Each time you follow through on an intentional act and resist impulses along the way, you build new brain circuitry, strengthening those good habits while eliminating poor ones.

5. Make peace with your impulses. For many people with ADHD, fighting off distractions and impulses will be a lifelong battle—even with practice. Mentally beating yourself up over them will only add to the emotions and triggers that drive bad habits. So, treat yourself with kindness, empathy, and even a little humor when your willpower is tested.

When you’re about to mindlessly check your phone for the hundredth time, stop and say something humorous, like, “You’ve got nothing better to do, Ms. Phone Checker? Really?” Have a gentle laugh at yourself. Remember that you’re but one person in a world full of fellow phone checkers—and we’re all trying our best to break the habit.

Avery Walsh, ET/P, is a certified educational therapist, learning specialist, and ADHD coach.

“I Never Shut Up. Exercise and Therapy Helped with That.”

By Jessie Daugherty Nichols

I talk too much.

For as long as I can remember, the urge to express and connect has been constant, for better or worse. On the plus side, my gift of gab makes me incredibly transparent. People don't often have to wonder what I'm thinking, and I've never been accused of being duplicitous or inauthentic.

Being hypervertal has other benefits, too. From the moment my kids were born, I talked to them incessantly, seizing every opportunity to impart my personal musings on various topics of interest—photosynthesis and the water cycle; the earth and space; the genius of the Coen Brothers; the history of feminism; the Civil Rights movement; the Trail of Tears; Frodo and the Ring, and the merits of Beck as an artist—in exhaustive detail. They could both speak in complete sentences before age one and now that they're big kids, we all overcommunicate.

More often, though, my excessive talking gets me into trouble. Like most people with ADHD, I struggle with emotional regulation and impulse control, which, for me, frequently manifests in unfiltered verbal output. This can make me seem friendly and approachable (I am), but it can also be off-putting and make conversations terribly awkward. I tend to overshare personal information or express fleeting thoughts and emotions without considering how they might be perceived. Because I care tremendously about other people's feelings (empath, here), I experience deep regret following many social interactions, especially when I realize I've been insensitive to another person's perspective or said something I don't truly mean.

Once, at the end of a key long-term relationship in my young life, a former romantic partner told me I had “no tact at all,” and although it was a bit of an overstatement, I had to admit that he wasn't entirely wrong. The advent of social media made this personal shortcoming even more problematic; I had an immediate public forum for my impulsive speech, and despite the occasional frantic deleting of regretful posts on my part, there are some who have severed their connections with me as a result. This kind of reaction from others—real or perceived, digital or in-person—exacerbated another defining ADHD trait for me: rejection sensitive dysphoria.

Hypervertal to Hyperactive: Linking Excessive Talking to ADHD

I started therapy, at last, when I realized my untreated ADHD was kind of ruining my life. My thoughtful and astute therapist introduced me to the idea that hyperactivity can be mental as well as physical, and he told me that I had been misdiagnosed with inattentive ADHD as a young adult. He noted that, in fact, I experience the hyperactive component of ADHD in the form of overwhelmingly chaotic thought and speech.

After a few sessions, my therapist told me I have “the most glaringly obvious case of combined ADHD” he has ever seen and suggested that I channel some of my hyperactivity into daily exercise.

Exercise and Therapy: Outlets for Chaotic Chatter

As a former high school athlete and lifelong lover of most sports and the outdoors, I didn’t consider myself a complete stranger to regular exercise. But between poor time management (thanks again, ADHD), the demands of parenting, plain old anxiety, and a colorful variety of unhealthy coping mechanisms, I had unknowingly slipped into some sedentary habits. I didn’t realize how much I was missing a physical outlet. As I began to rediscover the peace and mental clarity that exercise had to offer, I also learned just how much it improved my ADHD symptoms.

After some laps in the pool, a bike ride along a greenway, a few strength training sets, or even a simple power walk around the neighborhood, I find that my working memory is better. I also have a greater capacity for emotional regulation and impulse control, allowing me to navigate social situations and other challenges more effectively.

In addition to routine exercise, therapy itself has been extremely effective in curbing my impulsive speech. My therapist is a caring, compassionate, unbiased professional who provides a safe environment where I can dump out my racing thoughts, examine them, piece together the fragments, store those of sense and value, and leave the rest behind. Through cognitive behavioral therapy, I realized that the negative behaviors I had developed over time were an absolute drain on the finite amount of energy I possess for interaction and self-regulation.

From practicing mindfulness and spending time in nature to writing and even getting eight hours of sleep at night, I have found a way to replenish the energy that daily life—work, household chores, investing in my kids, listening to my spouse, transitioning between tasks, problem-solving, decision-making, and yes, filtering my thoughts during social interactions—requires of me. When I feel low-energy, I try to fall back on one of the strategies that have been helping to charge my batteries.

There are still moments when I feel overwhelmed, overstimulated, or socially anxious. I sometimes feel like I might spontaneously combust if I don’t say something to break the tension. I would be lying if I said I never wonder why I’m still talking as I babble semi-coherently about some inane thing or another. I would also be lying if I said I didn’t go home after a social event just to overanalyze every unchecked word I uttered to someone. Still, I’m learning to manage my impulses more regularly, one conversation at a time.

Jessie Daugherty Nichols is a former Language Arts teacher turned freelance writer who is learning to manage her ADHD and anxiety, one therapy session at a time.

“Am I Talking Too Much?” How I’m Teaching My ADHD Brain to Listen

By Les Steed

People with ADHD tend to talk—a lot. We talk because we’re excited or nervous or because we just want to be a part of the conversation. Sometimes we talk simply to fill the silence because silence is hard for us. When filling these gaps, reciprocating interest or signaling excitement, I tend to talk about myself—and it’s one of my most frustrating ADHD traits. (I also write about myself, but that’s not nearly as annoying.)

I don’t think I’m more interesting than anyone else nor would I describe myself as a narcissist. However, I am told, “You always make it about you.” The people saying this aren’t adversaries; they’re often my best mates or loved ones. And, to be fair, I sort of do.

Why do I always turn the conversation back to me?

The reason is usually one of these two: I’m seeking advice or assurance because I’m troubled by an emotional or traumatic event, or I relate to a story that another person shares, and I want to share a similar experience or relevant information with them—and it jumps out.

These habits become more prevalent depending on my level of emotional involvement, blood-alcohol level, or general excitement for the person and/or topic. If I’m not careful, I can get sucked into a talk tunnel, where I jump topics like a live wire—overriding or dismissing or drowning out my conversation partner’s contributions. Eventually, that person (and sometimes other people privy to the conversation) look at me awkwardly, and my bubble bursts. They may write me off as a bad listener or, worse, someone who doesn’t care. But I absolutely do care! I want to hear the rest of their story!

As an extrovert, I fill the room and like to make people laugh, and two pints down, I’m on a roll, ready to entertain. But by the end of my show, it feels like people sometimes are tired of me.

There’s rarely a pay-off to this behavior. I’m not forming or solidifying deep friendships. Would you trust your deep secrets or build a deep emotional connection with the guy telling outlandish (but most true) stories at high volume in the center of the party?

Learning to Become an Active Listener

I actually find the quietest people most interesting because they just sit, listen, and learn from someone else (without interruption). They meditate on the other person’s thoughts and feelings before responding. In doing so, they provide a safe space, where judgements are considered and welcomed.

I discovered from a friend that this is called “active listening.” She explained that active listeners listen for one minute or two, then ask for more detail, and use the word “you” instead of jumping to “I.” A revelation!

Since then, I’ve been working on active listening and curbing my propensity to talk too much. I created some goals that you may like to try.

Talk Too Much? Try These Tips

- **Imagine you are a ghost at a séance.** Your stories and opinions do not matter unless you’re summoned by the person talking.
- **Count to three after someone finishes speaking** to ensure they’re done talking. Then ask how they feel and/or what they think about the conversation topic, even (and especially) if you have five similar stories bursting in your head.
- **Deliver your stories as if you’re sending a voice note**—keep it short and no longer than five minutes. Otherwise, no one will be listening by the end.
- **Don’t analyze their points based on what you think** but get the analysis from them later if you want. Most people just want to hear their opinions validated. However, this doesn’t mean doggedly agreeing with them.
- **Think of the conversation like a game of catch.** When you are asked a direct question, it’s as if a ball is thrown at you. Wait a second, keep eye contact while you think of a response, and then throw the ball back with your own question.
- **Stop and ask someone to repeat the question** if you get lost in your thoughts,
- **Slow your drinking pace** to two-thirds of theirs, if the conversation is going well. It’s cheaper, and you’re less likely to say something you’ll regret.
- **Don’t talk to new people about anything controversial** or risqué.
- **People don’t want to know that you have ADHD** or, frankly, any of your medical issues unless it’s relevant to the conversation.
- You don’t have to be funny to be engaging. Finally, **don’t make excuses for who you are** or for going off on a tangent. It’s also okay to be a bit rough around the edges—the best people are.
- Last, but not least: **Avoid boring situations**—and people—whenever possible.

The following *ADDitude* experts and authors contributed to this chapter: Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D.; Mareen Dennis, LPP; Susan Lasky, BCC, SCAC; Caroline Maguire, M.Ed., ACCG, PCC; Janice Rodden; Roland Rotz, Ph.D.; Les Steed; Ari Tuckman, Psy.D.; Avery Walsh, ET/P; and Sarah D. Wright, A.C.T.

CHAPTER 7

Self-Awareness: Recognizing—and Embracing—ADHD Differences

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Why ADHD Self-Awareness Is the Key to Effective Action, Change, and Progress for Each of Us

Unlock real power and productivity by working to accept who you are, how you think, and what makes your ADHD brain hum.

ADHD brains engage too much in magical thinking.

We want things to be different and hope change will happen automatically without sustained effort. Or we battle our ADHD brains, denying and fighting a lifetime of truths about how we do and do not function well. Or we think about something so much that we convince ourselves we actually did it. Knowing what to do is not doing it. Moving from knowing to doing is at the heart of the ADHD challenge.

So what unlocks real change and progress? Recognizing (not resisting) our ADHD differences—and embracing our true selves. The more we understand ourselves (self-awareness) and appreciate the way we are (self-acceptance), the easier it is to maximize our strengths and create workarounds where needed (the power of possibility and choice!).

Our ability to strategize and take effective action depends on understanding and working with the way we think. Change is a process, and the more we understand the process, the easier it is. Here are a few ways you can start the process.

ADHD Self-Awareness Begins with Honesty

Self-awareness starts with taking an inventory of your strengths and challenges: who you are and aren't, what you are likely to do or not, and how you work versus how you wish you worked. Without self-awareness, you risk building a life or taking actions that won't work for you. When you know who you are and how you function (or not), you can develop strategies

CHAPTER 7: SELF-AWARENESS: RECOGNIZING—AND EMBRACING—ADHD DIFFERENCES

to boost your strengths and compensate for your ADHD challenges. When you are aware of your frustration triggers, you can take steps to minimize them. When you understand what recharges your energy, you can commit time to it on your schedule.

Angie was frustrated because she had trouble fitting exercise into her workweek. She decided to begin each day by going to the gym. It was a great idea, but it wasn't sustainable for someone who struggled to get up and arrived at work late several times a week. So she signed up for an after-work exercise class, which she often missed because she was exhausted by her job. A more realistic alternative was a midday yoga class. It got her out of the office, and she became more focused and energized in the afternoon. She went to yoga with coworkers, so it was a social event, making it easier to stick with the commitment.

Practice ADHD Self-Acceptance

You may not like everything about yourself, but when you accept who you are, how you think, and how you do things, you are more likely to get things done.

Create a judgment-free zone and let go of how think you 'should' be. You are a unique combination of personality, history, IQ, genetics, birth order, talents, environment—it's all you. When we accept ourselves, we are less likely to react and better able to act. Break out of the guilt trap of self-criticism. Guilt keeps us stuck in a web of failure and regret instead of allowing us to move forward.

Recognize That You Always Have a Choice

Accepting our challenges doesn't mean we can't change things. Let go of the victim mentality! Our problems may be compounded by biology, history, environment, experiences, or other people, but we can choose how we respond to any situation. Instead of focusing on what we can't do, look toward what we can. Maybe you'll have to work around a problem, but that's where the ADHD brain excels.

Trust Your Ability to Do Things Differently

Are there beliefs that limit you? Are you realistic in assessing a situation or your abilities? Do a reality check. Don't trust your first impulse to react. Our brains like drama. To us, it's all or nothing, black or white, perfect or useless.

CHAPTER 7: SELF-AWARENESS: RECOGNIZING—AND EMBRACING—ADHD DIFFERENCES

Give Your Brain a Roadmap

Believe that you have the power to change your life and make your goals specific. Working on too many goals simultaneously makes it less likely that you'll accomplish any of them. You can't catch two rabbits at once—even if you take pride in your multitasking ability.

Aaron was frustrated by his attempts to “master time.” He had changed his sleep and wake patterns and was proud of sticking to a schedule designed to maximize his productivity. It worked for a while, but he burned out. Why? He tried to embrace behaviors that didn't work with his ADHD brain. He explored more doable alternatives for accomplishing the things he wanted to change (such as “white space” in his daily schedule for downtime or unplanned tasks). He slowly shifted his sleep/wake cycle and acclimated to the changes. His brain had time to internalize these new behaviors. Less was definitely more!

Strategize for Success!

Change happens when strategies are clear and realistic, objectives are specific, and goals are achievable. Instead of Aaron's “I am going to master time,” start with “I will leave the house by 8:15 each morning and arrive at work relaxed and on time.”

The better you know yourself, the easier it is to develop ADHD-friendly strategies that work with your brain. Think of each task as needing two sets of strategies. The first is to assemble the tools, tips, and techniques to accomplish the task, and the second is to motivate yourself to complete it.

Take Action

Consider what might be getting in the way of your action (e.g., external events or internal concerns, such as negative self-talk, avoidance, doubt, lack of energy, or conviction). Be prepared with counter-strategies, and always be kind to yourself. The more you know and understand your ADHD brain, the better prepared you'll be to get things done.

This article was written by Susan Lasky, BCC, SCAC.

“Has ADHD Warped Your Sense of Self? It’s Time to Reclaim Your Story—and Power.”

By Alise Conner, Ph.D.

A defining feature of ADHD is its early onset—and the criticisms, punishments, and frustrations that also begin at a very young age.

Yes, ADHD is a constellation of inattentive, hyperactive, and impulsive symptoms accompanied by academic, professional, social, and other life impairments. But perhaps most importantly, ADHD is a web of deeply rooted memories and stories. These memories hold a long history that informs our perceptions of ourselves and our capabilities. They are hard to shake and may warp our self-esteem and understanding of who we are.

How Our Sense of Self Takes Hold

Ask anyone with ADHD, and they will recount all the times they were told—indirectly or directly—that they were stupid, flakey, spacey, unreliable, unbearable, overly sensitive, a troublemaker, or something of the sort.

I still remember when my elementary school teacher said in front of the entire class that my statement was a “non-sequitur.” I also remember scoring “far below my potential” on my exams.

My report cards in middle school noted that I often “daydreamed,” had a “poor attention span,” “forgot my books,” performed “erratically,” and “lacked motivation.” At the time, I was puzzled. How could my good intentions have led to such poor outcomes?

Experiences and memories like these seamlessly blend into our beliefs about ourselves; they form a central part of our self-identity at a young age. Shame, inadequacy, doubt, and failure—common themes in the narratives of adults with ADHD—are consequences of these labels. Oddly enough, these labels appear just as we are also learning that we are creative, spontaneous, fun, dynamic, perceptive, and so on. But it’s the critical messages that take hold.

ADHD symptoms continue to press into these early self-esteem wounds as we age. We mature into adults navigating ADHD’s emotional outbursts and sensitivity without the self-confidence to believe we have the positives and strengths needed to endure.

The Consequences of Being Misunderstood

Individuals with ADHD will also tell you that those early labels didn’t feel accurate.

Underneath all the criticism was a core experience of being misunderstood. “I know I’m smart, but I made so many errors and couldn’t concentrate while reading.” “I know I’m a good friend, and I care about people. I just forgot to text back or showed up late.”

Being repeatedly misunderstood causes people with ADHD to misunderstand themselves. Feeling deficient and mistrusting yourself from an early age makes it extraordinarily difficult to evaluate yourself properly as an adult.

There is a continual internal vacillation. “Am I smart? I know I am. A lot of evidence shows that I am. But what about all those times I wasn’t? Yeah, maybe I’m really not smart.”

And a persistent layer of doubt. “I can do this. I’m gonna go for my goal. But what if I mess it up? I probably will mess it up somehow.”

People with ADHD are also skilled at rewriting the plot line to those old memories. Take the pandemic: Millions of people lost their jobs because of it. For many, it was an obvious and concrete explanation for the job loss. For someone with ADHD, even a global pandemic can’t stand up to a lifetime of feeling inadequate. It doesn’t take long for a new story about the job loss to creep in—“I couldn’t cut it. I just didn’t do my work well enough.”

Wavering and misunderstandings can prevent us from taking risks or simply trying something new. It interferes with others knowing and understanding us. It’s exhausting. When I wrote this, I rode a tsunami wave of excitement, confidence, uncertainty, and fear about whether I am worthy or capable of being a published author (even though I am already a published author). I almost gave up before finishing it.

How to Heal & Develop a Sense of Self

Being misunderstood has many self-defeating consequences. So, what can we do about it?

1. Build an Initial Awareness of Your Habits

You can’t change what you don’t acknowledge. It’s critical to recognize your unique and specific experiences—the ones that left you feeling misunderstood and caused you to misunderstand yourself—and how those manifest in the present.

- What are your early memories and stories of being inattentive, hyperactive, impulsive, or otherwise ADHD?
- What are the stories you tell yourself about the messages you received?
- When do you notice self-criticism, doubt, inadequacy, or fear of failure popping up?
- What do you tend to do when these occur (e.g., avoidance or overworking)?

To get these answers, practice self-monitoring without any judgement or interpretation, and pay close attention to yourself throughout the day. Listen to the self-talk in your head. What emotions, physical sensations or behaviors do you notice? Write your observations down in your phone or journal.

Through self-awareness and monitoring, you'll notice those seemingly automated thoughts, feelings, and behaviors that influence your self-perception. Recognizing these negative tendencies can lead you to intervene before they weigh you down.

Remember, your self-criticism and doubt mimic those early memories of when you were misinterpreted. That doesn't make them true. Step back, and don't go down the rabbit hole. Perhaps even say, "You're not evaluating yourself properly."

Take an Inventory of Your Strengths

What have you been told (directly and indirectly) that you're good at? Where do you thrive? ADHD likely endows you with some of the very best parts of yourself—and what others like most about you. What are those qualities? Ask your friends, family members, partner, coworkers, or other important people in your life what they see you do well.

It's critical that you recognize and believe in your strengths. If you can only list your strengths without deeply believing them to be true, then stop at this step and work on this.

Reframe Memories & Stories

Revise the stories you tell yourself in a more kind and empowering light. Events can't be rewritten, but how we interpret or make meaning from them can.

For example, someone who often got into trouble growing up might say, "I've always been a problem," or "I let people down." One way to revise could be, "As a kid with hyperactive ADHD in a traditional school environment and without proper treatment, I wasn't understood. I was punished a lot, but I'm not a problem. ADHD makes it harder for me to control my impulses compared to other people, but everyone makes mistakes. That doesn't mean there is something wrong with me. On the flip side, that part of me helps me be an out-of-the-box thinker!"

Share your ADHD-related stories and experiences with others you trust. Talk about how those early memories made you feel and how they shaped how you view yourself in the present. Without awareness and understanding, the people in your life will be severely limited in their ability to encourage, support, or simply understand why you might think, feel, or act a certain way.

Practice Self-Compassion

To be misunderstood and to misunderstand yourself is a common and completely understandable part of ADHD; you are not alone. How could you not develop self-doubt when you learned to mistrust yourself at a young age? Be kind to yourself and avoid engaging in self-blame or frustration. Try saying, “Huh. That is so interesting. I’m doing that thing again where I fill my head with doubts. It makes sense that it happens.”

Build a foundation of wellness, balance, and competence in your life to boost the presence of stable thoughts, emotions, and behaviors. The following is a list of suggestions—start slowly and attend to the areas that would help you most. Focus on one strategy per week or at whatever pace is realistic and manageable for you to be successful. Most importantly, be gentle and gracious with yourself as you work to make changes in your life.

- **Engage in activities you enjoy** (e.g., writing poetry, hiking, fixing or playing a guitar, solving a puzzle, playing a sport, etc.).
- **Maintain a sleep schedule.** Go to sleep and get out of bed at the same time each day. ADHD can make sleeping more difficult but aim for 7-9 hours per night. Integrate additional sleep hygiene techniques (e.g., a comfortable bedroom environment; relaxing or tiring pre-bed routine; avoiding the phone, computer, and other screens before bedtime).
- **Eat regularly** and sufficiently.
- **Take prescribed medications.** What works for one person might not work well for another—collaborate with your doctor to find the best plan for you.
- **Minimize or eliminate alcohol**, caffeine, and other drugs.
- **Connect with people** and/or animals.
- **Practice mindfulness** (e.g., meditation, yoga, breathwork, walks in nature, etc.).
- **Integrate movement or exercise** in ways that are possible for you.
- **Consider meeting with a therapist or coach**, especially if you have life difficulties or would like to overcome barriers to your potential.

Above all, know that you always were and always will be so much more than the areas where you struggle. Your true and expansive story is waiting to be told.

Alise Conner, Ph.D., is a licensed clinical and sports psychologist with more than 15 years of experience in the mental health field.

6 Secrets to Goal Setting with ADHD

By Lara Honos-Webb, Ph.D.

ADHD has no “cure”—nor should it. Managing ADHD is not about fitting in or calming down; it is about standing out—identifying your competitive advantages and developing strengths into skills to help you achieve personal goals.

Over the 15 years of treating adults with ADHD, I have identified six interventions that empower people with attention deficit to make progress in their lives with—not in spite of—ADHD.

Skill #1: Name Your Strengths

Many individuals with ADHD suffer from low self-esteem and poor self-concept—often due to years of negative messaging about their abilities compared to individuals without ADHD. These negative beliefs can sabotage your quality of life and contribute to the development of mood disorders, anxiety, and other complex psychiatric issues over time.

For all these reasons, cultivating the skill of identifying your strengths—or “finding your gifts,” as I like to say—is powerful and essential to well-being.

To get you started, here are five ADHD gifts I’ve repeatedly observed and noted:

- **Creativity.** A study published in *Personality and Individual Differences* suggests that individuals with ADHD are better at divergent thinking than their neurotypical counterparts.
- **Empathy.** People with ADHD know that life’s biggest struggles are sometimes invisible to others, and their care can increase positive social connections.
- **Emotional sensitivity.** Intense emotions can help us see parts of the world that need to be fixed, as this intensity can make people more sensitive to life and, therefore, motivated to repair the world. Their passion can become a source of motivation for unleashing focused attention and action.
- **Nature smart**—The ADHD brain blossoms in green outdoor settings, according to research published in the *American Journal of Public Health*.
- **Exuberance**—Another way to think of hyperactivity

How to Find Your Strengths

Have a conversation with yourself. Ask yourself these revealing questions:

- How did you succeed this week?
- What are the three biggest successes in your life?
- When did you feel most appreciated?
- What are five things that interest you?

Take a strengths inventory/assessment.

- **CliftonStrengths** (www.gallup.com/cliftonstrengths/en/252137/home.aspx) categorizes answers into 34 themes and four domains
- **Values in Action Inventory of Strengths (VIA-IS)** (<https://www.viacharacter.org/researchers/assessments/via-is>) is a free assessment. Values identified include creativity, bravery, teamwork, leadership, and hope.

Skill #2: Set Meaningful Goals

Life is but a series of personal goals—daily or long-term, big or small. Goals span education and personal enrichment, health and fitness, interpersonal relationships, career, hobbies, bucket list activities, and much more.

Setting and achieving goals increases our well-being—a fact supported by research in the *European Journal of Personality*. But ADHD symptoms like poor working memory, inattention, disorganization, and overall executive dysfunction often derail efforts to set personal goals—and obtain results.

Knowing how to set reasonable, attainable goals is an important skill that helps narrow down what you really want and, eventually, the means to get there.

How to Set Goals

- Write out the goal.
- Write out the purpose of the goal. Understanding the “why” is especially important to increase motivation in individuals with ADHD.
- Write out one action step. What’s one small task you can do today that would bring you closer to your goal?

Goal setting is closely tied to this next skill...

Skill #3: Chunk Up Your Action Plan

Chunking refers to breaking down goal-related steps into small, doable tasks. A common problem with setting goals is the overwhelm that follows. Unsure how to proceed due to problems with planning, organization, and motivation, individuals with ADHD often resort to procrastination or procrastivity, which contributes to frustration, exhaustion, and stagnation.

Chunking is the most powerful and immediately useful skill I teach to my clients. We develop this skill through self-talk, or coaching our way through a task, with the following messages and reminders:

- What's the smallest amount of time I can dedicate to this goal now?
- I don't have to hit a home run—a single or a double will do.
- Walk, don't run.
- If I spend just X minutes on this, I can enjoy the rest of my time, guilt-free.

Practice self-talk often, and you may find yourself steadily shifting from avoidance toward meeting your goals.

With this skill, give yourself permission to break down tasks to “low-effort” levels with which you're comfortable. That might mean simply “previewing” a goal and laying it out on a schedule.

Skill #4: Strategize Your Self-Motivation

Motivation is a formidable challenge for many individuals with ADHD, and it is partly explained by the brain's dopamine deficiency. This neurochemistry makes it especially difficult to get started on and complete tasks that aren't inherently interesting, even with chunking.

We can develop this muscle through self-talk and motivational interviewing, a treatment developed by psychologists William Richard Miller, Ph.D., and Stephen Rollnick, Ph.D. Here are four reliable strategies for boosting motivation:

- **Develop discrepancy** between procrastination and what you really want for yourself. Distance yourself from avoidance to align more closely with your goal.
- **Build task-specific confidence.** Remind yourself of past successes to support self-efficacy.
- **Roll with resistance.** Don't rely on “feeling good” about a task to do it. Repeat phrases like, “It's up to me. I'm the one in charge” to move through a task despite discomfort.

- **Express self-compassion.** Rather than bully and beat yourself up throughout a task, show some empathy toward yourself and your efforts. It's a powerful way to shift motivation.

Use these phrases and questions in your motivation self-talk routine:

- "I can do hard things."
- "I will review my goal list to remind myself how important this is and that my time is limited."
- "Every time I say, 'I don't feel like it,' I postpone my goal-getting."
- "How good will I feel when this is done?"

Skill #5: Actively Manage Your Mood

Managing your mood actually means managing your outlook, behaviors, and actions. Emotional dysregulation is a core component of ADHD, so emotional control is a vital skill that requires extra focus and work.

Psychotherapy and medications can help with mood management, but these simple, daily exercises also go a long way:

- **Build your emotional vocabulary.** Research shows that high emotional granularity, or the ability to express an emotional experience precisely, is linked to better coping and mood regulation. Take a few minutes each day to learn or revisit words that better describe your feelings. Rather than 'sad,' you may find that you are 'despondent' or 'low-spirited.' Accurately labeling your emotions can also work to shift perspective, particularly for a negative feeling.
- **Turn the channel.** When you're feeling stuck, think of your past accomplishments and episodes of perseverance as if you were flipping through T.V. channels. It'll remind you of your capabilities and give you hope.
- **"Flexible Thinking Now!"** is a call to try another perspective on an emotion. Think: What would an observer say about your situation? What would your future self say?
- **Take a broader perspective.** Focus on resources that can help you solve a problem, like asking for help.

Skill #6: Power Change Through Healthy Habits

We tend to undervalue the power of lifestyle choices and healthy habits to increase our ability to focus, pay attention, and achieve our goals. The areas with the highest return on investment include:

- **Sleep** (Individuals with ADHD are prone to experiencing more sleep problems compared to people without ADHD.)
- **Stress management**
- **Exercise**
- **Time in nature**
- **Naps, breaks, focus doses** (e.g., Pomodoro technique)

Devote consistent attention to these six skills, and you'll be better equipped to achieve your personal goals for the future.

Lara Honos-Webb, Ph.D., is the author of The Gift of ADHD and The Gift of Adult ADD. The content for this article was derived, in part, from her ADDitude webinar, "Six Super Skills to Build Executive Functioning in Adults with ADHD."

“Perfect Is a Myth”—and Other Self-Esteem Boosters

By Ari Tuckman, Psy.D.,

In case you haven’t noticed, none of us is perfect. But adults with ADHD struggle more than most in getting through life—and their self-esteem may take a beating for it.

What if you could turn those negative emotions around and feel good about yourself? You can find small ways to raise your self-esteem while accepting your imperfections.

Before Jenny was diagnosed with ADHD, she was hard on herself for being unreliable and forgetful. When she understood how ADHD contributed to those shortcomings, she learned some strategies to overcome them.

Writing down appointments on a large poster board that she hung in her kitchen helped her remember get-togethers with friends. As Jenny started arriving on time for dates, she began to see herself as punctual and on top of things—even if she still forgot to pick up the occasional item at the supermarket.

Feeling good about yourself starts by treating ADHD with the help of professionals who understand the complexities of the condition. It ends with building skills to help you achieve little victories over daily challenges and regain confidence. These tips will help you do that:

1. Choose Your Battles

To use a baseball analogy, the best way to improve your odds of getting a hit is to be smarter about the conditions under which you swing. There’s wisdom in knowing when to walk away from a losing battle.

Sarah, a mother of two, with ADHD, decided not to volunteer in her children’s classrooms this year because she knew she was too busy to do a good job. Without this large time commitment, she could successfully meet other demands in her life—her part-time job, meal planning, laundry, etc.—rather than fail at all of them.

2. Just Get It Done

Holding yourself to very high standards tends to bring short bursts of enthusiasm, followed by long bouts of avoidance. Completing a project is often better than trying to perfect a late one. You don’t get partial credit for “almost done.”

Ron kept pushing deadlines, requesting just “a little more time” to put the finishing touches on his reports. After a heart-to-heart with his boss, he realized his tardiness affected his coworkers’ productivity, and his perfect but late reports weren’t appreciated by management. Ron learned to accept doing a good, rather than a perfect, job. He now gets along better with his coworkers and just received a raise.

3. Do It Now

People with ADHD often get pulled off into something else or simply forget. Doing this over time can take a toll on their self-esteem. When you have something you need to do, address it right then, or create a reminder so you’ll be sure to come back to it later.

When Tom started jotting down tasks on a small erasable board in his cubicle, he met deadlines and, in some cases, finished ahead of time. That earned him kudos from his boss. More importantly, it changed how he thought about himself at work and home.

4. Expect Difficulties

Those with ADHD wrongly assume that everything comes easily to others. Some tasks may indeed be a cinch for people without ADHD, but that doesn’t mean they don’t struggle. Like everyone else, you will have setbacks and failures. Use them as an excuse to keep trying.

Cassie was a poor money manager until she decided to leave her credit cards at home and use only cash for purchases. She overspent at times and had to resort to the ATM, but she quickly got back on track after she did. What’s more, her cash-only strategy gave her extra money to spend on dinners—and the confidence that she could put money away for the future.

5. Don’t Compare

When you’re feeling down on yourself, it’s easy to think of others as superhuman. For example, my friend Kevin exercises more regularly than I do, and my friend Bill is better at woodworking than I am. But I know more about woodworking than Kevin, and I work out more than Bill.

In the end, we are not so different from each other. You are more aware of your own shortcomings than those of others. Keep that in mind the next time you start to be too hard on yourself.

Positive Self-Talk to Feed Productivity & Tenacity

Repeating positive mantras and encouraging sentiments in times of stress positively impacts performance—and self-esteem.

Research among athletes and students has shown that positive self-talk improves performance in several ways. In fact, just uttering the three words “I am excited” in a high-pressure situation relieves stress, improves self-confidence, and leads to better performance, according to research from Harvard Business School.

Why does this matter? This research suggests that, with a few positive mantras and some mindful positivity, you can effectively become your very own ADHD coach. The trick: Learn the specific types of self-talk that can persuade and motivate. Positive self-talk will crystallize your focus, help you refocus when distractions yank you off-course, help you see things strategically, and ultimately, help you make better decisions. Here’s how to get started.

Why Do People with ADHD Need Positive Self-Talk?

Normal thought patterns reinforce existing beliefs. And as adults with ADHD, we are the products of a lot of negative programming. By the time we’re 18 years old, we’ve been told “no” about 148,000 times. We were told 148,000 times, “No, you can’t do that,” “No, you are wrong,” “No, that’s not for you,” and so on. This contrasts sharply with the few times we were told “Yes, by all means, you can do that.”

According to behavioral researcher Shad Helmstetter, Ph.D., author of *What to Say When You Talk to Yourself*, up to 77% of our thoughts are negative and counterproductive. So, the biggest reason we need self-talk, not more internal dialogue, is to deprogram the negative thoughts that hold us back. “Why does this always happen to me?” “I’ll never quit smoking.” “No matter what I do, I can’t lose weight.” “I’m never gonna be able to do this job well.” If you can get in the habit of catching yourself in these negative loops, you can use self-talk to reverse them.

Saying, “I gotta start this project soon,” or “Hmm, what if I did it this way instead of that way?” may help you get things done, but it’s inner dialogue—not self-talk, which is more focused on coaching.

CHAPTER 7: SELF-AWARENESS: RECOGNIZING—AND EMBRACING—ADHD DIFFERENCES

Where Can I Try Positive Self-Talk In My Life?

Think of how you can apply self-talk to things like:

- **Breaking through the wall of procrastination.** Self-talk can expose the irrational reasons you're avoiding the task.
- **Focusing on tasks.** Self-talk can help you resist distractions.
- **Recovering** from major setbacks.
- **Creatively problem-solving** rather than feeling stuck and powerless.

Anywhere there's a gap between your current performance and your potential, self-talk can make a big difference.

This article was written by Alan P. Brown.

“Life on Mars: Why Peopling Is a Mystery to Me”

By Elizabeth Broadbent

I have ADHD, and I worry.

Like 25% to 40% of people with ADHD, I have an anxiety disorder. This isn't a coincidence. People with ADHD are “consistently inconsistent,” and we never know when our symptoms will manifest. And so we worry. For some of us, that worry becomes a chronic condition. For others, that worry isn't a disorder, but it surfaces regularly. For most of us, it seems, our worry is inextricably tied to social situations—and it's been that way since childhood.

Peopling sucks. I am not good at peopling. Many of us with ADHD, even those who are labeled extroverts, are not good at peopling. We are good at pretending to people effectively, then coming home and collapsing with the mental effort of pretending to people effectively.

My anxiety disorder is probably (mostly) social. At some point in their lives, 12% of adults will experience social anxiety disorder. Symptoms of this include a fear of conversations with people other than your immediate family or very close social circle; trouble making and keeping friends (oh yeah); an intense fear that people are judging you (you are judging me *right now*); feeling very self-conscious around people and in front of them (I will not walk to the mailbox without eyeliner); and experiencing panic attacks triggered by social situations.

We're always scared we'll mess up socially. And, well, a lot of us do. Regularly.

Social Executive Functions and ADHD

Real talk: People with ADHD already have difficulty with executive functioning. This difficulty hinders our emotional control. We have trouble with working memory and with metacognition, or self-awareness. All these things help smooth social interactions. They tell us when to start talking and when to shut up. They tell us how much a person is interested in something and when to change topics; they tell us when to stop sharing details about our personal lives. They tell us when someone actually likes us and when they really don't. They tell us what to say, how to say it, and when to say it.

Maybe, like me, you find all these things a complete and total mystery, and you wonder if this is why you have very few real friends. Maybe, also like me, you find social interactions totally draining (even if people claim you're an extrovert). And maybe sometimes you also suddenly find yourself talking—and no one's listening. People look at you weird, but you have no idea why. If you could just put your finger on that why, it seems like you could solve everything.

That why, of course, is ADHD. Beyond that, everything gets murky.

Growing Up ADHD

A person doesn't suddenly and magically develop ADHD. An adult with ADHD has always had ADHD. Their working memory has never been the same as a neurotypical person's. They've always struggled with emotional control and metacognition. They've always been prone to impulsivity and maybe hyperactivity. The ingredients that make social interaction difficult have been around since childhood.

And children can be mean little goblins.

Many of us probably grew up as that kid, and you know exactly which kid I mean. You were the “spacey” kid who talked too much or the loud kid who wouldn't stop getting into trouble. Throw in rejection sensitive dysphoria—“the tendency to personalize ambiguous social interactions, interpret them negatively,” then find it impossible to regulate the ensuing emotions, which often leads to children with ADHD facing criticism for being “overly sensitive”—and you have a Perfect Storm for bullying. Of course, every kid with ADHD isn't bullied. But we do face social ostracism more often than neurotypical children, especially when we miss common social cues.

Guess when people learn the basics of proper social interaction—things like conversational turn-taking, oversharing, topic-changing, and the proper way to answer someone who's unhappy? They learn these things during childhood, and they usually learn them through interactions with other children. When your interactions with other kids are severely lacking because other children run away from you on the playground, you never learn to fix your broken social skills.

Like me, you walk through life baffled. You're constantly wondering, “What did I do?” Or “Why did I say the wrong thing?” I recently realized that when a neurotypical person tells you about something that happened to them, you should not reply with a bridge sentence like, “That's so awesome!” and then tell an anecdote about yourself that relates to their story in an attempt to connect. Neurotypical people think this is very rude. You should instead validate their story with words like, “Wow, that's awesome! Tell me more!” A response that, to us, means, “I understand you, here's how,” they read as “I am selfish and trying to take over this conversation.”

I don't want to tell you how old I was when I learned that. Most children pick it up before high school.

Peopling Is Not Getting Easier

We were awkward children, and we grow into awkward adults. No wonder we have social anxiety. We are anxious about social situations because we are not good at social situations. They leave us confused and hurt. We start talking, and people talk over us. We don't know when to talk. We don't know how much to talk. It's mentally exhausting, and even if we manage it, we want to collapse into a gooey puddle afterward. I come

home and hide in my enormous Vans hoodie, watch David Bowie videos, and pretend I don't have to leave the house ever again.

I'm not handing out a magic solution. Believe me, if I had it, I would. But if you're that adult with ADHD who can't people properly, you're not alone. I know how much it hurts. I know it has hurt for a very, very long time, and you've never known what, exactly, you were doing wrong. Reading some essays about it can help—though some of these relate to autism, they can still cue you into neurotypical social behavior. I finally looked my therapist in the eye and said, “My ADHD hurts my interactions with other people, and I'm sick of it. Can you help teach me how people expect me to act?”

I don't want to be neurotypical. I like myself the way I am, thanks. But in some social situations? Faking neurotypical would save me a lot of stress, exhaustion, and anxiety. And maybe, after parties, I wouldn't curl up in a giant hoodie and watch “Starman” 'til I fall asleep.

“To My Kids: A Love Letter from Your Scatterbrained, Unpredictable, Truly Lucky Mom”

By Susie B. Cross

I have some neurotypical mom friends, and frankly, I don't get them.

They have dedicated junk drawers filled with a couple of errant paper clips and their coupon folios; I have junk closets, stuffed with unfinished craft projects, Happy Meal toys, and detritus from the early 2000s.

Those mythological moms seemingly float through life with their clothes right-side-out, and they never so much as drop a cracker out of their pants during yoga class. Yes, they are a mystery. But other moms with ADHD? I get them, and they get me.

We are smart, savvy, and resourceful—just out-of-sync with the neurotypical crowd. Like so many other moms with ADHD, I bump and rattle through life, and my mothering style doesn't quite qualify as mainstream, but I'm no less (or more) a parent.

I Am a Default Chauffeur Driver (and Not Very Good)

Of course, my kids are routinely late for school. How am I supposed to know where my car keys are *every single day*?! But I also may deliver them pathologically early—because I get overly anxious about them never being on time. Those patient-as-Job boys also arrive at unanticipated times to unanticipated places. A 3.5-hour trip to Chicago can easily stretch into a 6-hour trek, past Grandma's house and up to Wisconsin. No rhyme, no reason. It just happens.

Dinner Is a Crapshoot

My mom always put a hot, food-pyramid-compliant dinner (for nine of us) on the table by 5:30 p.m. sharp. In my house, the food groups get tossed out in favor of tepid plates of whatever sludge I can dig up. The dinner window spans from about 4:30 p.m. until 9ish—and things get even more interesting if I zone out and forget that providing an evening meal is part of my job description. We call those “scrounge” nights, where every man, woman, and child is on their own.

I'm Not My Kids' Personal Secretary; They're Mine

I can't remember many things—and my boys know that. (Simple verbal reminders lose effectiveness when I daydream about beach rocks or cage fighting or how good fabric softener smells.) My boys tape permission slips to the light fixture above the kitchen table, and they always check their lunchboxes before walking out the door—to ensure I have not packed them a can of condensed soup or my wallet.

Again. I've trained them well.

After so many years of kicking myself, I am somewhat at peace with my ADHD-inspired foibles and peccadillos. After all, I have had this brain for 55 years, and it's not going anywhere. My boys, though? They haven't had a half-century to become acquainted with my mental meanderings. I'm sure they compare my brand of ADHD mothering to that of other moms—the ones who don't forget to pick up their kids at the end of their first day at a brand-new school.

I know these near-men have learned a few things by having me as their mom. I pray they understand (or grow to understand) that nurturing and loving are not in the details. My executive functions may fall short, but I exceed at keeping it real, adding a little unpredictable spice to every day, and giving bear hugs. Equally as important, I hope they realize what took me so many years to grasp: Every brain is different, and a scattered one is just as lovely as any other.

Susie B. Cross is an ADDitude contributor and blogger.

The following *ADDitude* experts and authors contributed to this chapter: Elizabeth Broadbent; Alan P. Brown; Alise Conner, Ph.D.; Susie B. Cross; Lara Honos-Webb, Ph.D.; Susan Lasky, BCC, SCAC; and Ari Tuckman, Psy.D.

CHAPTER 7: SELF-AWARENESS: RECOGNIZING—AND EMBRACING—ADHD DIFFERENCES

Additional Resources

Books

Brain Hacks: Life-Changing Strategies to Improve Executive Functioning

by Lara Honos-Web, Ph.D.

<https://amzn.to/4ezlZrn>

Driven to Distraction: Recognizing and Coping with Attention Deficit Disorder

by Edward M. Hallowell, M.D., and John J. Ratey, M.D.

<https://amzn.to/3CZVPNg>

Taking Charge of Adult ADHD

by Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D.

<https://amzn.to/3DmEFe8>

The Mindfulness Prescription for Adult ADHD: An 8-Step Program for Strengthening Attention, Managing Emotions, and Achieving Your Goals

By Lidia Zylowska, M.D.

<https://amzn.to/3QUrjgs>

The Queen of Distraction: How Women with ADHD Can Conquer Chaos, Find Focus, and Get More Done

by Terry Matlen, MSW, ACSW

<https://amzn.to/3TOD1qZ>

Understand Your Brain, Get More Done: The ADHD Executive Functions Workbook

By Ari Tuckman, Psy.D.

<https://amzn.to/3XAUrWz>

What Does Everybody Else Know That I Don't? Social Skills Help for Adults with Attention Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder

by Michele Novotni, Ph.D.

<https://amzn.to/3TDAMad>

CHAPTER 7: SELF-AWARENESS: RECOGNIZING—AND EMBRACING—ADHD DIFFERENCES

Your Brain's Not Broken: Strategies for Navigating Your Emotions and Life with ADHD

By Tamara Rosier, Ph.D.

<https://amzn.to/3qInO1K>

Online Support Groups

ADDitude ADHD Support Group for Parents

(<https://www.facebook.com/groups/adhdparentsgroup/>)

This *ADDitude* Facebook group offers positive connections and support for parents of children with ADHD and related conditions.

The ADHD Mama (<https://www.facebook.com/theadhdmama/>)

This Facebook group has helpful and encouraging videos illustrating what it's like living with ADHD as a woman.

Organizations

- The A.D.D. Resource Center (<https://www.addrc.org/>)
- Attention Deficit Disorder Association (ADDA) (<https://add.org/>)
- Children and Adults with Attention-Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder (CHADD) (<https://chadd.org/>)
- The Centre for ADHD Awareness, Canada (<https://caddac.ca/>)

Directories

- *ADDitude's* ADHD Directory (<https://directory.additudemag.com/>)
- The ADHD Coaches Organization (ACO) (<https://acoo.memberclicks.net/>)
- The American Professional Society of ADHD and Related Disorders (APSARD) member directory (<https://apsard.org/portal/directory/>)

ADHD Expert Webinars & Podcast Episodes from *ADDitude*:

“Executive Function Strategies to Externalize Time, Memory, Motivation”

>> <http://additu.de/tuc479>

The better you understand how executive functions operate, the better you will be able to design strategies that will help you get things done more reliably. Here, Ari Tuckman, Psy.D., provides clear explanations on what executive functions are, what they aren't, and which approaches are not considered executive functioning strategies. He also discusses how to tweak your environment, choose the right tools, set up the right blockers, consider consequences, and hold onto a resilient mindset.

“Optimizing Executive Functions in Children and Adults with ADHD”

>> <http://additu.de/mcweb4d>

To succeed in school, at work, and in life itself, your executive functions need to be sharp and working well. What are ‘executive functions,’ exactly? The abilities to reason and creatively problem-solve, to exercise self-control and resist temptations, to think before you speak or act, to stay focused and concentrate, and to exercise the flexibility to see things from different perspectives and adapt to change. The good news is that executive functions can be improved at any age. In this webinar, Adele Diamond, Ph.D., FRSC, FAPA, FAPS, FSEP, provides recommendations for children and adults with ADHD who want to optimize or improve their executive functions.

“All the Feels: An ADHD Guide to Emotional Dysregulation and Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria”

>> <http://additu.de/webinar-rsd>

Among the biggest emotional challenges facing adults with ADHD is rejection sensitive dysphoria (RSD), an extreme sensitivity to criticism and judgment that seems to exist only in those diagnosed with the disorder. Here, William Dodson, M.D., LF-APA, explains why RSD may be unique to people with ADHD and how out-of-control emotions undermine relationships, self-confidence, and a strong sense of self. The good news is that there are effective treatments that address it head-on. Dr. Dodson discusses treatment options, such as go-to medications that can prevent emotional impulsivity, behavioral therapy such as CBT and DBT, and more.

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Food and nutrition, supplements, natural treatments, medication, alternative therapies

ADHD and LD at School

Learning strategies, accommodations, 504 Plans and IEPs, homework help

Weekly Round Up

The best articles of the week on ADDitudeMag.com

For Women with ADHD

Managing a family with ADHD, organization/clutter, time management, shame and emotions, more

Special Newsletters

ADHD/LD Learning Series for Educators

Realistic, effective solutions to the specific academic and behavioral challenges associated with ADHD and LD in the classroom

8-Week Parenting Class

The very best ADHD parenting strategies, one email per week

10 Weeks to Success @ School

A self-guided course for parents on academics, homework, IEPs and 504 Plans, reducing distractibility, and more

5 Weeks to Healthy New Habits

Strategies for defeating clutter, increasing productivity, strengthening relationships, and more

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additudemag.com/shop

Declutter Your Life (and Home! and Office!)

How to manage clutter when the sheer physical and emotional space consumed by our clutter becomes unmanageable.

How can we declutter our ADHD lives when we're paralyzed by our paper piles or unsure where to start? What if we are emotionally attached to objects we no longer need or become so oblivious to our surroundings that we cease to see that our homes are in disarray? When do collecting habits border on hoarding tendencies? This downloadable eBook answers those questions and more.

>> Learn more about this eBook: additu.de/declutterbook

7 Core Executive Functions in Children & Teens

Strategies for Emotional Regulation, Inhibition, Problem-Solving, Working Memory, and Motivation

It's never too late for your child to improve their executive function skills, develop independence, and build confidence. In this eBook, caregivers will learn how to employ strategies that improve emotional regulation, verbal and non-verbal working memory, self-awareness, inhibition, motivation, planning, and problem-solving skills in children with ADHD. Caregivers will be equipped with strategies to boost organization skills and homework independence. Tips for teaching self-advocacy, problem-solving, and memory exercises for forgetful kids round out this eBook.

>> Learn more about this eBook: additu.de/efebook

Emotions of ADHD

How to Understand and Manage Emotional Dysregulation, RSD, Anger & Overwhelm

We can't always stop big emotions from taking over, but we can learn to minimize the damage they cause to others and ourselves and develop emotionally healthy responses. In this 230-page eBook, adults with ADHD and caregivers will learn how to employ emotional regulation strategies for common ADHD emotions, such as rejection sensitive dysphoria (RSD), anger, stress, and overwhelm.

>> Learn more about this eBook: additu.de/emotionsebook

FREE ADDitude Downloads

19 Ways to Meet Deadlines and Get Things Done

ADHD-friendly time management tips and time assessment chart.

Stop Procrastinating!

18 strategies to get stuff done and stop hiding from your to-do list.

Never Be Late Again

How to improve your time-management skills.

The Eisenhower Matrix for Prioritization

Learn how to use this simple, effective decision-making tool.

Dopamine Menu Template

Learn how to build a dopamine menu that engages your ADHD brain.

The Ultimate Executive Function Guide

Practical, hands-on solutions to executive function challenges.

Inattentive ADHD, Explained

Inattentive ADHD is frequently misdiagnosed—or missed entirely—and the consequences can be serious.

ADHD Health & Fitness Guide

Learn which lifestyle changes—eating healthy, sleep, exercising—have the greatest impact on ADHD symptoms.

Understanding Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria

Learn how to identify and treat rejection sensitive dysphoria.

Emotional Regulation & Anger Management Scripts

Boost your emotional regulation skills with these metacognition-building scripts and questions.

73 ADHD-Friendly Ways to Organize Your Life Now

How small daily changes can lead to less clutter—and less stress.

Find these and many more free ADHD resources online at:

additudemag.com/download